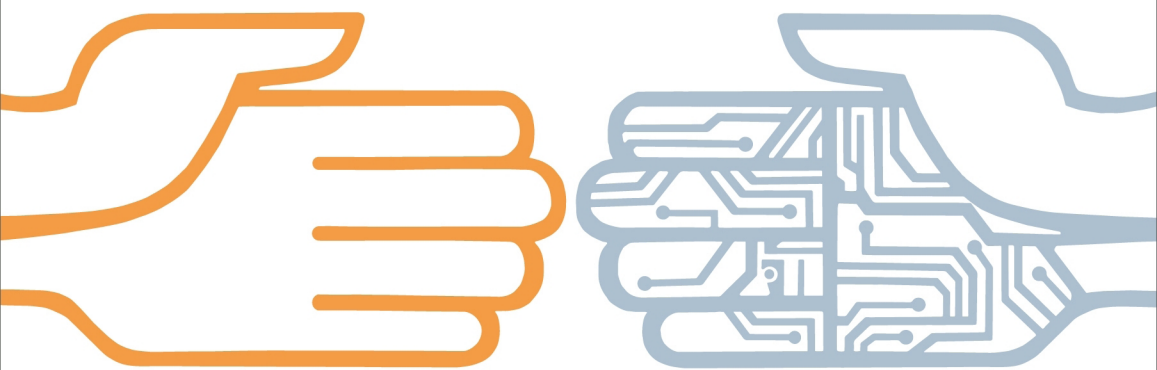
'Superb'

Rory Sutherland, Vice Chairman, Ogilvy UK

the Human experience

How to make life better for your customers and create a more successful organization



John Sills

BLOOMSBURY

'Even though Britain proudly claims to be a service economy, most transactions with business and government seem designed entirely around the convenience of the service provider, not the value to the consumer. We really do need a Copernican revolution in both government and commerce to overcome this wasteful misalignment of effort, and this revelatory book will tell you exactly where to start.'

Rory Sutherland, Vice Chairman at Ogilvy UK,
TED Global speaker and Author of *Alchemy*

'Well written, witty, keenly observed and with passion. One for humans, aren't we all?'

Tim Mason, CEO at Eagle Eye, former Deputy CEO
and CMO at Tesco

'John Sills' entertaining and convincing book contains a vital message; the best way to build and sustain a great consumer company is not to deny but to celebrate mutual trust and common humanity. Never mind making business more successful, this book could make the world a better place.'

Matthew Taylor, CEO, NHS Confederation and former CEO of the RSA

'In a world of shocks, uncertainty and measurement skewed towards the functional, this is a powerful case for thinking just as hard about how organizations make customers and colleagues feel. Here is the perfect guide to "doing the right thing" and making businesses more trusted and sustainable.'

Vernon Everitt, former Managing Director, Customers,
Communication & Technology, Transport for London

'Calling all business leaders – please read this book and restore humanity to your company's customer experience!'

Ash Schofield, Chief Executive Officer at giffgaff
and Marketing Academy Fellow

'John Sills is a master story teller, his arguments powerful from a career spent relentlessly in the pursuit of making things better for customers. An extremely funny, heart-warming, and practical guide to how we go about restoring humanity to the customer experience. Regardless of industry sector, this is one of the most relevant reads of our times, for any leader looking to do better by and for the people they serve.'

Sharon Davies, CEO of Young Enterprise

'There is no business "growth hack" greater than loving and caring for your customers. John shows you how and reminds you why.'

Lauren Currie OBE, Founder of UPFRONT

'Focusing on "what matters" to the individual and wrapping themselves around them in tackling their questions and problems has and always will be what First Direct is all about. John's book brings this philosophy to life fantastically. It's simple really – solve for what matters and good business outcomes happen.'

Chris Pitt, Chief Executive Officer at first direct

'John brings a very human touch to understanding brilliant customer experience, with fantastically vivid examples.'

Mark Evans, Managing Director, Marketing and Digital at Direct Line, Board Member of The Marketing Society and Chair of School of Marketing

'This is a great book. It should be read by anyone who cares about creating and receiving fantastic customer experiences (which is pretty much everyone).'

Owain Service, CEO at CogCo, Managing Director and Co-Founder of the UK Government's Behavioural Insights Team

'John Sills builds the case for restoring humanity to customer experience with pertinent and accessible examples. *The Human Experience* is insightful, persuasive and motivating. A must read for business leaders.'

Seán Meehan, Martin Hilti Professor of Marketing and Change Management, IMD Business School

'The most relatable, relevant and riveting book on customer experience I have come across. A must read!'

Ritchie Mehta, CEO at School of Marketing

'John has created an extraordinary collection of insights that would inspire any leader in business to look again at their customer experience with fresh eyes and see the power of the human role. It is an entertaining read with a mixture of his personal anecdotes as a consumer, against his wise insights as a world class expert. John dispels many established myths and sets out a refreshing landscape of ideas to bring the humanity back to the centre. I thoroughly recommend the book, whether for a student, or a seasoned leader.'

Joe Macleod, Author, *Ends*

'Very impressive, and really useful for those who genuinely want to ensure their customers are well served!'

Richard Sells, Former Chief Innovation Officer, Electrolux

'Challenges the negative power inherent in current marketing group think.'

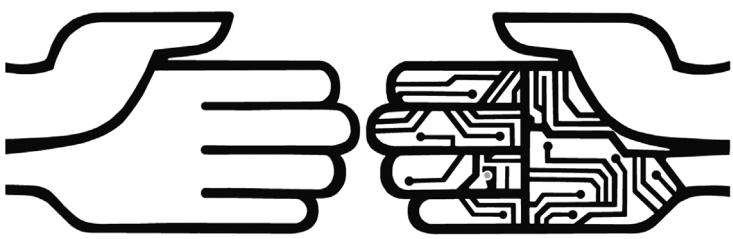
Raoul Pinnell, Chairman, MediServices Healthcare

'A critical customer experience masterpiece – challenging, important, funny and practical. If you have customers, read this book.'

Charlie Dawson, Author of *The Customer Copernicus*

the Human experience

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John Sills

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There's a great saying that you are everyone you've ever met.

I love that idea, although I did once meet an 80-year-old drunken sailor who lived on a rotting boat in Marseille harbour, so I'm not sure what part of me is him.

However, I do think it's true that you learn something from every encounter, however brief. So, this is my way of saying thank you to everyone who's helped get me to the point of writing this book (and also my safety net in case I accidentally forget to name-check someone I really should have).

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I'll leave the final word of thanks to my wonderful Nan who, when she was 101 years old, gave me her two bits of wisdom for a long and happy life, which I pass on to you now:

1) Drink whisky every day
2) Laugh at the world

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Introduction

Like most people on moving day, we were stressed. Boxes were half-packed, books were heavier than anticipated and the overly keen future owners were making regular drive-bys to see if we were gone yet. Amid all this, having a four-year-old son to entertain and keep calm was a daunting task.

But not all heroes wear capes and in this case they wore Tripps Removal Company overalls. They did exactly what we paid them to do: they took everything we owned, packed it in big boxes and placed it on a huge lorry. That's not what made the experience so special, though.

As soon as they arrived, they spotted our biggest concern and set about making our son a central part of their job. They asked him to help pack – the excitement of a 'teddy bear prison' was worryingly appealing to him – let him draw and scribble over any boxes he wanted to and gave him a tiny toy version of their big removal van to play with.

For us, it made the moving day experience far calmer than it might otherwise have been, allowing us to focus on feeling excited rather than anxious. For them, it made the process more efficient, distracting a potentially disruptive tiny person and letting them get on with the job in hand without unplanned interruption. It was a simple yet impactful human customer experience. And yet it's an experience that, sadly, we're at risk of seeing less and less of.

I started my career on a market stall in Essex, UK, and since then I've worked in and with companies around the world to make things better for customers. I've been in frontline teams delivering the experience, innovation teams designing the propositions and global teams creating the strategy. I've been a bank manager during the financial crisis (not fun), launched a mobile app to millions of people (great fun),

and regularly visit strangers' houses to ask very personal questions (incredible fun). I even signed up to be a mystery shopper when I was 21. I was a cool 21-year-old.

There are three things I've learnt throughout this time and which, hopefully, you'll learn from reading this book. The world is perfecting the functional experience at the expense of the human experience. Organizations are full of humans who are not allowed to act in a human way. Yet, the best way for companies to increase their efficiency is to make things better for customers. Oh, and I spend far, far too much time on trains.

Let's start with a character from a slightly more famous book, the Tin Man from L. Frank Baum's *The Wizard of Oz*. A well-mannered, well-functioning chap who could, with some regular oiling, make his way along The Yellow Brick Road. While the Tin Man was able to get to where he wanted to go, he was miserable. He didn't have the one thing that would have made him (and, I'd imagine, his venturing companions) truly happy – a heart. Many companies and customer experiences nowadays have something of that Tin Man feel about them: functionally fine, delivering a service seamlessly and repetitively, but desperately short of humanity, the very thing that can make a real connection with customers.

In the past few years, as a partner at independent customer-led consultancy The Foundation, I've listened to a call from a mother to her energy provider while sitting in a supermarket car park with her four children, in floods of tears because a wrongly cancelled direct debit had blocked her bank card and left no way of her buying food for the family. I've heard the story of a woman whose house move fell through at the last minute, leaving her to pay for both a mortgage and rent, with her bank refusing to help until she'd missed enough payments to trigger their 'financial support' process. I've watched open-mouthed as a customer whose son had recently died was told that the only way for an account to be closed was for their son to call up himself and

confirm the reason for closure. Conversely, when you experience real humanity – which can be delivered by a person or a pre-programmed machine – you feel the impact immediately.

It's the electrician turning off his radio when our toddler is going down for a nap. It's Octopus Energy personalizing their hold music to play the song that was No.1 when you were 14. It's Metro Bank having baby changing rooms and dog biscuits. It's Google Maps asking if you want to send feedback when you shake your phone in frustration. It's Barilla Pasta creating a Spotify playlist of songs that play for the exact time you should cook different types of pasta for. It's my financial adviser putting a stamp on any envelope that needs sending back. It's DHL letting you track your parcel on a little map, knowing you have other things to be getting on with. It's Apple auto-filling security codes that get sent to your messages to save you switching apps. It's the estate agency changing their 'For Sale' signs to 'Buy Me' and 'I'm Taken'. It's South Korean supermarkets packaging together seven bananas of different ripeness so you have the perfect one for each day of the week. It's the Swiss Federal Railways guard personally accompanying a group of passengers to a new train with a hastily reserved carriage and free tea and coffee when the original train unexpectedly broke down. It's not, however, Apple emailing you at 5 a.m. on New Year's Day to tell you your trade-in is now worth £0 rather than £300. Happy New Year – you're broke.

The impact of this loss of humanity is often worse for those customers most in need of support. If you can afford it, or are seen as 'valuable', you can get a better service. Or if you have the right network and influence, you can speak to someone who knows someone to get a problem sorted (or know the right way to circumnavigate the complaints process and be connected directly to the CEO). Sadly, many others are left to deal with online FAQs, long call-waiting times and unresolved problems. It's a microcosm of wealth and opportunity inequality played out in contact centres across countries around the world.

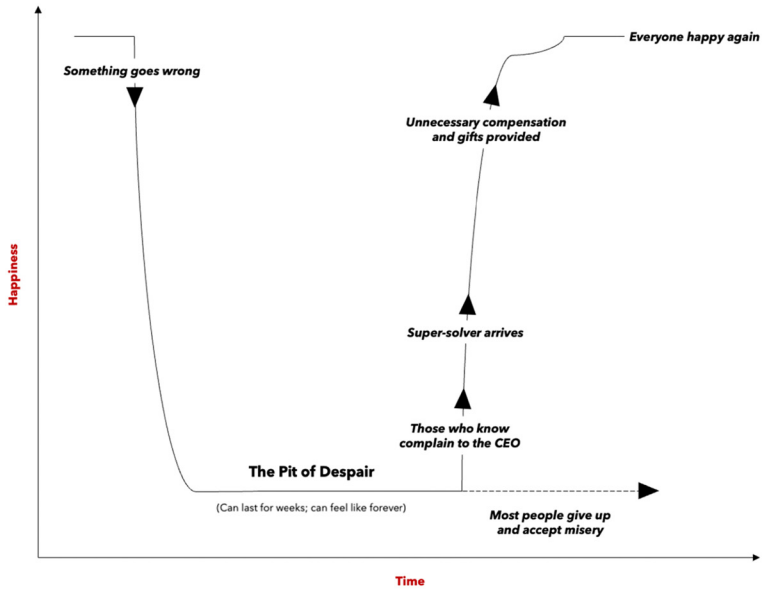


Fig 1.1 The Pit of Despair.

Ultimately, the only thing that really matters is how you make people feel. Companies should be there to help make life as easy and enjoyable as possible, not to create extra worry, stress and wasted time and energy for people who'd rather be watching Netflix, going for long walks or even spending quality time with their families. Increasingly, this humanity seems to be pushed to one side in favour of the illusion of efficiency. Yet in reality, investing time and effort in creating a human customer experience will in turn lead to a more efficient organization. Not just happier customers who'll instinctively buy and recommend more, or a stronger brand that will be more attractive to potential customers, but a reduction in costs through fewer calls, fewer surveys, fewer errors, fewer complaints and the vastly reduced attrition of employees. Therefore, in this book I'll argue that restoring humanity to customer experience – balancing the human and the functional experience – is better for both customers *and* for businesses.

We'll start, in Part One, by exploring in more depth what causes this lack of humanity and dispel three myths that get in the way – the myth of customer loyalty, the myth of customer feedback and the myth of 'return on investment' (ROI).

In Part Two, we'll be introduced to eight companies from across sectors and countries who are leading the way in providing a human customer experience and being commercially successful because of it: AO.com, Bendigo Bank, Chiltern Railways, Citymapper, NHS Blood and Transplant, Octopus Energy, Riverford and Workday. In the rest of the book, we'll then look at these organizations in more detail, understanding the behaviours and enablers that make them a human organization to deal with.

In Part Three, we'll explore the seven behaviours that each of these companies exhibit when creating their customer experience: Accessibility, Consistency, Flexibility, Proactivity, Respect, Responsibility and being Straightforward. Then in Part Four, we'll investigate the five enablers that each of these companies has to allow this human customer experience to flourish and the ways of working they commit to that make this approach commercially successful: Ambition, Connection, Empowerment, Focus and Perspective.

Throughout the book, I'll argue that adopting these behaviours and enablers will mean that customers can stop wasting their lives dealing with the stress caused by uncaring companies and start to enjoy the experience of being a customer again. And I'll argue that it will also help companies save and make money, having customers that recommend them for real (rather than just in hypothetical questionnaires) and reducing the work caused by not getting it right the first time.

Just like the Tin Man, organizations already have everything they need to be more human. They're full of brilliant humans who often just aren't allowed to act in a human way. Perhaps all that's needed is to set those people free, to act like the humans they've spent their whole lives training to be.

PART ONE

Things Can Only Get... Worse?

In which I rant about why customer experience needs to be more human and dispel three myths that get in the way.

CHAPTER ONE

The Three Myths

The difference between the past and the present of customer experience first dawned on me during a family holiday, when we took a trip on a beautiful old steam train. The journey started with a friendly guard welcoming us on board, pointing to the right carriage and making a show of punching a hole in the paper ticket that my overexcited son was holding. We settled into our seats – and what seats they were. Deep leather cushions you could fall asleep in, each with its own spacious, wood-panelled table to spread our picnic out on, next to a huge window made for daydreaming out of. A fully stocked trolley service passed through the train with freshly made food and piping hot drinks.

As the train pulled out of the station and the smoke cleared to reveal the rolling hills, it dawned on me just how different this was from my usual daily commute: an impatient queue to get through the temperamental automatic barrier, an annoyed-looking guard avoiding eye contact, a robotic announcer's voice acting like a starting gun for the well-dressed, middle-aged, suited-and-booted office workers piling onto the platform.

'The train now approaching platform one…'

On your marks…

'Is the 7.51 Great Western Railways service…'

Get set…

'To London Paddington…'

GO!

As the train arrives, the penguin shuffle begins – everyone keen to keep their place regardless of the very real risk of being jostled onto the track. The possibility of an actual seat is too important.

(Never has a button meant so much to so many and had so much power over our lives. Be the one to touch it and you get free entry, permission from the others to step through the doors unchallenged and take your pick of the remaining seats. The ultimate fastest finger first.)

We get on, entry to the train accompanied by the daily dawn chorus of '*can you move down the carriage, please?*', finding our regular spots squeezed onto the luggage rack next to the folding bikes, leaning on the door for a quick exit or sitting on the bin as a last resort (but one that is still preferable to the unstable horror of actually standing between the seats).

Headphones on, volume up… Another £50 well spent.

We can now get to more places, more quickly, and more safely than ever before. We can find an answer to any medical question with a few swipes on a screen. A face scan and string of numbers, and we can send money instantly around the world.

And yet…

Train travel used to be far more luxurious. A seat, a window, maybe even a whisky to pass the time. Now a damp cheese panini and a free cup of water feels like a treat. Staring dreamily out of the window has been replaced by staring disgustedly into someone's armpit.

Banks have stepped away from personal managers and individual assessments to algorithmic scoring and automated assistants. Money remains complex and confusing for most of us, a major source of stress in people's lives despite the nicely coloured debit cards.

The family GP, someone who took the time to know you and your body and could give you a real answer to your question, has been replaced by an overworked, dishevelled doctor, forcing us to seek medical advice from strangers online who know someone who knows someone who once had mildly similar symptoms.

While many things have become far easier to do, somehow being a customer seems harder work than ever before. Do-it-for-you brokers and travel agents have been replaced with Compare The Market and Airbnb.

Getting in touch with a company for anything out of the ordinary is often met with an automated '*You know you can do that on our website?*' retort. Long call-waiting times have become normalized and acceptable. And a 'thank you for your custom' has been replaced with the requisite feedback request, asking for a few minutes of your time – for free – to answer a series of questions on whether you'd recommend a company (regardless of whether you have, in fact, recommended them). It's no wonder that in a 2021 study by Metro Bank, over 90 per cent of Britons (including 83 per cent of 16–24-year-olds asked) think the world would be a nicer place if there were more face-to-face interactions.[1]

Oliver Burkeman discusses this contradiction of convenience in his must-read book on time and how to use it, *Four Thousand Weeks*[2]:

'Smoothness is a dubious virtue since it's often the unsmooth textures of life that make it liveable, helping nurture the relationships that are crucial for mental and physical health, and for the resilience of our communities. Your loyalty to your local taxi firm is one of those delicate social threads that, when multiplied a thousand times, bring a neighbourhood together; your interactions with the woman who runs the nearby Chinese takeaway might feel insignificant, but they help make yours the kind of area where people want to talk to one another, where tech-induced loneliness doesn't yet reign supreme. As for Apple Pay, I like a little friction when I buy something, since it marginally increases the chance that I'll resist a pointless purchase.

'Convenience, in other words, makes things easy, but without regard to whether easiness is truly the most valuable in any context. Take those services that let you design and then remotely mail a birthday card, so you never see or touch the physical item yourself. Better than nothing, perhaps. But sender and recipient both know that it's a poor substitute for

[1] https://www.metrobankonline.co.uk/about-us/press-releases/news/the-future-of-the-high-street-lies-400-years-in-the-past/

[2] Burkeman, O. (2021) *Four Thousand Weeks*. The Bodley Head.

purchasing a card in a shop, writing on it by hand and then walking to a post-box to post it because contrary to the cliché, it isn't really the thought that counts but the effort – which is to say, the inconvenience. When you render the process more convenient, you drain it of its meaning.

'The venture capitalist and Reddit co-founder Alexis Ohanian has observed that we often "don't realize something is broken until someone else shows us a better way". But the other reason we might not realise some everyday process is broken is that it isn't broken to begin with – and that the inconvenience involved, which might look like brokenness from the outside, in fact embodies something essentially human.'

To be clear, this isn't a rose-tinted view of the past, harking back to a golden age of personal service and high street shopping, and I'm certainly not advocating that all customer experience returns to an in-person interaction. New technology has created incredible improvements, throwing off the shackles of 9–5 store openings, endless queueing and limited stock availability.

When used well, the data at our fingertips is helping us make better decisions each day, whether it's showing us new things we might like to buy or helping us create new spending habits to save more for the future. It's easy to stay updated with where your parcel is and what time your plane is arriving. In many cases, when things go wrong customers can contact companies in a variety of ways all far quicker than sending a letter to the CEO (and then shame them on social media if a reply isn't forthcoming). But a sign of real progress is to be able to improve the efficiency while keeping the same level of quality, yet it seems that while new technology has created faster, more convenient customer experiences, the trade-off for many customers has been to sacrifice the pleasurable aspects to make way for the functional enhancements.

In the UK, customers are no more satisfied than they were a decade ago.[3] Only one in five believe companies put employee or customer

[3] UKCSI report, January 2020

needs ahead of those of shareholders.[4] And there's little evidence that companies have become the efficient, low-cost corporations promised by the digital dream. As we're getting rid of humans from the customer experience, we're getting rid of the humanity too.

It's the corporate equivalent of football's much-derided Video Assistant Referee (VAR) initiative. While functionally improving the accuracy of decisions throughout the game, VAR stripped away the humanity inherent in the sport. It has created progress in one sense, but, like customer experience, has done so while sacrificing some of the more pleasurable aspects of the sport.

Likewise, the accusation is that on-pitch football officials now avoid making big decisions, knowing that VAR will be there to check them instead. In organizations, rigid processes combined with a lack of empowerment cause employees to suspend their humanity and stop thinking for themselves, handing responsibility – and with it vital nuance and empathy – over to the systems around them. VAR may get more decisions correct and ensure that the success and money goes to the 'right' teams but if it ruins football as a spectacle, then fans will stop going to the matches and the beautiful game will die.

Similarly, investing in providing a high-quality human customer experience may look like a cost, but it'll also make customers more likely to stay and do more with an organization and will save companies a lot of time, effort and money in the process, too.

* * *

So far, this may all seem a bit obvious. Of course, it's common sense to treat customers as well as you can. Of course, most people in most organizations are good people trying to do the right thing. And of course, I also suspect nearly all of you reading this are humans and so know how to behave in a human way. Yet something strange often happens to people when they become part of an organization. Simply

[4] https://www.edelman.co.uk/research/2020-trust-barometer-uk-results

pulling on a suit or starting a Zoom call can act like a temporary personality transplant to those who are otherwise empathetic individuals, impacting those setting the strategy, designing the processes and delivering the experience.

As we've seen earlier, a reliance on automated processes can cause common sense to disappear – and with it goes the emotional intelligence displayed in every other part of their lives. Humans who would otherwise be treated with respect become 'customers', an ethereal entity reduced to a number or pound sign, there to be 'targeted' or 'managed'. Decisions are made that will knowingly cause stress or effort for tens of thousands of people in the name of commercial efficiency.

Throughout this book, we'll explore some of the reasons behind this phenomenon and what can be done about it. But to start with, it's worth dispelling three unhelpful myths that exist in current-day customer experience, that create the conditions for this lack of humanity to exist: The myth of customer loyalty; the myth of customer feedback; and the myth of return on investment (ROI).

CHAPTER TWO

The Myth of Customer Loyalty

I loved my local taxi firm – low prices, lots of cars and easy to book. Sure, the car was often 'just round the corner' and it was a bit annoying that I had to call if I wanted to pay by card, but overall, they were great. I used them all the time. Then Uber came along, with its one-tap ordering, cashless payment and map of where your car actually was so I switched. Immediately. Years of using the same taxi firm meant nothing to me when this new service appeared on my phone screen. That's because, for most organizations, customer loyalty is a myth.

Loyalty is a particularly personal thing, driven by association with other humans. It's a feeling that links people together under some common purpose or relationship, '*a strong feeling of support or allegiance*', as the Oxford English Dictionary puts it. It's a feeling of emotional connection, not functional transaction.

Many of these connections will be with individual people, political parties or athletic affiliations. It's (sadly) become a frequent sight at lower-league football grounds to see long-time fans collecting money to try and rescue their club from collapse – something that I don't recall seeing outside the boarded-up windows of Blockbuster. Where 'customer loyalty' does exist, it tends to be with smaller, local companies, those that are a crucial part of the community, or where the owner is personally known and regularly visible. Therefore, in a world where bigger organizations are focusing on the functional experience, 'loyalty' is really just shorthand for usefulness – or, more specifically, staying more useful than the alternatives.

The last 20 years has provided mounting evidence to this point of view, as much-loved institutions such as Woolworths, Blockbuster and

British Home Stores (BHS), as well as entire industries, have found their customers to be anything but loyal. Shiny, new, more useful alternatives appeared on the digital horizon, causing customers to sprint towards the light, only stopping to swap memories of their misspent youth in the Pick-and-Mix aisle.

This usefulness comes in many forms. For some customers, it's often a more useful price. For others, it's ease, with anything that requires leaving the sofa an insult to customer experience. It could even be status. Why do people queue for days outside the Apple Store to be the first to buy a phone they could order online and have delivered? Not always because of the useful price or the useful product, but the useful status marks them out as Someone That Buys New Apple Things As Soon As They're Available and is therefore a) rich, b) trendy and c) very much in control of their time management.

But as customer experience has become more faceless, so 'loyalty' has become more transient, with a better, more useful proposition just a tap away (and the ability to find out about that offer only needing a few more taps, or a well-worded question to Alexa). If you don't believe me, think about a company you use a lot. Now imagine they've tripled their prices or halved the quality of whatever it is you're buying. Still feeling loyal?

This mistaken belief in customer loyalty has a real-world impact on organizations. It encourages an over-weighting of focus onto acquisition and onboarding, believing that once the customer has been attained, they'll be likely to stay for good. Attention quickly shifts onto attracting the next customer, rather than keeping the existing ones happy. It also creates a laziness in design, with loyalty schemes and reward points used to artificially inflate an organization's usefulness. But these loyalty schemes are not, as their name suggests, anything to do with 'loyalty'. If they were, it's unlikely customers would have the audacity to stand in front of the cashier at Costa Coffee while removing their Starbucks, Caffè Nero and Coffee #1 cards to find the right one to stamp. (Of course, such cards are very useful tools for companies to collect behavioural data on their customers.)

This isn't a good situation for organizations to be faced with, leading to a deathly spiral of new customer offers and discounted prices alongside a proposition that is quickly copied by new entrants and incumbents alike.

The only way for organizations to get closer to genuine 'loyalty' from customers is to act in a human way, to create a personal connection, through colleagues allowed to throw off the corporate shackles and communication that shows genuine care not just regulatory compliance. Focusing on creating this emotional connection can create deep relationships, ones that outlast any bumps in the road. This will mean more customers joining off the back of genuine recommendations and word-of-mouth marketing and more customers staying as happy, contented customers.

As for my taxi company, after a few months under pressure from Uber they decided to release their own app. Instant booking, automatic card payments and a map to show exactly which corner their car was round. You could pre-book, without a penalty for cancellation, and without the need to rate or be rated by your driver. So of course, I immediately switched back again.

Relying on loyalty as an alternative to adapting and staying useful generally only has one outcome. As the poster in a window at a soon-to-be-closed Jessops store put it, '*Thank you to our loyal customers. To everyone else, thanks for shopping at Amazon.com*'. Customer loyalty is a myth. Staying useful is what matters. And if in doubt, remember that nobody cares about your business as much as you do.

CHAPTER THREE

The Myth of Customer Feedback

In February 2016, the Trinity Mirror group launched a new regional print newspaper, the *New Day*. For those of you who are familiar with the direction print journalism has been travelling in the past decade, this may have come as a bit of a surprise. Not so for Simon Fox, the Trinity Mirror CEO at the time, who was bullish during a radio interview on the day of the launch:

> *'This isn't an idea we dreamed up overnight... It comes from deep consumer insight, talking to thousands of readers…'*[5]

In May 2016, the CEO was back on the airwaves, explaining why he'd decided to close the newspaper down. The reason given is insightful in itself:

> *'At the end of the day, what consumers told us they would do, and what they actually did, were different things. We couldn't persuade enough people to try the product and make it part of their daily routine.'*[6]

You can imagine the scene that makes this misunderstanding possible: A large survey sent out followed by a focus group that takes place on a cold Tuesday evening in Manchester. Eight participants scroll through their phones and make polite small talk

[5] https://www.mirror.co.uk/news/uk-news/new-day-uks-first-new-7414916 (BBC Radio 4's *Today* programme, 22 February 2016)

[6] https://www.cityam.com/trinity-mirror-boss-new-day-newspaper-failed-because/

until a smartly dressed business type asks them to enter a stark white room with a big round table. Behind the long mirror a group of strategists have their laptops whirring while digging into the free sandwiches and crisps. The participants dutifully answer all the questions that they're paid to answer and give opinions they didn't know they have:

Q1: Would you like to have more news that's relevant to you? Yes.
Q2: Are you tired of clickbait journalism that dominates social media? Yes.
Q3: Do you miss reading printed newspapers? I remember when I was a kid…
Final Q: Would you like relevant news delivered to you every morning in a simple and digestible format? Of course!

The participants go home well fed and well paid; the strategists head to the pub buoyed by the undeniable evidence that suggests their idea is a winner. But yet, despite that, they 'couldn't persuade enough people to try the product and make it part of their daily routine'.

Why?

In an ideal world, we start the morning reading the paper while eating avocado on toast with Classic FM playing in the background and the kids dressing themselves, tidying their rooms and walking to school in virtual bubble wrap to insulate them from danger.

In an ideal world, the *New Day* is a great idea, when there's time to flick through the pages of a freshly pressed paper, sat at our breakfast bar and having an in-depth discussion about the day's headlines with our equally interested partner.

But in the real world, there are kids to dress, dogs to feed, parents to medicate, work to prepare for, washing to put on, nuisance sales calls to avoid, school parent WhatsApp group threads to gossip on, cars to put petrol in, partners to argue with about why the car is out of petrol, toothpaste to find and kids still to get dressed.

This is myth of customer feedback.

As we'll cover in more depth later, we're living in an epidemic of feedback requests, with surveys being sent for every conceivable customer interaction. As you exit the public toilets at Paddington station, there's a touchscreen – a *touchscreen* – feedback terminal asking you how satisfied you were with your visit. On Twitter, BBC News Technology Editor Zoe Kleinman shared a photo of a bin at Heathrow, which has its own '*Do you like this new bin?*' feedback button on it. A bank recently asked writer and speaker Hanna Andersen how likely she was to recommend them based on the ease of cancelling a standing order. Her reply?

> *0 – because no one in the history of the world has recommended a bank based on cancelling a standing order*

These relentless requests for customer opinions means there's never been more 'customer information' in organizations. However, most of this information starts at the thin end of the wedge, focused on the product, not the person. Companies prefer to ask questions about themselves: *What do you think of our product? Do you like our new idea? Would you recommend us to a friend?* This information gets averaged and aggregated, presenting a view of an experience that no one is really having, rather than looking at the thick end of the wedge for the inconvenient truths. At that end, you instead discover what really matters in customers' lives and how companies can be most useful within that.

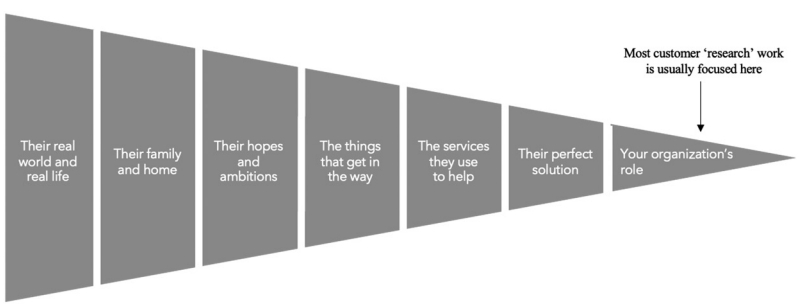


Fig 3.1 – The Customer Insight Wedge

It's a point that Stan Sthanunathan of Unilever – famed and envied for its consumer insights function – made at a Yale School of Management event in November 2020. Sharing his and their beliefs on the need to differentiate between consumer insights and people insights, he said:

> *'People are only consumers for a few hours of the day; if you don't understand how to add value to hours of their day outside of being consumers, you run the risk of creating a brand that lacks staying power.*[7]

Rarely do companies just speak to customers about them and their lives, without some kind of pre-defined script or agenda. Rarely do companies take the time to understand and uncover the deeper psychological stresses and strains impacting customers' lives. Rarely do companies listen to people's real-life experiences and behaviours, seeing them as humans instead of a sanitized and aggregated collection of thoughts based on a hypothetical situation or a specific product a company produces.

No wonder, then, that while the majority of organization executives believe they are providing a superior customer experience offline, online and on mobile, only one in three customers believes their favourite brands understand them.[8] The deluge of survey requests and data-filled dashboards is creating an illusion of connection, a comfort blanket to be wrapped around business leaders to make them feel close to their customers, whereas in reality all they're really close to is opinions on their organization from people who care enough to comment.

[7] https://som.yale.edu/blog/elevating-insights-the-power-to-shape-future
[8] ftp://ftp.software.ibm.com/software/be/pdf/Great_experience_divide.pdf

As Terry Leahy (CEO of one of Britain's largest retailers, Tesco, during their climb to the top of the grocery retail world) said while talking about how the organization used customer data:

> *'What creates loyalty is how much we understand your life and what we do about it that helps your life… If you don't have a vision as a retailer that you are doing this to understand customers better, and deepen that relationship, you're always going to wonder why you're making the effort.*[9]

Perhaps if Trinity Mirror had started at the thick end of the wedge, they could have genuinely created a new dawn for print journalism with the *New Day* – or at least saved considerable money and effort trying.

[9] Martin Haywood, 2009, Any Colour You Like, p.23

CHAPTER FOUR

The Myth of ROI

The train company that shuttles me in and out of the city wrote me a letter I'd been hoping to receive. I could finally get rid of my old paper ticket and replace it with a shiny, contactless card (we'll leave to one side for the moment that they could have emailed and, in 2020, the ticket really should have been going directly onto my phone). The smartcard arrived a few days later and I went online to load my existing season ticket onto it.

And that's where the problems started. They seemed to have decided to gamify the experience, providing a cryptic challenge involving multiple systems and screens, apparently unlockable to a Luddite like me. I asked their Twitter team for help, who suggested a visit to the local train station. They suggested a visit to one of the bigger stations, who suggested I phone the services helpdesk. They suggested the bigger station again. There were lots of mentions of 'loading' and 'validating', but not many offers of 'we'll sort that out for you'.

This experience went on for over a month, trying to set up the new card with a team of people who meant well but clearly had no idea what to do. It was pretty terrible for me as a customer, but clearly very costly for the company too: repeated failures causing increased calls and queues for them to deal with. While this was happening, I received two more letters suggesting I apply for a new smartcard.

That same month, I bought a new car (not, I should add, to avoid further train usage). A few days later, I received three letters from the company, on the same day, in three different envelopes, all giving information about slightly different parts of my contract.

Two days after that, my life insurance company contacted me and said I'd missed one tick box on the underwriting form I needed to

complete, as to whether or not I smoke. Their solution was to reprint the whole 15-page form and send it in the post for me to put one tick in one box on one page, then post back to them again.

For every one of these companies, my preference is online and email only, and has been for about 15 years.

This is where the traditional question of the 'Return on Investment of Customer Experience' is flawed. It's not simply about working out how many more products can be sold by installing a new webchat function.

Firstly, many organizations seem to forget that the ROI of a good customer experience is, well, more new customers and more current customers buying more from you (and the 'return on investment' on that is, through your business you are making people's lives better).

As the UK Customer Satisfaction Index (UKCSI) reported in 2018:[10] *'Organizations that maintain higher customer satisfaction than their sector average have achieved stronger turnover growth, profit and employee productivity than those whose customer satisfaction is below the sector average.'*

Secondly, many organizations don't connect customer experience and commercial performance in a way that shows the money that is being wasted, failing to consider the cost of inaction. This could be the waste we've seen above, or it might be having to fix the things that have gone wrong: repeat calls, avoidable errors, complaints.

Consultancy firm Vanguard call this 'Failure Demand', which shows the costs associated with not getting something right first time:

> *'Failure demand is defined as "a demand caused by a failure to do something or to do something right for the customer". Failure to do something – turn up, call back, deliver something – causes the customer to make another demand on the system.'*[11]

[10] UKCSI report, January 2020

[11] https://beyondcommandandcontrol.com/failure-demand/

Finally, organizations fail to consider the cost of opportunities lost through bad customer experience.

When I moved house, I compared energy companies. They all answered the phone quickly, seemed keen to tell me about what they could offer and made a compelling case to join them, yet none of them asked for my contact details to get in touch nearer the time of my move and help with the switching process.

I checked out the broadband providers too. In an entertaining webchat with one, they insisted it was impossible for them to send the equipment to my existing address:

Me: Hi, we're moving house and looking to get the broadband sorted so we can set it up on the day we move in. If we join you, can I set up the account and have the equipment sent to my current address, please?

Agent: No. It'll be sent to your new address.

Me: But the current owners live there.

Agent: You won't need to wait in for a delivery as our box has been designed to fit through most letterboxes!

Me: But we won't be living there. Are there any other options?

Agent: There are no other options.

Agent: Is there anything else I can help you with today?

Me: Can you help me with that problem, please?

Agent: There is no other option.

Me: There must be a way. Can you talk to someone and find out, please?

Agent: It cannot be delivered to an alternative address.

Agent: You can go to a store. They might have a router there.

Me: Can you check if they have one?

Agent: No.

Agent: You have to visit the store.

Me: Right, that's not great really.

Agent. You're welcome. Thanks for chatting with us. Have a great day!

Chat ended by agent

The big exception in my house-move debacle was Direct Line, first on my list for home insurance after impressing me with their car insurance experience. The process was quick, simple and as promised, and the agent also offered to change the address on my car insurance policy while I was on the line.

Of course, organizations should consider which improvements will make the biggest difference and invest accordingly but the decision should be less about trying to calculate a theoretical answer to how much money it will make and more about how much happier it will make your customers, how much more attractive you'll be to potential customers and how much money you'll save in wasted effort and failure demand. It's closing the gap between the marketing promise and the customer reality – a gap that could be costing companies more than the price of the posters in the first place. After all, bad customer experience is expensive to provide.

* * *

As a result of people and organizations believing in these myths, an empathetic, systematic approach to customer experience is often replaced by a functional, transactional one. If you're wondering whether your company is one of these that's falling into the trap, it's easily recognized by – among others – these six symptoms:

- Reactively fixing pain points as a customer experience strategy (rather than proactively designing for the future);
- Prioritizing customer experience effort primarily by what customers are complaining about, or what the CEO has said is important because of a single complaint they received (rather than by what will create value for customers and the business);
- Subscribing to generic frameworks suggesting that all customers want the same outcomes, such as 'personalization' or 'speed' (rather than creating design principles specific to your business – I may want my food to arrive quickly in McDonald's, but I don't in a Michelin-starred restaurant);

- Building large expensive journey maps that end in a recommendation of 'Transformation' (rather than having a laser focus on the few moments that matter most);
- Obsessing over a single number as a proxy definition of success and measuring everyone in the organization against it (rather than creating a balanced scorecard based around earning customer decisions in your favour);
- Pestering customers for feedback and focusing on averages, not actuals (rather than using the information you already have available to you and focusing on the experiences at the edges).

Instead of loyalty, organizations need to focus on usefulness. Instead of feedback surveys, on genuine understanding. Instead of ROI, on the cost of inaction. However, while that's easy to say, it's hard to do so let's find out who's doing it well.

PART TWO

Trailblazing on Behalf of Customers

In which I reveal the companies who are delivering a human experience, from which others can beg, borrow, and steal.

CHAPTER FIVE

Behaviours and enablers

So, what to do about all of this? How can we combine the best of the functional advancements of the past 20 years with the emotional, human touch that means so much to so many?

In some ways the answer is quite simple. It's to be human, to be conscious of the world and people around us, to use our natural creativity and to show common sense, fuelled by a desire to make things better for the people we share our planet with. However, as we've discovered, it's not so simple when organizations exist at scale.

Nearly every person I've worked with in my career has cared about customers and nearly all the companies I've worked with have known, broadly, what they needed to do to improve things. Yet somehow these intentions and ideas fail to make it to the frontline when competing against commercial priorities and organizational biases.

So, to answer the question of how to create a human experience in the twenty-first century, I stepped back to an idea from early on in my career: modelling (not *that* sort of modelling, although I did win the Clacton-on-Sea Bonny Baby contest in 1984). In short, you find someone who's demonstrating the behaviour you want to achieve, observe it, break it down, then try it yourself over and over again until you become good at it.

Eight companies stood out from across sectors and geographies who are leading the way in providing a human customer experience and being commercially successful because of it. From these, seven behaviours – how they conduct themselves with customers – and five enablers – the internal ways of working that create the right conditions – emerged. These are organizational traits that, if adopted, will lead to more human companies and better customer experiences regardless of sector or country.

The seven behaviours are:

Accessible
Consistent
Flexible
Proactive
Respectful
Responsible
Straightforward.

The five enablers are:

Ambition (to trailblaze on behalf of customers)
Connection (to what really matters to customers)
Empowerment (of colleagues to do what's right)
Focus (on the moments that matter)
Perspective (to see the bigger picture).

This isn't intended to be an exhaustive framework or a grand theory of customer experience. As mentioned in chapter four, there will be things that are important in some industries and organizations but not in others. Moreover, it's crucial for a company to decide on the distinct experience they want to deliver, based on knowing what really matters to their customers and where they have a competitive advantage in their industry.

So with that caveat in place, let me introduce you to the stars of the Showcase (with a special mention to those I would love to have featured but didn't have the space to – such as American Express, DBS, Gravity Payments, Hubspot, Moo Cards, Morrisons, Mother Raw, Patagonia, Timpson, Thames Valley Wealth, Trailfinders, UK Storage and Wordpress – and those who have had enough written about them already, such as Amazon, Disney, JetBlue, John Lewis, Pret A Manger, Southwestern Airlines and Zappos).

CHAPTER SIX

Introducing the Showcase

Note: these are just an introduction to the organizations in question; their full stories will be discussed throughout the rest of the book.

Company: AO.com

Category: Electrical Retail
Country: UK and Germany
Context: Launched in 2000 when CEO John Roberts bets his friend that he can change the way white goods are purchased via the internet. Returned to profit in 2020–21 with a 62 per cent increase in group revenues to £1.6 billion.[12]

I was introduced to John Roberts of AO.com by my business partner, Charlie Dawson. Charlie was in the middle of writing his book, *The Customer Copernicus*[13], about successful customer-led organizations, and AO.com were going to feature as a great example of one of these. John had agreed to speak at a lunch we were hosting, with around 20 leaders from other businesses invited to hear his story. He covered how AO.com had started because of a £1 bet in a pub and how they'd convinced Sainsbury's to let them be their white goods provider (again, as a result of a pub conversation). But what really stood out to me was the way John spoke about customer experience. There was no talk of Net Promoter System (NPS), journey maps or frameworks. Instead, he

[12] https://www.retail-week.com/electricals/aocom-back-in-the-black-as-covid-drives-soaring-sales-and-profits/7040145.article?authent=1
[13] Dawson, C. and Meehan, S. (2021) *The Customer Copernicus.* Routledge.

talked about mums and grans – make decisions that would make your mum proud and treat people as you would your own gran.

He told a story of a driver who, on his way to deliver a fridge, called ahead to let the owner know he was on his way. The customer's son answered the phone and mentioned it was his parents' wedding anniversary so the driver stopped en route, bought a pot plant (in AO .com branded colours) and handed it over as a gift when the surprised customer opened the door – his mum would be proud and his gran would be happy.

I spoke to John to find out more about how he's managed to build and maintain this approach over the last 20 years.

Company: Bendigo Bank

Category: Financial Services
Country: Australia
Context: Founded in 1858 to improve conditions in the Bendigo goldfields, with 1.9 million customers and named third most trusted brand in Australia.[14] First Australian bank to shun fossil fuel investments; declared carbon neutral in June 2021. Launched innovative 'Community Bank' model in the 1990s.

Having worked in banking myself, I was interested to find out more about Bendigo. It had come to my attention as a company that repeatedly appeared in lists of 'most trusted' and 'most loved' companies and seemed to be an organization of great tradition and heritage, having been set up over 150 years ago in the Australian goldfields.

While other Australian banks – particularly Commonwealth and WestPac – tended to take the headlines for digital innovation, Bendigo had something different about it. The focus on community (and within that, customers) seemed more than just marketing spin or good PR. In the 1990s, Bendigo set up a 'Community Bank' model that allowed

[14] https://www.bendigobank.com.au/media-centre/bendigo-bank-ranked-the-third-most-trusted-brand-in-australia/

customers in local areas to essentially own their own local bank, using the profits to fund local projects to benefit the community, an approach that has delivered more than $200 million worth of benefit since it started. More than that, this community focus seemed to play a major role in their approach to design, regularly gathering views from customers, community members and colleagues as to what the customer experience should look like.

Senior PR Manager Simon Disney helped to point me in the right direction to find out more about the Bendigo Bank approach and how this historic business is still creating a great customer experience over a century later.

Company: Chiltern Railways

Category: Transport
Country: UK
Context: Tripled customer growth to 29 million from 1999 to 2009.[15] 2018 customer satisfaction 92 per cent, the highest of any UK franchised train operator – and remains consistently high.[16]

Hardly a day goes by without someone coming up to me and saying: 'John, I am one of your followers on the various social networks you're on – why do you go on about Chiltern Railways so much?'

Okay, maybe not every day. Well, it's happened once. And that was my wife, who isn't even on Twitter but was staging an intervention on behalf of concerned friends.

Either way, I love Chiltern Railways.

If you're reading this outside of the UK you might not understand why this is a big thing. You might say, 'Surely all train companies are equally efficient, providing exceptional service with pin-point timing for a reasonable price?' Not quite.

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[15] https://www.chilternrailways.co.uk/news/chiltern-railways-celebrates-25th-anniversary-hybridflex-launch

[16] https://www.chilternrailways.co.uk/news/chiltern-railways-receive-92-national-rail-passenger-survey-score

In fact, as we covered in the introduction to this book, the opposite is usually true. Over-crowded, unclean trains, patrolled by militant train guards with joy in their eyes as they hand you a £57 ticket for the privilege of standing on a patch of bare carpet between the First-Class carriages.

Chiltern Railways' trains run on time. Their carriages are clean. It's easy to get a seat. They were the first UK train operator to offer onboard Wi-Fi and first to have a presence on Twitter. London Marylebone station, where the trains arrive, has a speciality cheese shop. All in all, they do what they need to do and they do it well. In other words, they get the functional stuff right. However, they've also managed to create an organizational culture that allows their people to show their human side, encourages them to care and puts them front and centre of the customer experience.

Every Christmas, they fill Marylebone station with staff members dressed as elves, giving out mince pies and offering to help people with luggage onto their trains, knowing that there will be travellers heading to family for the festivities (a clever move, as it also helps them get people on the train quicker and keep the trains running on time).

Another example is their social media team, who are genuinely social, not an automated 'sorry for the inconvenience' copy-and-paste bot. I once went to one of their 'meet-the-manager' events and afterwards tweeted:

> *'Just been to the meet the managers event for @chilternrailways to tell them how good they are – worried that makes me a train geek.'*

Their reply?

> *'Thanks! But you're right, that is rather worrying…'*

I caught up with their former Director of Customer Services, Alan Riley, to find out how they do it.

Company: Citymapper

Category: Transport
Country: Global
Context: Launched in 2011 in London. As of 2021, the company serves 50 million users across eighty cities.[17] One of the most awarded mobile apps including a regular Apple 'Editors' Choice'.

Many of the best inventions arrive because of timing, a moment when several things come together to create the perfect conditions for success. Think iTunes and the combination of internet speed, computer storage and a demand for downloading music.

In 2011, mobile phones were taking over the world and more importantly, they now had a blue dot to show you exactly where you were. Cities started sharing their data openly, realizing the benefit it could have to their citizens. London was about to host the Olympic Games and with them, millions of tourists putting strain on the world-famous public transport system. And so Citymapper was born.

I remember using it for the first time. This bright green design that stood out on an otherwise identikit iPhone. A simple, big button to get you home. The list of ways you can get to where you wanted to go – including the infamous 'Jetpack' option that told you how long it would take to fly through the sky (if you happened to have the equipment close to hand). Since then, Citymapper has taken the world by storm, rapidly expanding to cities in every corner of the globe and rapidly expanding its route options as it harnesses the power of the data available to it.

Use the app now and you get walking, taxi, cycle, scooter and carshare routes. It'll give you the quickest route, the simplest route or the cheapest route. And that's not all. As well as a step-free route, Citymapper recently earned plaudits for offering two types of walking route late at night: Main Road and Fast. While the latter gets you there quickest, the former takes you on well lit, busier roads, showing a real understanding for what matters to people walking home alone late at night.

[17] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Citymapper

It's always struck me as a company that understands what really matters to people as well as the importance of designing for humans in stressful situations, of zigging while every other app zags, so I spoke to Head of Brand, Gil Wedam, to see if that was true.

Company: NHS Blood and Transplant (NHSBT)

Category: Healthcare
Country: UK
Context: 800,000 active blood donors and many millions of registered blood donors

I first heard about the NHS Blood and Transplant (NHSBT) customer experience when starting to research this book. Director of Future Agenda Patrick Harris is always keen to share companies he thinks set the standard and emailed me to tell me why he loves them so much:

> *You have to feature NHSBT. They built an app that yes, replaces what paper, email and phone call might have done before – such as auto diary entry, donation venue and availability look up, etc.*
>
> *But the real magic is that they are very personable on the day (you are a hero as you donate), you get treated with tiny luxuries – biscuits at the end are a necessity of the task but they let you sit with others to chew over food and stories about why you donate.*
>
> *Separately, they are very human with the app that was built because besides the generic stuff it does, it shows you where your donation has gone afterwards. It's very rewarding. They make me want to go back to give more blood (in fact, I now donate plasma too) and let's be clear, that is quite an accomplishment as blood donation isn't exactly top of the list of recreational activities for most people.*

What makes NHSBT unique among the other featured companies is that their 'customers' aren't receiving any tangible benefit. There's

no product they're buying or service they're receiving, they're being asked to give up their time and take part in a potentially uncomfortable procedure, purely for the benefit of others.

In this situation, it would be incredibly easy for customers to say no, which makes their success all the more remarkable – and a lesson for others that, if you invest in a great experience, customers will keep returning to you.

I spoke to Jon Latham, who spent 12 years with NHSBT heading up Marketing, PR, and Customer Experience. His time there included being the driving force behind the famous 'Missing Types' campaign that was named PR Week's 'Campaign of the Decade'.[18]

Company: Octopus Energy

Category: Utilities
Country: UK, US, Germany
Context: Launched in 2016. Added 50,000 customers a month, now supplies energy to over 2 million homes; 92 per cent rate them as 'excellent' on Trustpilot; the only UK supplier to be recommended by consumer champion *Which?* four years in a row. Reported lowest cost to serve per customer in the UK.[19]

In June 2021, a rather odd headline appeared on the *BBC News* website:

> *'Lloyds' bank manager "sacked for helping customer" headhunted'*.[20]

The article went on to explain that bank manager Nadia Begum had lost her job after helping a visually impaired customer open his mail and pay his bills. As she hadn't declared this to Lloyds, it was deemed

[18] https://www.nhsbt.nhs.uk/news/missing-type-blood-donation-campaign-named-campaign-of-the-decade/
[19] https://www.bcg.com/en-gb/publications /2020/interview-with-octopus-energy-jon-paull-on-cutting-edge-customer-service
[20] https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/uk-england-oxfordshire-55752716; https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/uk-england-oxfordshire-53607183

a breach of their colleague code of responsibility and her contract was terminated.

How organizations react in these situations says a lot about them. Lloyds decided to sack Ms Begum. Octopus Energy, on the other hand, pulled out all the stops to hire her. CEO Greg Jackson said: *'When I heard her story, I knew immediately that we needed to hire her… Nadia's warmth and humanity was the perfect fit.'*

Little wonder, therefore, that Octopus Energy is taking the world of utilities by storm. Since starting up in 2015 to provide a tech-enabled challenge to the traditional way of doing things, Octopus has been *Which?* Recommended Provider for four years running, USwitch Supplier of the Year in 2018, 2020 and 2021, and there is a rapid global expansion underway. And it's not just customer experience they care about. As I ventured onto the Octopus website to start my research, a friendly Octopus character appeared to say, *'Hi there! Carbon emissions from electricity are currently high. This device is currently charged to over 80 per cent – you might like to unplug it for a few hours.'* So I did, and the Octopus smiled and disappeared.

I spoke to Pete Miller, co-founder and Head of Customer Experience at the company.

Company: Riverford Organic

Category: Food retail
Country: UK and France
Context: Founded in 1987 with Guy Singh-Watson, delivering 30 boxes of vegetables to friends and family in Devon. The company now delivers 80,000 boxes a week and was awarded the *Observer*'s 'Ethical Product of the Decade'. Since June 2018, it's been 77 per cent employee-owned.

It's fair to say I'm slightly obsessed with Riverford. I first became a customer over a decade ago, although I can't quite remember why. I do recall getting the first few boxes delivered though and wondering what on earth these strange vegetables were: pak choi, kohlrabi,

Jerusalem artichokes – not things we readily had when I was a child growing up in Essex.

Immediately this company had a different feel. The communication was straightforward, the language very simple. It was easy to order and no trouble to make changes. If you went on holiday, or wanted to stop your boxes, you could do so easily. No tricks or loopholes to get through. You were given the names of the people making your deliveries and given everything you needed to calm any concerns – cool bags for milk, boxes for veg, even wool-covered deliveries to keep meat orders chilled.

Inside each box, every week, was a note: a simple, A5 piece of paper with a recipe idea on one side (based on the bits in your box) and a few hundred words from the founder, Guy Singh-Watson. These notes covered everything from thoughts on farming to opinions on politics, creating a huge openness as to how the company was run. This shouldn't have been that remarkable, but I couldn't think of a single other organization whose leader had such direct and open contact with customers so regularly. They say never meet your heroes, but I was lucky enough to speak to Guy Singh-Watson to understand what makes Riverford so special and I'm happy to say he didn't disappoint.

Company: Workday

Category: Enterprise Software

Country: US, Germany, Ireland, Sweden, UK

Context: Founded in 2005 following a breakfast between the founders Aneel Bhusri and David Duffield in California. Industry leading customer satisfaction of 97 per cent.[21] Subscription revenue more than doubled to $3.79 billion between 2017 and 2021.[22] No. 10 in the World's Best Workplaces.[23]

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[21] https://blog.workday.com/en-us/2021/new-approach-same-goal-staying-dedicated-workday-customer-satisfaction.html

[22] https://www.workday.com/en-us/company/latest/newsroom/media-resources.html

[23] https://www.greatplacetowork.com/best-workplaces-international/world-s-best-workplaces/2019]

Workday first came to my attention in a conversation with Matt Watkinson, author of the brilliant book, *The Ten Principles Behind Great Customer Experiences*[24]. Matt suggested Workday as a company that might fit well in the Showcase, a company that manages to find the balance between being a predominantly digital product and creating a human customer experience.

As soon as I started researching them, I could see he was right.

Business to Business companies are often missed out of conversations about customer experience, with the focus usually being on individual consumers rather than organizational customers. However, all organizations are just collections of people and if anything, creating a great experience for companies can positively impact many more people in a much shorter period.

Workday's story is one of massive growth, which makes it all the more impressive that they've managed to maintain their customer focus. What stood out for me was their committed approach to collaboration, staying close to what really matters to their customers in an industry that can often leave the company and customer quite detached from each other, which means the relationship becomes quite transactional. Instead, Workday have deep partnerships with customers, both in terms of their design and delivery for the experience and empowering their colleagues to share improvement ideas. These two traits meant they were able to react quickly during the COVID pandemic in 2020, understanding the pressures their customers were under, then pivoting their offer appropriately in response.

Head of Customer Experience Emily McEvilly gave a series of interviews during the pandemic that revealed a lot about Workday's approach to customer experience.

[24] Watkinson, M. (2012) *The Ten Principles Behind Great Customer Experiences*. FT Press.

PART THREE

The Seven Behaviours

In which I give a few suggestions as to what a human customer experience looks like.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Accessible

*'If you do need to ring us, someone will pick up the phone and they'll know what they're talking about and they'll have the authority to make things better. People make it out to be expensive but it's not as expensive as people think. You ring them up and get ten options then three more options, then put your account number in, then you get through and get told "we're too busy to answer" and you just think "F*ck off"! It's so disrespectful to customers.'*

Riverford Organic

Being accessible means:

- easy to get in touch with;
- responsive when a customer contacts you;
- having visible leadership and transparent ways of working.

Imagine meeting someone who said they were really into you, but as soon as you started dating them became hard to get in touch with. You had their social media details, but you could only use that to see what they were up to, not to contact them. They'd email you, but you couldn't email back. You had their phone number, but they never answered. Apparently, they'd been taken by surprise by how many of their other friends also wanted to talk to them. After a while, you weren't even allowed to talk to them directly, with someone else acting as a gatekeeper to decide if what you wanted to talk about

was important enough for them to bother with. I suspect in this situation most people would break up with this person very quickly yet this faintly ridiculous scenario is played out every day between organizations and customers.

An organizational arrogance has appeared, with customers viewed as an annoyance, leading to the creation of escape-room-esque experiences if they have a problem and need to talk to someone. (The game starts by trying to discover the hidden 'Contact Us' details, requires skilful avoidance of the chatbot guard, then needs the secret phone menu code to be cracked, with any failure being met with the devastating '*you can use our website for this!*' line, immediately terminating the call and sending you back to the start.) No-reply email addresses, withheld numbers, chatbots, long call waiting times and social media used for marketing not conversing. Executives who are visible for investors and shareholders but out of reach for customers.

It ends up creating physical and mental effort for these customers, who begin to feel like an unwanted stalker. Phoning, emailing, WhatsApping, emailing again, then Googling the name and Twitter handle of the CEO to try and find any way of getting a response from the organization you need help from.

Tom Goodwin, author of *Digital Darwinism*, summed up the irony of this situation in a tweet in January 2020:[25]

> *Brands: 'Consumers want conversations with brands'*
>
> *Also Brands: 'We live in an always on, 24/7 constantly connected fast times'*
>
> *Also Brands: 'Please allow up to 28 days for a reply to your email' (sent from 'Donotreply@company.com')*

[25] https://twitter.com/tomfgoodwin/status/1216821920525627392

The best organizations do the opposite: they're easy to get in touch with, happy to speak to their (paying) customers. They respond quickly, acknowledging the contact even if it might take longer to sort out the problem, reducing uncertainty for the customers. And they're open about their business, what they're trying to achieve, and who's making the decisions that impact your relationship with them.

Let's look at some examples of (in)accessibility in action.

Do Not Reply
(Or the importance of it being easy for customers to get in touch)

It was time to say goodbye to the old fridge. I logged on to the council website, found the Bulky Waste Collection page, booked a slot and paid my £50. So far, so easy.

The confirmation arrived (addressed to 'Councillor John Sills' – part of my mini rebellion against having to select a meaningless title – a decision I would later come to regret). It was from a 'NoReply@' email address, with an extra line in bold to make sure I'd really understood this was a one-way thing:

> *'This is an automated email. Please DO NOT reply'.*

I thought this was rather unnecessary as I had no intention of entering a long two-way email exchange with the local Bulky Waste team. All that changed a few days later when I found out our road was going to be closed for repair on the day of collection.

I went back to the email: no reply possible. So I went on the website: no obvious way of changing the booking. I looked at the small print:

> '*Your booking cannot be changed once your request has been submitted'.*

So, to the phones. A 30-minute wait then a promise of a call back that never arrived.

Collection day came and went. The fridge remained at the end of the driveway (causing a few tuts and eyebrow-raises from neighbours concerned that I'm affecting their house prices). I then tweeted about it and pretty soon the Bulky Waste social media team responded. I got a call from someone very apologetic that this incident was happening to a local councillor (ahem) and a promise to get it sorted. She followed up with an email and, a few days later, the fridge disappeared.

For them, several calls and messages, a pointless journey, a second collection, a call back and a few different colleagues involved. For me, about two hours of my life wasted on a fridge when I could have been wasting it watching TikTok. And all because I couldn't reply to an email.

It's worth pausing to reflect on this. From a customer's perspective, I'm wasting time trying to do something that should be quite simple. More than that, I'm trying to stop their collection team making a pointless journey, only for them to have to repeat it when they realize they can't get down the road.

I'm trying to save *them* time and money.

But it's not just email where this lack of accessibility – and increased cost to the business – is apparent. It's increasingly hard to actually speak to someone.

I had a quick question about my car insurance, so picked up the phone (with my headphones in for greater multi-tasking potential). The first three menu options I chose all resulted in an automated *'you can do this on our website!'* message followed by a prompt hang-up. The fourth finally got through to someone, whose first reply was, *'You know this information is in your policy document?'* I reminded him that normal people don't carry their policy booklet around with them on a daily basis.

A 30-second query ended up in a 10-minute mission and an exasperated customer, all because the company really didn't want to talk to me. Surely it would have been better just to answer the phone?

A friend of mine who runs her own business had a more extreme version of this issue when having problems with a small company she relied on. Frustrated, she emailed the CEO, asking to set up a call with someone:

> *'I'd like to have a conversation with a human being. To do this I've had to ask your team, send you a message on social media and then email you. Please can we just speak?'*

His emailed reply?

> *'What's the issue?'*

No hello. No sorry. No acknowledgement of the request.

After a bit of back and forth and a flat refusal to speak on the phone, my friend gave in and emailed a long list of issues.

The CEO's replies to a couple of the issues tell their own story:

> *Issue 4. There's no way to make clear what the VAT is*
> *CEO: I'm not following your feedback here*
> *Issue 7. The receipt you send isn't clear it's a receipt as it's not written in the subject line*
> *CEO: I'm not following your feedback here*

My friend's reply back to him tells its own story, too:

> *That's because you've chosen to make me email you about complex, nuanced things. This is why a conversation is the best way to communicate.*

On a spreadsheet, the phone call was more costly than email. In reality, a five-minute conversation would have saved a lot of time and typing, a lot of confusion and been a far better experience overall.

Challenging the Chatbots (Or the importance of making machines more of a help than a hindrance)

Think back to the worst customer experience you've had recently, the most comical, the one you put on Twitter to get a few quick likes. Chances are, it involved a chatbot, one of those friendly, well-meaning automated assistants that pop up on websites when you need some help.

Chatbots are seen as the solution to the problem above, the reason why we don't need to email or call the companies we rely on. An AI army recruited as a first line of defence, a complicated level-up boss to be defeated before customers are allowed to speak to someone who can actually help. While functionally brilliant when you have a simple question, their lack of nuance and empathy can cause wasted time and frustration for the customer (not to mention the dawning realization that they're locked in a war of words with a piece of code, their sarcasm and CEO-letter-writing threats wasted on a bot with no appreciation for the rules of customer experience combat).

Take my COVID-inspired conversation with the easyJet chatbot, in an attempt to get a refund on a cancelled flight:

'Hi, my flight was cancelled two weeks ago and it says "refund being processed" but it's been like that for two weeks.'

'Sorry, I don't understand what that means. Try telling me a different way.'

'When should I expect my refund?'

'Sorry, I don't understand what that means. Try telling me a different way.'

'Refund?'

'I'm sorry, I'm still learning and unfortunately I don't know what you want just yet. Please try again soon!'

Around the same time, I had a similar experience with a shed company:

'Hi there! Just ask me a question like "What colours are available?"'
'Can I build this shed on a gravel patio?'
'I think you're asking me about international, is that correct?'
'No.'

Or this conversation with a delivery company bot, showing the risks are greater when things are misinterpreted, rather than misunderstood:

'Hi, I just received an email from you about my delivery. I've been at home all day but your email said "Oh no, we missed you".'
'Nice to know you care.'
'Excuse me? Are you a real person or a bot?'
'Well, I must have really impressed you if you think I'm real, but no, I'm a virtual being.'
'I want to speak to a real person.'

Even more risky is trying to make the chatbot *too* human, creating awkward conversations that are perfect for Twitter but less good for getting done what you want to get done, like this one sent to me by UX Designer Claire Durrant:

'*Can someone call me, please? I have a problem with my parking charges.'*
'Please choose an option:
1. How do I get help?
2. Are you single?'
(Intrigued…) '2. Are you single?'
'Unfortunately, my heart lies with another… R2D2 will always be the one.'
'Why are you telling me about R2D2?'

'Established with a small team 20 years ago, our company is proud to be shaping the future of mobility through world-leading solutions for 16 million users!'

'I want to speak to someone about my parking charges.'

(Admittedly, this perhaps does do a good job in replicating the unwanted advances that many women regularly get online, but I'm not sure that's what we're looking to achieve here.)

These examples are part-humorous, part-frustrating. In each case there's been a real issue that needed resolving and time and effort has been wasted in dealing with a bot that couldn't help. Ultimately, the customers end up calling the company anyway, but now with more frustration and a worse perception of their businesses. While in direct comparison colleagues are more costly than chatbots, that equation fails to consider the added value human interaction brings: a problem resolved more quickly, a human side to the company, a personal touch with a greater ROI than any Facebook ad.

Humans are also more likely to look at a problem holistically, recognizing connected and complicated issues that could end up in further phone calls to the company. Compare and contrast the chatbot responses above to this one with a real EE employee:

'I'm afraid all you can do, John, is wait. I get that's super frustrating and you just want to know whether it works or not, but if after 24 hours the feature isn't added, I'll escalate it to our big-level 2 IT guys to take a deep-sea dive into what's going on. I'm so sorry I couldn't fix this for you myself.'

Or this, from Amazon:

'I may not be able to give you the universe, which is the replacement or resending the parts, but at least I could try and give you the stars – a discount on a new pack – which is an option.'

In fact, I once heard about someone in charge of LiveChat for his company who couldn't understand why he had so few messages coming through. He decided to add a welcome note on the website, saying, '*Hi, I'm James, I'm a human, not a robot*', and almost instantly the number of people using the service increased.

In their current guise, chatbots are little more than glorified gatekeepers, intelligent enough to get in the way but not yet able to resolve queries or replicate those small moments of human interaction that elevate an experience from good to great. That may come in time. For now, though, while chatbots may save companies some loose change, they're unable to respond to those unscripted human moments that require creativity and spontaneity – the moments that build long-lasting relationships.

Behind the Curtain
(Or the importance of visible leadership and transparent ways of working)

A strange thing happened in the early stages of the COVID pandemic that seemed, in part, to address the inaccessibility of many modern companies. Suddenly, our inboxes were flooded with emails from people we'd never previously heard of. Emails like this:

Hello

I'm Martin, Marissa, Dave, Denise and David, and I'm the CEO of a company you've used occasionally in the past.

I'm sorry I've not been in touch before. I thought you'd prefer to read our automated emails about our latest offers on all the things you can buy from us. In fact, it's been so hard to get hold of me that a special website has been set up – ceoemail.com – for when you've become fed up with our generic responses to your complex complaints. But now, things are different. In a situation like this, you need certainty. You need to know who I am, that my focus is solely on helping you, and the people who work for me, to get through this tough time. You need to know you can trust me and

trust us. I want you to know what we're doing to help, how our colleagues are being looked after, the safe environment we're creating and even how we're working with our competitors to get through this.

I want you to know I'm a real person, too. A person with worries, concerns, family I care about and friends I'm not seeing. I want you to know that I genuinely understand. And I want you to know it's from me. Not a team of copywriters. Not a made-up name printed on the bottom of a letter to help manage the deluge of replies. But me, a real-life human being.

Stay safe,

Signed, the CEO of every company you know

These emails demonstrated an openness that had been missing from customer relationships. The people at the top of the companies we deal with, those making the big decisions about our experience and our money, pulling back the curtain and allowing an insight into what they were doing for colleagues and for customers. And it was nice. *Really* nice. It became a crucial part of the sense of community that was forming to get through the COVID lockdowns, to help manage customers' expectations and also make direct requests, to reduce panic-buying, help elderly neighbours and respect opening hours that prioritized key workers.

Some of these emails were deeply personal too, like this one from Eytan Levit, co-founder of Mixtiles:

Hey

I write this email as a dad of two pre-teen kids, who's worried about keeping them busy at home.

As a son of two 70+-year-old parents, worrying that they'll stay safe.

As an ex-husband trying to help his ex-wife transform her fitness business to an online one.

As a people person who has been locked down for two weeks now, struggling with loneliness.

And, of course, as the founder of Mixtiles, working around the clock to make sure our products reach our customers safely and quickly.

Coronavirus sucks – it's uncharted territory for everyone, including us here at Mixtiles. And we're doing our best to make things work.

That's it. There's no real punchline to this email… All I have to offer here is just sharing my emotions with you and maybe letting you know that you're not alone.

Stay healthy, stay safe.

This commitment to openness was the primary reason for including Riverford in the Showcase (*see also* page 50). Every week – and long before the COVID pandemic deemed it necessary – founder Guy Singh-Watson writes to customers with a personal thought on food, farming, politics or sharing his own personal leadership challenges. His approach is open and honest, laying bare his beliefs, his ideas and his fears.

When asked why he'd chosen for Riverford to become employee-owned instead of selling to a venture capitalist, he famously (and passionately) replied:

'To sell it to one of those bastards, it would feel like selling one of my children into prostitution.'[26]

Similarly, during the Black Lives Matter protests of 2020, while other businesses were busy releasing well-meaning but non-committal social media posts, Guy wrote a deeply personal message to Riverford's customers:

[26] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WGkLwRpj6sM

Twice a week, I pick artichokes with my eldest daughter, Alice. Moving down the towering rows, I hear snippets of her Novara Media podcast about George Floyd's murder – and as we offload our full bags, she questions me and Riverford's response to Black Lives Matter.

I am out of my depth.

Growing up in a 99 per cent white area, however liberal your beliefs, it is hard not to absorb worn-out clichés. I struggle not to become defensive when pulled up on using the wrong language, or when I am plain wrong; without the liberalism I was raised on, defensiveness could so easily morph into the ugly resentment and alienation displayed by far-right groups.

Unbeknownst to me, our staff council discussed the issue last week. Reading the notes, I was struck by the depth, nuance and humility:

'The injustice of racism is an affront to our shared values of equality and diversity.' Broadly it was agreed that 'We should support BLM whilst actively campaigning for issues we have more specific knowledge of. We have lots to learn ourselves. In line with our values, we should look for actions as well as words, particularly in an area where we have things to learn and improvements to make. We are an overwhelming white business. We can do better.'

I don't think I can improve on that conclusion.

The question for CEOs as we come out of the pandemic is what they do from here. Customers now know them and know about their business. We've become experts in supply chains, cost challenges and how they treat their colleagues. Some may choose to go and hide back behind the curtain, saving their speaking for shareholders and letting their social media teams do the talking for them. But others may – hopefully – choose to build on this accidental accessibility, with openness from those at the top filtering down through the company and becoming the way things are done.

* * *

Throughout this chapter, we've heard stories of a waste collection service whose refusal to speak to customers just wastes everyone's time, the challenges and chat-up lines of stress-inducing chatbots and the human side of CEOs during the COVID pandemic. Perhaps the biggest challenge to creating an accessible experience is the presumption that everything will work just fine. Often companies map the perfect customer journey, the one where everything goes right and the process just works; where the chatbot understands or the customer has one of the Frequently Asked Questions. Yet often, the reason the customer needs to reply to that email, to make that call, or to speak to the CEO is because something has gone wrong that's causing them stress or worry. Often, the difficulty in being able to get in touch increases that stress and worry. And often, in the long term, it's actually more cost-efficient for the company to make it easy to be contacted than to try and hide behind layers of FAQs and bots.

Looking at the overall customer relationship rather than the individual transaction could help save a lot of time, money and hassle for the business. It would also create better conversations, happier customers and more successful long-term relationships. That's why being accessible is at the heart of the experience the companies in our Showcase create:

'Every variant of myname@ao.com comes directly to me. Now we're bigger, our team deal with them, but I still get to see – and get an explanation for – every single one I get sent.'

AO.com

'One of the first things we did was to say we'd never send an email from a no-reply email address. That's a principle we've stuck to.'

Octopus Energy

'Our growth focus was Bicester Village, the new shopping centre that opened outside of London. It attracted a lot of Arabic and Chinese tourists. We all know how frightening it can be, travelling in a different country, being confused in a train station, so we introduced Arabic and Chinese speakers at Bicester and London Marylebone stations. We wanted to make it as easy as possible for tourists who were going there.'

Chiltern Railways

'There is a relationship that people have with Citymapper. Your little friend for the big city vibe. It comes down to how we talk to the user. We don't say "plan route", we say "get me somewhere" and "get me home". We don't say "loading", we say "thinking". We take a colloquial approach and tone. The world is too serious.'

Citymapper

According to a KPMG case study in 2019[27], each bank manager has a lot of control over processes and decision making: *'A branch manager shared: "My mobile phone number is printed on our marketing materials. If a customer has an issue they can call me directly and I can make a decision. When a customer applies for a home loan, we process their application in our branch. This means we have ownership over the length of processing time, can set expectations and deliver on them."'*

Bendigo Bank

'As soon as a customer joined us, they would get an email from Greg [the CEO] *himself, which the customer could reply to and would go straight into his inbox. That very quickly gave us feedback from real humans without the need for any feedback forms. If somebody was pissed off,*

[27] 'Bendigo Bank Customer Experience Case Study', 2019, https://home.kpmg/au/en/home/insights/2018/09/customer-experience-bendigo-bank-client-story.html

you knew it straight away. Right up until we had 1 million customers, he was answering them himself. Even now, 90 per cent of letters come from a named individual who you can reply to if you need to, and all senior managers see the emails that customers send to the CEO. We need to get rid of the problem or get the customer an answer.'

Octopus Energy

In summary, being accessible means:

- easy to get in touch with;
- responsive when a customer contacts you;
- having visible leadership and transparent ways of working.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Consistent

'Consistency builds trust. Too often leaders become overly corporate and change the message every time a new CEO comes in. "Mums and Grans" – everyone gets it and it works for us.'

AO.com

Being consistent means:

- the customer reality matches the brand promise;
- the experience is the same however the customer chooses to interact;
- the whole relationship is as good as the start.

Let's return to our inaccessible partner. As well as being hard to get hold of, they're frustratingly inconsistent. When you first met them, they'd go whenever you wanted, wherever you wanted. They'd surprise you with gifts, be on the phone all the time and be a shoulder to cry on whenever you needed one. Yet as time goes on, things change. They act in one way in the house yet seem to become a completely different person when they're around their friends or colleagues. They seem increasingly uninterested, giving more attention to some other guy they'd just met. They stop returning your calls.

You decide you've had enough, but still caring for them, want to stay friends. It doesn't go well. They beg you to stay, offering to change and to do all the things you've been asking for. When you say your mind is made up, they blank you and you never hear from them again.

It's a familiar situation in personal relationships and, sadly, in customer relationships too. Consistency breeds certainty, something us humans thrive on, reducing stress and worry and allowing us to live more in the present. The best organizations are consistent across the relationship, not just brilliant at the initial customer 'onboarding'. They're consistent in the message they give to customers and colleagues about who they are and why they exist. And they're consistent regardless of what 'channel' the customer wants to use, with a phone call, email, webchat and letter all being treated with equal importance and likely to generate the same response (even if the letter has been sent to the CEO by a disgruntled-but-savvy customer).

Let's look at these issues in a bit more detail…

Big Little Brand Lies (Or the importance of the reality matching the promise)

As we approached the end of the un-nicknamed 2010s, I decided to set some new decade's resolutions that I would absolutely definitely keep until at least February 2020. Within a few days, not only had I given up, but I'd been reminded that telling people what your brand will deliver is important, but delivering it is even more so.

I spend a ludicrous amount of time on trains every week, so one of my ideas was to use some of that time to close my eyes and rest my brain. I downloaded one of the meditation apps at the forefront of the mindfulness movement, offering short audio clips that help people take their mind of their daily stresses.

The experience itself was great: lots of content, lots of options, lots of accidentally napping on the train and missing my stop. What was less great, though, was the number of emails they sent me once I signed up. In the first week alone I had seven emails, offering discounts on products, asking for feedback and even one suggesting I relax and 'do nothing'. Unnamed meditation app provider, I would love to 'do

nothing', but unfortunately, I have a huge backlog of your emails to work through:

Saturday 08.20 From: Unnamed meditation app provider
Subject: Do you have a minute? We'd love to hear your feedback
Saturday 14.30 From: Unnamed meditation app provider
Subject: Just until tomorrow: 20 per cent off!
Sunday 08.30 From: Unnamed meditation app provider
Subject: Your New Priority: Do Nothing – Take our NEW 30-minute…

This is a great example of the disconnect between a brand's promise and the reality of the experience it provides. The organization is set up to promote mental health and well-being, to escape the information overload that we all face every day, yet by sending so many unwanted emails, they were inadvertently adding to one of the biggest stresses most of us face – overflowing inboxes.

It feels like their marketing team is detached from the rest of the business, focused on its own key performance indicators of product sign-ups and positive net promoter scores rather than delivering the organizational purpose through its customer experience process. This detachment of brand promise and brand reality is more problematic when the marketing team make big bold claims without thinking through the implications for their colleagues on the frontline.

In 2010, NatWest went very public with their 'Customer Charter', a set of 14 commitments they promised to keep.[28] I remember standing in a queue in a NatWest branch, staring at a poster with one of these commitments emblazoned on it:

'*Commitment no. 2 – We will aim to serve the majority of our customers within five minutes in our branches.*'

[28] https://thefinancialbrand.com/12348/rbs-natwest-14-point-customer-charter/

Of course, as a customer, I read this as:

> '*Commitment no. 2 – We will ~~aim to~~ serve ~~the majority of~~ our customers within five minutes ~~in our branches~~*'

You can imagine how I felt as I watched the clock and my time waiting in the queue ticked past the five-minute mark. The marketeers who came up with the promise were sitting safely in HQ; it was their frontline colleagues who were getting it in the neck from disappointed customers.

I heard of a similar situation at HSBC with their famous 'The World's Local Bank' line. One customer would regularly come into a branch and quiz the staff on their knowledge of world geography, just to see how worldly they really were. Of course, overall the marketing campaigns may have been a success, drawing many customers in with the clear commitments being made. This is certainly the case for HSBC, who have consistently been the most valuable bank brand in the UK.[29] However, as the hyperbole around brand purposes and promises ramps up, the risk of having disappointed customers is increasing. The money spent on marketing is quickly negated by the cost of dealing with complaints and service failures, with customers opting to go elsewhere, bringing more pressure on to the marketing team to fill the bucket again.

Planning a great advertising campaign isn't enough. The promise and the process need to align, delivered by colleagues who feel empowered not enraged. That may well give customers a bit more headspace, too.

Two-Headed People
(Or the importance of consistency however a person interacts with a company)

When I was 16, having worked on a market stall earning £1 an hour for the past couple of years, I decided it was time to get a proper part-time

[29] https://www.statista.com/statistics/292043/most-valuable-bank-brands-in-the-united-kingdom/

job. Like most job-hunting teenagers, I looked to retail. Applications went into UK grocery stalwarts Safeway, clothes-retailer Burton, and frozen-food specialists Iceland, with my mum crossing her fingers for the 15 per cent discount card that came with the roles.

The first two applications went as expected: form filled in, call received, interview offered, then an impatient wait to hear whether I had the job. Iceland were different, though. They were quiet. *Very* quiet. After handing in my application, I heard nothing.

I phoned to find out what was happening and they didn't answer my call. So I went into the store to see the manager and he was too busy to see me (despite the fact that they were still advertising and no one actually shopped in Iceland). It was frosty, to say the least. So, I took the job at Safeway, forging a career as the fastest checkout boy in the east of England (unofficial accolade), while my mum began her own discount shopping service for any friends and family who were interested.

A year later, the store manager of Iceland phoned to offer me the job. That (sadly) happened a long time ago now, yet I still remember the experience vividly. What's more, my family and I still have a lingering poor impression of the company because of it.

The only thing that really matters is how you make people feel and that's true whether they're a customer or a colleague. That means every interaction a customer has with a company forms part of their customer experience, including experiences they have as a potential or actual employee. Yet in most organizations, the customer experience team and human resources teams are rarely on the same floor, let alone in the same meeting rooms. They're both focused on the same thing – building a good reputation with the public, hoping to earn decisions in their favour and then giving an experience that makes people feel great about interacting with them – but rarely share their knowledge, skills and approaches to doing this with each other. This is despite the fact that the same things matter to potential recruits as they do to customers. They both want certainty, knowing their application has been received, what the next steps are and when. They want empathy,

an understanding that this application is a big moment for them, being treated with sensitivity regardless of the outcome. And they want humanity, to see the personality in an organization, not a faceless corporate machine.

Because these two departments are kept separate, the time and money spent perfecting the customer experience can be undermined by a completely different recruitment experience. CVs and applications go unanswered, people are left waiting a long time to find out what's happening and cold, automated responses are given, even though these are hugely emotional moments in the person's life.

This has a genuine commercial impact. Copywriter Keenan Steiner's 2017 article on 'The Cost of Bad Candidate Experience' showed that 6 per cent of rejected Virgin Media candidates went on to cancel their customer contracts, at a cost of around £4.4 million every year to the company. (He also showed that the cost of acquiring a customer through traditional marketing channels was 10 times more expensive than acquiring one who came through a great recruiting experience, whether they end up joining the company or not.)[30]

Careers fairs, interviews and assessment centres are all brilliant opportunities to act in a way that brings your brand to life for people – and as Trello showed with their application auto-response, this can even be done during the most mundane parts of the experience.[31] It starts with a friendly welcome:

> *Hurrah! We have received your job application. At least, we think it's yours. It is possible that someone who thinks very highly of you is forwarding around your resume while pretending to be you. That's not a bad thing, is it?*

[30] https://www.linkedin.com/business/talent/blog/talent-acquisition/bad-candidate-experience-cost-virgin-media-5m-annually-and-how-they-turned-that-around

[31] https://www.themuse.com/advice/a-job-application-autoresponse-that-will-actually-make-you-happy

Make the crucial information clear:

> *Now, this bit is really important: PLEASE PLEASE PLEASE make sure that when you reply to us, you reply to this email. We keep track of all this stuff in FogBugz and that ugly case ID number in the subject is the only thing that keeps us sane.*

And end on a reassuring note:

> *P.S. If for some reason you are not actually applying for a job, or if you just wrote with a question about Trello, I apologize, for I am a stupid recruiting robot, built without much cognitive ability, and rest assured that an actual human will really look at your email and reply to it appropriately.*

The first step to giving a great customer experience is to get great people; the first step to getting great people is to give a great colleague experience. However, as recruitment becomes more automated, the temptation is there to standardize the approach and forget about the human at the receiving end. This may make things more efficient, but it may also be affecting your business in ways you haven't realized, too.

Just ask my mum, who definitely hasn't gone to Iceland since.

Time to Say Goodbye (Or the importance of designing a great end to the experience)

My list of COVID lockdown boredom purchases was highly impressive: a standing desk (used a lot), a telescope (used a bit) and a new VR headset (no comment). The most boring of the boredom purchases was new patio doors. Except unlike the other impulse buys, this one didn't even make it into the house.

I'd gone through all the required steps when buying double glazing. A salesman had come to the house, stayed for longer than I would have

liked, offered me a ludicrously high price, called his manager several times to 'see what he could do' and eventually we settled on the amount that I wanted and he was probably able to offer me right from the start.

When the surveyor visited to plan the job, however, it was a different story. He walked in, took one look at the current doors and let out a sigh. Not just any sigh, but the sigh of a man who'd been here a hundred times before, a sigh accompanied by the faintest shake of the head, a sigh of a man who knew exactly what the next five minutes was going to be like:

'You can't have the door you've bought in there. It's too small. It won't be able to open from the outside.'

'Right. I was really hoping for a door that opened from the inside and the outside.'

'Yep. You've been told the wrong information. You'll need a bigger hole, which will cost a few thousand more.'

(Sees my face)

'You can cancel it and get a refund. It's what everyone else does.'

So, cancel it is what I did. Or, at least, I tried to do.

The company had been incredibly easy to get hold of when I wanted the quote. A call-back the same day. An appointment in the diary within 48 hours. Text messages to keep me updated with the visit time. Email and phone contact details for the regional manager. Sales documents delivered rapidly after the appointment.

It was a different story when trying to get back my deposit. A generic 'customer service' email address to contact. A default reply passing me on to the local team. Silence for a few days. No replies to emails. A call-back promise that didn't materialize. Then another. Then another. Finally, an email and a refund, but with no apology for the mistake or the hassle it caused, or alternative suggestion for how I could get the doors I wanted.

From contact to quote to purchase: three days.

From contact to call to refund: three weeks.

In 2017, Joe Macleod published a brilliant book called *Ends*[32]. In it, he discusses '*why we overlook endings for humans, products, services and digital. And why we shouldn't*'. It's a fascinating book, delving into the general discomfort humans have with endings (it turns out that saying goodbye really is hard to do) and the impact it has on the way in which organizations design their customer experiences.

Companies seem to work on the presumption that all the hard work is in winning a customer and that once a customer has been won, they're staying forever. In reality, there are very few companies that customers will stay with for their entire life. This is especially true in increasingly commoditized industries such as utilities, telecoms and insurance, where it's likely a customer will be with a company for a few years, then go to someone else, then consider them again in the future. So, it makes sense for companies to make the last impression a great one. Yet so often customers are treated to either the hard sell ('*have you spoken to our retention team to offer you all the great things we didn't offer you when you weren't thinking of leaving?*') or the cold shoulder ('*you're no longer interested in us so we're no longer interested in you*').

As is often the case, companies could take a leaf out of Amazon's book. My former colleague Graham Allinson received an automated phone call letting him know that his Prime service was about to renew and the money would soon be debiting his account. More importantly, it then said, 'Press 1 to speak to an agent if you want to cancel your subscription.'

Really proactive, making it easy to leave and, in doing so, making him feel more favourably about the company and encouraging him to stay. Not keeping quiet and hoping the customer doesn't notice the renewal until it's too late.

In the case of my patio doors, we're still going to get them replaced in the future and I accepted that the salesman had made an honest mistake. But the way the experience ended, creating hours of physical

[32] Macleod, J. (2017) *Ends.* Author.

effort in chasing and in mental effort of worrying, means that company has now fallen far down my list of options to consider next time I'm going to impulse buy some home improvement.

Rather than companies seeing an ending as the final step in the customer relationship, they should regard it as the first step in winning them back in the future and maybe, in doing so, it will make them think twice about leaving at all.

* * *

Throughout this chapter, we've heard about a meditation service that sends stress-inducing emails, a fairly frosty recruitment policy from the 1990s and a dodgy patio door salesman with selective hearing. Creating consistency is easy to say but hard to do. This is especially true as organizations grow, introducing more people and processes that create opportunities for misalignment and mistakes.

More than that, consistency is becoming harder to deliver in a world where there's so many more ways to access an experience. No longer is a shop just a shop on a high street. Even a single independent shop will have a premises, a website and a social media account. As the company grows, the variables grow, too. Apps, chatbots, messaging services. Facebook, Twitter and TikTok. Payment taken in cash or by cheque, Apple or Google Pay, on credit or by Klarna. Multiple towns, cities and countries.

In this context, keeping control of a single brand message is hard enough when having the message distributed across so many channels and people, let alone aligning it with the actual experience. This is where the most human, authentic companies have the advantage. There's no need to try to keep everyone on message as the message is central to who they are and how they work. There's no need to force together HR and Marketing, as the treatment of colleagues and customers will naturally align. And there's less challenge when customers leave, as they've not been hiding things or playing tricks on customers during the rest of the relationship.

This is what the companies in our Showcase (*see also* pages 43–52) had to say on the importance of creating consistency:

'Blending the boundaries between an actual, human experience and a digital, automatic system is a very deliberate path we've taken. As a consumer you want to feel every interaction is consistent. If I tap a link to change a payment, I want to be told in an empathetic way as if I would if I had phoned up and had a conversation about it, so we take a real conversational approach to our design experiences, regardless of which channel you go down.'

Octopus Energy

*'Our app is strongest when you land in a city you've never been to before. You get spat out from the Metro train and you're like "oh f*ck". All you need to do is open Citymapper, it says "hey, looks like you're in Hong Kong". You set your hotel as Home and you get this freedom to wander.'*

Citymapper

'The job of our marketing team is to get them through the door. The job of the operational team was to make sure they had a good donation experience. Then when they walked out of the door the job of the marketing team was to get them to keep coming back. It was all tied together as closely as possible because the experience itself runs right through pre, during and after donation.'

NHSBT

'When coming up with our visual design approach, it was important that our app really stands out. You should be able to recognize the app, even when standing four meters away on a bus stop.'

Citymapper

'We had around 50,000 customers when we noticed we were starting to struggle operationally and we started by following the industry norm of splitting into specialist teams. We quickly realised we'd lost that magic of someone calling and saying, "I was speaking to Harry the other day" and being able to quickly put Harry on the phone… So we set our teams up so they can look after a customer fully, from start to finish, everything they might need. It means we don't have to have long and laborious scripts that get rid of all that humanity. Instead, we can just hire great people and let them be themselves.'

Octopus Energy

In summary, being consistent means:

- the customer reality matches the brand promise;
- the experience is the same however the customer chooses to interact;
- the whole relationship is as good as it was at the beginning.

CHAPTER NINE

Flexible

'I want to make sure we don't fall into a trap of just working from a playbook. That's important, and it's great to onboard new employees, but you have to empower your employees with enough training, with ensuring that they develop enough empathy for customers so that they can react the right way to customers in certain situations and not be handcuffed by a playbook. They have to have tools, have to have approvals at their level so that they can help service customers and keep them happy.'

Workday

Being flexible means:

- knowing when to stand in front of the rules;
- adapting to different people and situations;
- allowing customers to have curated choices.

Successful human relationships rely on compromise. The ones that work well are those where the people involved are willing to talk, to listen and to adjust. The ones that break down are those where stubbornness rules, where partners refuse to concede any ground or change their plans, even if it's obvious that it's causing the other person hassle or stress.

The most customer-led companies recognize the importance of this human element: that people are different, will need different

things at different times and that not every situation can be predicted. Yet providing this flexibility is often at odds with how organizations grow and operate, with rules required to create the crucial repeatability of their offer, helping to scale while keeping quality high and processes legal.

In fact, an inflexible organization can often make a bad situation worse. As a customer, the initial frustration at not being able to get to the outcome you wanted can be worsened by the rigidity on show in front of you. It can create a sense of helplessness, an exasperation felt particularly keenly when it's obvious to both parties what the right thing to do is, a desperation for common sense to prevail.

This common-sense factor was missing in a story Media Relations Specialist Jamie Douglass told me about a recent restaurant experience:

> *'I just went to the local pizza place and tried to use one of their 2-4-1 vouchers, but the guy insisted he could only accept the voucher if you booked the table over the phone. So I went outside and called them. The same guy picked up the phone and conducted the entire conversation 100 per cent straight looking at me in the eye through the glass door.'*

The best companies break away from the parent-child customer relationship in favour of adult to adult. They understand that perfect journey maps rarely translate into reality, ready to react when something doesn't go to plan. They give choice – not too little, not too much – creating space to adapt in different situations. And they know that humans are prone to changeable whims and desires on any given day, using stereotypes and segmentation to help guide but leaving room for individual preference.

Let's have some examples of this in action…

Stand and Deliver
(Or the importance of knowing when to stand in front of the rules)

Shortly after moving to a new house, I spent a traditional middle-aged Sunday wandering around furniture shops. I bought an amazing new chair, but only after a lesson that good customer experience relies on people standing in front of the strict processes handed down from head office.

We'd had our eye on this chair for a while, so headed to the shop to enact the obligatory sit-on-it-for-15-minutes-to-make-sure-it-was-exactly-the-right-level-of-comfort test. When we got to the shop, there were big signs everywhere promoting their 'Display Furniture Sale', and even better, the chair we wanted was half price.

Comfort test done, I went to pay for the chair before someone else could snatch it from our grasp. That's where the problems started:

> *'I'm sorry, sir, because it's ex-display, we can't deliver it. You have to take it home – today.'*

Not ideal. Particularly because we have quite a small car, quite a tall toddler and quite of lot of junk that seems to have gathered in the backseat without us noticing.

Suddenly our dream of a perfectly comfy half-price chair to sit on for the next 20 years was in danger of slipping through our fingers but we presumed there must be a way to do this, the company must be used to this situation.

Instead of an easy answer, what followed was a bizarre back-and-forth with the team to work out whether it would be possible for me to actually give them my money for a product they wanted to sell:

> *'Can I take the chair out to the car* [parked in their car park, right outside the store] *to see if it will fit?'*
>
> *'No. You have to buy it first.'*

'If I buy the chair, take it outside and it doesn't fit, can I bring it back in and get a refund?'

'No, no refunds on ex-display furniture.'

'If I buy the chair, take it outside and it doesn't fit, can I bring it back in until I'm able to collect it during the week?'

'No, you have to take it today.'

By this point, I was living in one of those puzzles that feature a fox, a chicken and a bag of grain. There seemed like there might be a way to make his happen, but they really didn't want me to buy this chair. (Unlike my son, who was refusing to move from the chair and yelling, *'This is our chair, you can't have it!'* to any other prospective purchasers who even so much as looked at it in an admiring way.)

I decided to take the risk and buy it, confident that with some careful chair leg removal, and abandoning my family in the store, I could get the chair in the car, get it home and return triumphant an hour later. So I handed over my card, paid for it and hoped I was right.

'Could someone help me carry it to the car, please?'

'Yes! Of course we can, but only as far as the door.'

So the helpful (young, muscly) assistant carried the chair to the front of the store with me, then put it down and watched as my wife and I struggled to take it the extra three metres from the door to the car, open the boot and balance it there to remove the legs – all while trying to stop our toddler running out in front of the other vehicles that were finding parking spaces.

For any large organization to be successful, it needs to have processes and policies in place to ensure a consistent delivery of what it offers. But rules can't possibly account for every scenario that might occur, with journey maps often built around an aggregated experience, not accounting for the myriad of moments that need reacting to every day. This leads to customers being frustrated and colleagues being

embarrassed, knowing what the simple solution is but having to give that apologetic 'I would if I could' response. The best organizations understand this, providing guidelines but giving their people the freedom to use their initiative and common sense to do what's right in the moment, for that customer.

Unpredictable Individualism (Or the importance of letting customers do things their way)

I was a month into a rather surreal complaint with my British telecoms provider when a ray of hope appeared in tweet form. My pedantic 280-character rant had triggered an alert on a social media monitoring screen somewhere in Scotland, throwing the team into emoji-led action with a response offering an apology and help.

Unfortunately, the smiley face was as good as it got.

The one thing I really didn't want to do, I told them, was to speak to their orders department for a fifth time. The one thing I would have to do, they told me, was to speak to their orders department for a fifth time. Oh, and the orders department liked to keep things simple – for them – so didn't call customers. Instead, I could call them at a time convenient to me. As long as it was also a time convenient to them and they were able to answer the phone. So ensued a week-long game of telephone tennis.

The problem eventually got sorted, but my energy had, by then, evaporated.

Despite all the 'it just works' evidence to the contrary, being a customer in the 'effortless economy' can be incredibly hard work. We're surrounded by services trying to help us say good riddance to unnecessary effort. We have on-tap experts ready to remotely fix our plumbing, Spotify sorting our music while Alexa arranges our auntie's groceries and DoNotPay overturning our dubious parking fines. Yet 'it just works' only seems to be the case when, well, it just works. Too often processes are designed to PowerPoint perfection, failing to consider that in real human life things may be more

unpredictable. Or they're deliberately designed for the business to maximize opportunities or streamline costs, regardless of the impact on the person at the other end of the process, as I found out when trying to close an old bank account over the phone, which proved a near impossibility.

It could only be done, they said, if there was fraud on my account (which, to be clear, means it could be done, but they were choosing not to do it). Paper was the way it had to be. A month later, the promised Account Closure forms arrived (slow, but to be fair, the form was coming from the 1980s). It wasn't pre-filled, had no return envelope and no freepost either, meaning I had to pay 55p to close an account with 26p in it, or leave it open and at risk of fraud. Which ironically would have meant I could close it over the phone. But if I wanted to open an account? Instantly, through the app, their banner adverts tell me.

Need your broadband fixing? Check out the FAQs. Thinking of leaving us? Let me connect you to someone straight away.

Got an issue with your mobile phone? Try our unpaid community helpers. Want to upgrade? We'll call you anytime, day or night.

Want to buy some patio doors? I'll call you all afternoon to book an appointment. Want to cancel the order? I'll get back to you next month.

This approach may save money in the short term, but it'll make customers resentful in the long term – regardless of how good their social media emoji game is. Instead, what's needed is a company that's available for customers in whichever way they want to get in touch, something that may change depending on the time, place or other commitments the customer has that day.

The digital revolution has created a low-effort world and given companies the chance to provide a human customer experience for less. However, it's also led to a dereliction of duty and a prioritization of processes that make money for the company over those that reduce effort for customers.

When something unplanned happens, customers are too often left to take responsibility with only the most resilient willing to push

through the layers of 'have you tried our help articles?' to speak to someone who can actually get things back on track. It's time people would rather spend in exciting and Instagrammable ways: trying new foods, travelling the world, secretly acting out eighties films in huge, abandoned warehouses. People do not want to spend their lives on the phone to British Telecom. For example.

So, the challenge for organizations, having designed an experience that looks great on Post-its and posters, is to make that experience a reality for people. This means thinking through different eventualities caused by human unpredictability, understanding when people should do it themselves and when a helping hand is going to be needed. It means knowing that things won't always just work and having a plan in place to deal with the off-script moments that will inevitably happen. And it means giving customers certainty, ensuring they're kept up to date with what's happening and what's going to happen next.

Otherwise, they'll decide to do things their way anyway – starting with choosing a new company to give their custom to.

Structured Flexibility
(Or the importance of giving customers curated choice)

When I worked in retail banking in the early 2000s, we launched an in-branch radio station. One of our business customers was furious. He cornered me and explained how much he valued those few moments of peace and quiet while queueing to pay in his money. In our attempts to modernize banking – which we thought was what people wanted – we'd completely ruined his experience. He wanted faster payments, predictive data and a better app, but the music was a step too far.

I thought back to this customer when out for dinner with five white, middle-class friends in early 2020. All in our thirties, all married, all homeowners, all with 'good' jobs in or around London. In other words, a segmentation dream. We even neatly sat together laughing and drinking as if we were a real-life stock photo, ready to be labelled with a

two-word alliterative title. Yet as I looked around, I noticed we weren't as similar as we seemed. Two of us were wearing traditional analogue watches, another had a classic eighties Casio, one had no watch at all, one had a Fitbit and another seemed to have a useless piece of plastic strapped to his wrist (on closer inspection, this turned out to be a first-generation Apple Watch).

There were three iPhones, two Androids and one old Windows phone. Three of us would have chips implanted for identification purposes and contactless payments, the other three visibly recoiled at the idea. Two refused to have any financial information on their phones for fear of data security (one of whom was the Fitbit wearer, a laggard in one sense and an early adoptee in another). Three did no kind of financial budgeting at all, while the other three kept their receipts religiously and ticked them off at the end of each month. One wasn't even on Instagram.

This is not just about similar people having unexpectedly different views. Modern life has an endless stream of new things to try, buy and discard, with more choices available for how to try and buy than ever before, influenced by an ever-widening range of friends, family and followers. It's a world where we all desire to be seen as individual, while being desperate to belong to groups of people like us. This means that it's harder than ever to put people into neat marketing boxes, with customers choosing the most useful option for them in the moment.

Shall I use cash, contactless or Oyster? Uber, Taxi or Tube? Dishoom, Dine in for a Tenner or Deliveroo? Do I feel more 'Premium' or 'Value' today? This hour? This minute? In the past, it was the organization's choice as to whether you qualified for their 'premium' service. Now this premium-ness is self-selected. Someone might want the best quality meat in Waitrose and then buy their tinned goods in Aldi. They might want the all-inclusive TV package but be happy with the most basic banking service. Many will pay hundreds each year to get a superb music subscription, but not want to pay a penny for their daily news fix.

As for my angry audiophobe, I asked what kind of music he liked and he told me he only listened to classical so I (warily) suggested he come in at 2.30 p.m. when the radio station did a daily 'Classics' segment.

A week later, he cornered me again. I braced myself for the worst. With a beaming smile, he told me he that loved it so much that after he'd paid in his money, he'd get a coffee from the machine and stay in the branch until the classical music was finished.

* * *

Throughout this chapter, we've heard about a challenging chair-buying experience with a hierarchical helper, a classical-music-loving bank customer and a white middle-class dinner party with at least some digital diversity. Flexibility is crucial for delivering a human customer experience, yet causes a challenge for companies, whose efficient size and scale relies on delivering the same thing to lots of people repeatedly over time.

In 2012, I launched the first mobile app for one of the UK's big banks. As I sit here writing a decade after the app launched, the industry has still failed to get rid of cheques. More than that, in 2019 the neo-bank Simple announced with a fanfare it had added a new service to its mobile-first offering:

'We've recently started offering Paper Cheques!'

So, what's needed is a 'Structured Flexibility' approach to designing and delivering customer experiences. This means understanding where the start point is, agreeing the ideal outcome and designing around the main bits that have to happen within it – and then leaving everything else open to interpretation, with customers choosing the experience that's right for them (and colleagues to have the freedom to be genuinely human). It also means helping customers to make the right choice not just functionally deliver the thing they think they want. Rory Sutherland touched on the need for this curated choice

in *The Spectator* when discussing the challenges with buying a house through online property search:

> *'An online search merely shows you what you think you want. When people buy through a human estate agent, however, they very rarely end up buying something matching the specifications they set in advance… When we buy or choose online (at Amazon, Rightmove, Ocado), or when we buy anything using a decision tree, we never get to see what we might have bought had we chosen differently.'*[33]

Alongside this is the need to react when things don't go to plan, which more often than not comes from giving colleagues the autonomy to assess the situation, use their common sense, and react to the human in front of them in a way that chatbots are currently unable to. You can't please all of the people all of the time, but you can create the conditions for them to please themselves.

> *'We've always stayed away from "here's three routes, we know best". The final job of picking what's best for you is also up to the user. We've been criticised for that for having too many options, but we skew towards giving as much info as possible in the simplest way for the user to make the final call. There's always context which drives the person's final decision.'*
>
> Citymapper

> *'We can't react to every whim customers have. Customers expect us to have an opinion, and to have made some of those decisions for them, and to offer a curated range based on some thoughtful choices.'*
>
> Riverford

[33] https://www.spectator.co.uk/article/the-problem-with-online-property-searches

'Our model is about optimisation, not maximisation. We don't just need blood. We need the right type of blood at the right time, in the right place. In 2012 we started our app development, which gave customers a calendar grid to allow them to book their own appointment time and location. Crucially, it also allowed us to get the right mix of blood, as we would change which appointment slots customers saw on the app depending on what their blood type was and what we would need. We also built into the app a feature that allowed you to let us know if you were going on holiday for a while, so you'd get no communication from us during that time. That was very popular.'

NHSBT

'More than 300 Bendigo branches are built on Bendigo Bank's Community Bank® model. This model was implemented in the late '90s as the main point of differentiation from its four larger competitors. It allows communities to invest in their local branch with profits being used to fund local projects – totalling more than $200 million since inception.'[34]

Bendigo Bank

'We hand design each and every icon for each city, inspired by the real world. There is no generic "metro" or "bus" icon. What the bus stop looks like in the real city is what it should look like in the app. The biggest compliment we get is people thinking we're based in their cities. Even the mascots – our "Greenies" – are designed to be local. We want locals to be proud to be represented by them.'

Citymapper

[34] https://home.kpmg/au/en/home/insights/2018/09/customer-experience-bendigo-bank-client-story.html

'In your processes you need to think about how you empower your frontline employees on a regular basis. If they feel like they have to go for approvals up the chain for anything they want to do for customers, then you're really handcuffing them. They can't react quickly, nor can they do what's right for that customer.'[35]

Workday

'Human relationships shouldn't be defined by a training manual telling you how to treat customers. There's a misconception that being big makes it hard to maintain a human response, but it's manageable if you invest in your people.'

Riverford

In summary, being flexible means:

- knowing when to stand in front of the rules;
- adapting to different people and situations;
- allowing customers curated choice.

[35] https://www.blakemichellemorgan.com/podcast/how-workday-stays-customer-centric-during-covid-19/

CHAPTER TEN

Proactive

'One of our operations team who deal with customers came up with a wonderful idea to send out some flowers to customers, but not to fix a complaint, just if you feel the customer needs cheering up. Another thing we noticed with the pandemic is that we had a real increase in the number of people who cancelled meter installations because they didn't want to switch off the Wi-Fi. So engineers took the initiative, and took battery packs to plug people's Wi-Fi routers into, meaning they could change the meter and the customer could stay online.'

Octopus Energy

Being proactive means:

- doing the work for customers;
- identifying and resolving potential problems;
- answering the next question before it's asked.

The best conversations with friends are the ones where you're practically finishing each other's sentences. You're on a roll, going deep into topics and exploring tangents without missing a beat, completely in sync and fully getting what each other is saying and thinking. Those same friends are the ones who sense when something is wrong and ask, 'are you ok?' They buy you a coffee when you need a pick-me-up, get tickets for a show that they know you'll love, message you to tell you there's a delay on your usual train to work. They look out for you more

broadly too, telling you if they don't think someone is good for you, or encouraging you to try new experiences.

Now imagine the opposite. A stilted conversation with someone who feels like they're on a different wavelength, full of awkward silences and long pauses. Someone who has more experience than you and sees the mistakes you're about to make, but lets you make them anyway, waiting until you're in trouble and you beg them for help to step in and sort things out. Someone who knows they're not a great friend, but just thinks you should put up with how they are.

Too often, it's this second experience that customers have with organizations. Keeping quiet when a renewal is coming up, giving the impression that they're hoping they won't get 'caught out'. Taking a 'just in time' approach to customer experience, stepping in only when they must, driven by a desire to save cost until the last possible moment. Only dealing with the issue at hand when a customer calls, so they can move on quickly to the next call and hit their service KPIs.

The most human companies take a different approach. They predict what else the customer needs to know to achieve their outcome and tell them beforehand. They spot and fix problems before the customer is aware of them, putting in the effort so customers don't have to. They know about 'Failure Demand' and that taking the time to get it right in the first place saves a lot of time, effort and cost for everyone in the long term.

Let's look at some examples…

The Effortless Economy (Or the importance of organizations doing the work for customers)

You know what it's like. One minute you have a slightly blocked sink, the next your entire kitchen floor has been ripped up, four machines with a jet-engine decibel level have been installed and a worried looking builder is telling you the other guy got it wrong and asbestos may have been forcefully circulating through the house for the past three weeks.

It's fair to say this rapid escalation of events wasn't the comedown from the first COVID lockdown I'd been hoping for. Mistake after mistake had been made by our insurance company so after eight weeks without action, I felt sure that if I raised a complaint with them, they'd be eager to help. What I actually got was an example of how often companies' processes require customers to do the work themselves, forgetting they're human beings with limited time to spend on this earth and that the company is being paid to take the effort away.

When I asked to complain to my case manager's boss, I was told this wasn't possible and that the process was to complain to the case manager. I said that might be awkward as the complaint was about him. They said they understood, but I should give him time to respond. I pointed out that the complaint was about his continuing failure to respond. They said hmmm, that does seem a little ironic. Like rain on your wedding day… I pointed out that's not ironic, that's just bad luck. They said I should listen to the song. I said we're going off topic.

Ultimately, I did have to complain again, directly to my case manager. Then, if I wasn't happy with his response, my reward is to log in to their sophisticated claims portal and escalate it myself. To my case manager's boss.

In this example, the customer is essentially being used as an extension of the team. Despite the fact there's clearly an issue to be resolved, I'm having to make calls, send emails and repeat myself many times to try and get a satisfactory outcome.

In another example, the lack of proactivity was less about the time and more about financial loss. The day before I was due to attend a smart post-COVID black-tie event, I realized my shirt had 'shrunk' during lockdown. I ordered a new one in a slightly larger size and paid extra for 24-hour delivery.

The next day came, but the shirt didn't. I phoned the company, who immediately acknowledged the situation and apologized for the shirt being delayed. They offered to refund the extra money I'd paid for express delivery. In our world of open and immediate data, they would have known instantly that the shirt was wasn't going to arrive on time

– and the human impact that would have had on me, given I'd clearly ordered it in a rush.

While they did refund the money, having to spend more time phoning up (when really, I needed to be on the treadmill) added insult to injury. How much better would that experience have been if they'd contacted me proactively, apologized and automatically refunded the money? More than that, I wonder how many customers never bother phoning to complain and therefore how many express delivery charges the company get to keep despite failing to deliver on their promise?

Question Time
(Or the importance of predicting and answering the next question)

Is there anything else I can help with?

Eight words. Eight, seemingly inoffensive, overly polite words. But eight words that annoy me more than any other in customer experience because, more often than not, they haven't helped with the thing I wanted help with in the first place. Instead, they've usually just answered the specific question I've asked rather than helping me achieve the outcome I wanted. Let me give you an example…

I subscribe to a sports magazine, one of those online-only, £1-a-month special offer things that gives you more articles on football than you ever realized you needed and that I'll almost certainly cancel when the deal runs out.

Each week, they send a round-up of their latest writing, covering everything from Euro Final match reports to the life story of a Bulgarian reserve who played one match for Arsenal in 1993. I started receiving two of these emails with slightly different content. Nothing major, but a bit annoying, so I emailed the Customer Service team:

'Hi, a couple of weeks ago I started receiving two nearly-identical weekly digest emails from you. Have I accidentally got two accounts linked to my name or something? I don't want to be paying twice by mistake.'

The reply answered that question but no more:

'Hi John! Thanks for reaching out. There are no other active accounts.'

Then the dreaded:

'Let me know if you have any other questions, happy to help!'

Well yes, anonymous emailer from anonymous online sports magazine, I do have other questions, all related to how I stop getting two identical emails from you each week.

This is a great example of focusing on the single question rather than the broader customer outcome, not considering the next question that I might have so I emailed back, making my next question clear:

'Okay – do you know why I'm getting two emails then? Is one signed up via Apple?'

This time their reply was stoic and resolute, refusing to give more information or help than absolutely necessary:

'To answer your question on our end there are no other active subscriptions. Hope this helps!!!'

I took the triple exclamation mark as shorthand for 'and I hope you stop emailing me now!!!' So back I went, trying to make the request even more clear:

'Hi. [Anonymous sports subscription magazine] is sending me two identical emails each week and I'd like one of them to stop. Can you help, please?'

I didn't get a reply, but I did get two more emails on Sunday.

A similar and possibly more expensive situation happened to one of my colleagues who bought a second-hand car, a beautiful classic red Jaguar. He took it to his local garage for a few tests and a much-needed tune up. A few hours' work at most. Around midday, he received this message:

> *'Good afternoon. Unfortunately, we've had some forced renovation work in our garage. Please expect some delay in this job. Sorry for the inconvenience.'*

His reply was as expected:

> *'Could you let me know when you expect the car to be done?'*

But their reply wasn't:

> *'I'm sorry, we're having some issues with our system. I'll get back to you sometime.'*

This issue of not answering the next question, only focusing on the specific request rather than the overall outcome, is annoying for customers and expensive for companies. It's also quite un-human.

From an early age we learn how to have good conversations. A back and forth of questions and answers, anecdotes and opinions, following interesting tangents as they appear and not being constrained by a set process or structure that must be followed. Imagine if conversations with friends were delivered in the way some companies speak to customers. They would seem awkward, stilted, robotic:

> *'I've decided to move to a new country.'*
> *'Really? Wow, that's huge!'*
> *'Yep! Let me know if there's anything else you want to know.'*

'Erm… where are you going?'
'Argentina! Anything else you want to know?'
'Erm… why are you moving?'
'I just am. Anything else you want to know?'

A human version of this conversation would be free-flowing, the person with the information knowing what the other person will want to know and sharing it without needing endless prompting:

'I've decided to move to a new country.'
'Really? Wow, that's huge!'
'I know! Exciting, though. I decided I wanted to see the world but keep my career going and I've still got some family in Argentina so decided there might be a good place to go first. I leave in three months!'
'That's so exciting! Can I come with you?!'

This is especially important in complex industries such as banking, insurance and IT, where customers may know the outcome they want, but may not know the right questions to ask.

People inside the industry – more familiar with the products, language and regulations – have a crucial role to play in helping customers to navigate the complexity, not just answering the question the customer thinks is the right one to ask.

For companies, this 'get it done' approach creates an illusion of efficiency, showing issues being resolved quickly but missing the amount of failure demand, repeat calls and lost customers as a result.

The anonymous sports subscription magazine and car-impounding local garage could both take a lesson from WordPress on this. I've had my blog with them for years and anytime I need help (which is, frankly, all the time), they're brilliant at really understanding the outcome I want and answering all questions I might have before I even know to ask them. In fact, sometimes the issue with WordPress is that they're

too keen to help. I've often found myself locked in conversations with their brilliant support team, them not quite satisfied with their own (perfectly good) answer, wanting to find other ways that might help my site look better or load faster.

On several occasions, after the webchat has finished and I've gone away happy, I've had emails appear a couple of days later suggesting other ideas that they've been thinking about or have discussed with colleagues. As a result, I have absolute faith that they'll get me to the outcome I want, not just answering my question but helping me work out the right questions to be asking in the first place.

Dealing with something properly the first time not only saves time and effort for the company but builds confidence with customers that any future issues will be dealt with properly.

Now, is there anything else I can help you with?

* * *

In this chapter we've heard tales of a work-shy insurance company, a subscription magazine service with a one-question-only policy and a car repair garage with a confusing approach to communication. For most businesses, their stated reason for being is to make people's lives easier or better somehow: better products, simpler services, more choice, less effort. Yet as the 'Move Fast and Break Things' mantra has taken hold, it seems that customers have been the ones to pick up the pieces of broken processes, expected to put in the effort when things don't work out as planned. Customers' time and energy is being taken advantage of, with many organizations seemingly forgetting that customers are paying them money to take away some kind of stress or hassle, or to add some kind of improvement or delight to their lives.

Being a customer shouldn't be hard work, shouldn't require an extra to-do list of things to sort out once you've logged off your Zoom calls for the day. A company that's truly proactive is demonstrating every day that it cares about its customers and about helping them achieve

the outcome they want, showing a desire to take away any added effort and stress and just leave an enjoyable experience.

Proactivity gives a sense of certainty, a trust that the company is looking out for your best interests, taking a weight off your mind. It not only gives confidence that they'll be there should something go wrong, but also that they'll be in touch should a better offer emerge, not leaving it to chance that you may or may not see an advert or notice a renewal coming up. More than anything, being proactive adds a genuine humanity to the relationship, acting in the way a friend who has your best interests at heart would do.

This is how some companies choose to do it:

'We have this "pause" feature for Citymapper PASS to pause your subscription. It's worry-free, so if you go on holiday you can pause it easily. During the pandemic, over 90 per cent of passes were paused, not churned, which is amazing given the world stopped moving. I think it was because of the comms about that feature. Two days before it's about to restart, we send an email, notification and SMS and give a one-tap option to pause it again. There was a lot of honesty about that feature, about the openness of us. Just straight up, no shady stuff. That builds trust and pays off in the long term. You might be able to hit some KPIs with the shady stuff but it's short term. The moment the user realises you care about them and take them seriously, the customer is with you long term then, it means so much to them.'

Citymapper

'In the Marketing team, if we want to launch a new offer we might have to send a million emails. So, we'll send out the first 500 and the marketing team will pick up every email response to those. We'll talk to the team on the phones and see what's being said. We have a Slack channel set up where anyone across the organization can say what's happening and share a link to hear the real customer call. Then we'll revise the letter based on

what we've learnt, then send to 5000 more, and repeat the process. Then 50000. This means that for most customers, their questions and issues have been answered before they've even had to ask them. Because you're hearing real conversations rather than surveys, you get this first-hand experience of what really matters to people, what they care about and your place in their lives.'

Octopus Energy

Bendigo Bank has a proactive approach to making sure customers are on the best possible products: *'Annalise Hewitt, Branch Manager, shared that "Every 3 months I call my home loan customers to ensure they have the best rate." It is something the bank's customers appear to appreciate and remember, with one survey respondent stating: "They contacted me with information about changing my account to one with a better return for me."'*[36]

Bendigo Bank

'Some things don't change. I've never met a customer who said they want to pay more, pay slower, want a smaller range, curated worse, and want it delivered less conveniently. We take all those things and ask "How do we make them better every day?".'

AO.com

In summary, being proactive means:

- doing the work for customers;
- identifying and resolving potential problems;
- answering the next question before it's asked.

[36] https://home.kpmg/au/en/home/insights/2018/09/customer-experience-bendigo-bank-client-story.html

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Respectful

'As the company has grown rapidly, it's maintained its small company mentality. We've always remembered that customers have a choice and that the way to make a profit is to be great for our customers. And customers have higher demands now, with more choice than ever.'

Chiltern Railways

Being respectful means:

- being conscious of the customer's time;
- being respectful of them as an individual;
- showing humility when called for.

Returning to our theoretical partner, you'd want someone who treated you with respect. You'd want them to think the best of you and appreciate your experience and knowledge, listening to what you have to say. They'd respect your time, understanding that you have a full and busy life and that you want to spend it on the things you love doing.

They'd remember that they're just one bit of your life, aware you have a job to do and friends and family who are important to you and are therefore appreciative of the time you get together. And they'd feel bad if they upset you, wanting to put things right and being genuinely sorry for any hurt they'd caused.

Conversely, a less-good partner might be more interested in talking than listening, ignoring your experience and subjecting you to regular explanations of things you already know. They might not trust you,

doubting you when you tell them where you've been or what you've been up to, making you feel insecure. They might waste your time, inclined to cancel on you at the last minute, ignore your phone calls, or not reply to messages when it's pretty clear you need an answer right away.

They might even burden you with their own problems and issues, over-stating the importance of their role in your life and taking you for granted. While they're acting like this, they're messaging friends behind your back and posting on social media saying how much they want new people in their life, instead of replying to your messages.

You wouldn't stay with this person, would you?

Respect and humility are crucial human traits that seem to have gone missing in the past decade, more broadly in public discourse and more specifically in customer experience. We see companies take liberties with customers' time, act as if customers are a burden trying to cheat them and refuse to own and apologize for issues.

The companies that do show this respect understand their role in their customers' lives and remember that nobody cares about their business as much as they do. They're respectful of the time customers must commit to using their product or service, only asking for information or feedback when absolutely necessary. And they treat their customers as fully-functioning, adult humans, presuming the best about them and showing humility when something goes wrong.

Here's some stories to bring this to life…

The Lost Art of Aftersales (Or the importance of only asking for feedback when it's really needed)

We're living in an epidemic of feedback requests. In late 2019, I had to rush my mum to the local A&E in Colchester, Essex. It was as you'd expect an A&E on a Saturday morning to be. A steady stream of people came in, unsteady on their feet due to an array of alcohol- and athletics-induced injuries.

We waited a while, got shunted around between different doctors doing different tests, and were out again within a few hours with a

prescription and a plan to sit on the couch for the rest of the weekend. An hour after we arrived home, I got a message on my phone:

> *'We would like you to think about your recent experience in the Accident and Emergency Department at Colchester General Hospital. How likely are you to recommend our Accident and Emergency Department to your friends and family if they need similar care or treatment?'*

While I've got your attention, let me be really clear with you. If you **ever** find yourself in need of emergency medical support, my strong recommendation is that you go to your *nearest* A&E. If you're in Manchester and break your leg, I don't want you to think '*oh, John said Colchester was good. I know it's a bit of a drive but shall we try there instead?*'

Phone up a call centre:

> *'Please press 1 to complete our survey or press 2 to get on with your life.'*

Buy something online:

> *'How would you rate the experience of navigating through our attempts to apply behavioural economics theory to our checkout process?'*

Or even visit my (brilliant) local Indian restaurant:

> *'Have a free starter. Now, I need a favour. Have you heard of Tripadvisor?'*

Not content with simply sending the emails, organizations regularly send these surveys as if they're a matter of urgency. Google once wrote to me to let me know that it was my *'Last chance! 10 minutes to help improve Google Analytics!'*, presumably hoping I'll see the notification

and decide it's better to be late picking up my son from school than miss this chance of a lifetime to share my thoughts with one of the internet's tech giants.

CX specialist Luis Melo was taken aback by British Airways' request for his time complete with a slightly ominous deadline:

> *'This survey should take around 12 minutes to complete and if you get interrupted, you can return later to pick up where you left off. We would appreciate receiving your feedback in the next few days.'*

And when my over-enthusiastic pensions provider wrote to update me on the changes they were making to their internet portal, the promise wasn't only that this brochure was a 19-minute read, but that it was '*just*' a 19-minute read, as if customers wouldn't be able to believe their luck.

(In fact, to be really pedantic, it said '*designed to take just 19 minutes*' suggesting they had a shorter version ready to go but have evidence that 19 minutes is the optimum time to be spent on such things, so upped it accordingly.)

Moreover, when the feedback is given, it's often ignored. As my insurance policy came up for renewal, I was asked how likely I was to recommend the company. I gave a zero-score given the issues I'd had. I also ticked the box to say I was happy to be contacted to discuss it more. No one called, so I cancelled the renewal and went elsewhere. It turns out my feedback wasn't so important to them after all.

It's completely right that companies should want to try and improve their service and a big part of that is to understand how people are perceiving the experience they're receiving. However, it seems that organizations are outsourcing this responsibility to their customers, making them work hard to get the service they deserve rather than take on the responsibility themselves.

This deluge of feedback surveys creates extra work, extra emails and extra effort for people, generating an unusable volume of data

for organizations to deal with. It would be a better experience for the customer, and more efficient for the organization, if such surveys were used sparingly and only to explore questions that can't be answered elsewhere. These are real-life humans with real-life lives, who would rather spend their time living their lives than giving companies feedback for free – especially when there are so many other ways businesses can find out what they need to know.

Design for the 99 (Or the importance of presuming that most people are honest)

Once a year I embark on a clothing shopping spree. This event is usually heralded by an old favourite suddenly feeling a bit tighter or a raised eyebrow from a colleague that I'm wearing that shirt *again*, signalling the need to dive back into the world of e-commerce and bulk buy enough stuff to get me through the next 12 months.

During one of these recent sprees, I was reminded why Amazon is winning: they design the customer experience based on a belief that people are honest. Because I only buy clothes once a year, I tend to buy a lot and then send back nearly as much. This means a lot of my money floating in the internet while I wait to see if they receive the parcel and give me my refund. Given it's a pretty important moment for a customer, it's surprising how different the experience can be.

The first company I sent bits back to emailed me a few days after I posted the items:

> *'Once your refund is processed, the refunded amount will appear in your account. Please be aware this may take several days.'*

So far, so standard. Not so with the second company. Like the first, they got in touch after a few days to say the parcel had been received. Similarly, they said it could take a few days to send the money back. But

unlike company one, they added a slightly unnecessary note shifting the blame onto the banks:

> *'We've refunded £154.97 to your account. As banks can still be a little slow, it could take up to a week to appear on your account.'*

This really annoyed me so I did what many of us do in this situation and took to Twitter. Somewhat sarcastically, I reminded the company that the banks hadn't stopped them taking my money quickly and that if they really wanted me to have the money sooner, my office was just a few minutes' walk from their HQ, with plenty of cash machines on the walk between the two.

Finally, there was Amazon. I dropped the parcel off at the newsagent's at 9.54 a.m., just in time for the 10 a.m. pick-up. By the time I'd got back to the house just a few minutes later, I had an email from Amazon:

> *'Hello John*
>
> *We've issued your refund for the item below. Your return is now complete.'*

The money was back in my account the next day – seems the banks weren't too slow that time.

Amazon process the refund the minute the package is picked up, knowing it's highly unlikely I'm going to try and rip them off and send them back a box with a brick in it. They also know that even if I have decided to try and steal money from them in this slightly elaborate way, the vast majority of customers won't.

Put simply, Amazon presume the best in us humans (and they know it's more efficient to trust people than to slow the system down for everyone).

Zalando's early success was built on a similar approach of trusting customers, being one of the first in the fashion industry to offer a 100-day returns policy. Interviewed in *The Customer Copernicus*,[37] Filip

[37] Dawson, C. and Meehan, S. (2021) *The Customer Copernicus*, pp.92–3

Dames, Zalando's former chief business development officer, shared the risk and the reality:

> *'The 100-day return policy doesn't economically make sense if you look at the fashion industry in terms of seasonality, stock and turnover. You buy something then three months later, you can return it. It's a lot of trust in the customers.*
>
> *'However, most returns came back within the first two weeks. Only a single-digit percentage of sales were being returned after month one, two, or three. Internally and externally, the 100-day return was a very strong signal about what kind of business we were and how we planned to succeed.'*

In contrast, many companies presume the worst of their customers. Banks design overly secure apps and logon procedures. Train companies charge huge penalties for ticketing mix-ups. Traffic wardens levy outrageous parking fines for putting a zero instead of an 'O' when typing your registration number on the machine.

Maybe that last one is just me.

When I had an issue with my broadband during COVID, an engineer that was speedily sent out told me I needed a new router. He let me know to *'call* [the company] *and they'll send you a new one free of charge, as this is a known fault'*. The call didn't go as planned. The agent said the engineer had left no record of saying that to me. Eventually he agreed to send me a router because, in his words, he wanted '*to give you the benefit of the doubt*'.

That's nice of them, I thought, given I'd been a customer for 12 years.

Are Amazon the best clothes shop? No. Do they give me style advice? No. Do they seem to think I'd like a floral dress because I once bought my mum a Maeve Binchy book? Yes. But one reason Amazon are winning is because they treat me as if I'm a good, honest human, not a crook trying to get away with a free pair of trainers which, combined with their low-effort and low-cost shopping, is a fairly compelling experience.

Sincerely Yours
(Or the importance of showing genuine humility when called for)

A company's tone of voice is hugely important to help build their brand identity but when dealing with a customer's problem, it may well be best to err on the side of caution and be as empathetic and human as possible in the situation.

I used to use one of those social media planning services for my tweets. It claimed it would find the optimum time to post my 140-character thoughts for maximum audience engagement. In hindsight it was entirely unnecessary as I already knew exactly what time my followers looked at Twitter each day, given that she lived in the same house as me. Being a social media start-up, they had a fun and friendly tone of voice. Everything was beyond awesome, cool and exciting, move fast and break things. Then one night, they broke my credit card.

I received a polite email from their CEO saying that they seemed to have had trouble processing my payment and could I be so kind as to check my card was still valid. So far, so good. A helpful email with an easy action. I went online straight away and updated the card details. But something clearly went wrong in cyber space because the requests kept coming.

There were more and more every hour, some kind of digital Groundhog Day. By the time I woke up, my inbox was a copy-and-paste catastrophe:

01.03 a.m. – 'Action required: We couldn't charge your credit card'.
01.03 a.m. – 'Action required: We couldn't charge your credit card.'
01.40 a.m. – 'Action required: We couldn't charge your credit card.'
02.58 a.m. – 'Action required: We couldn't charge your credit card.'
03.44 a.m. – 'Action required: We couldn't charge your credit card.'
04.23 a.m. – 'Action required: We couldn't charge your credit card.'
05.05 a.m. – 'Action required: We couldn't charge your credit card.'
06.29 a.m. – 'Action required: We couldn't charge your credit card.'

Over the next few days, I sent several emails of my own back (resisting the temptation to send the same subject line each time) to try and stop the onslaught. With no help obviously arriving, I decided to hit the big red button, cancelling the subscription, closing my account and clearing my credit card.

Two days later, I received an email from their support team.

'Hey there, John!
Thanks so much for the follow-up, and your patience here.
We'll circle back with an update when it's all fixed up.
You rock, John.'

I'll leave it to your imagination what two-word phrase sprang to my mind in response to their three-word sign-off.

When you're face to face with someone, you can read their emotions, see how their body is reacting and, hopefully, adjust your style accordingly. Even when you're on the phone, a person's tone can give a clue as to how they're feeling. In defence of this particular company, none of these things are available on email. You're sending thoughts into the ether without knowing what frame of mind the person on the other end is going to be in when they receive and read it. But when you've sent someone 24 emails in 24 hours, you can probably have a good guess that telling them they 'rock' isn't going to go down well. Likewise, using nonsense business speak like 'circle back' gives a clue that you're not seeing the world through your customer's eyes.

Eurostar understood this need to show humility brilliantly during the COVID pandemic, putting aside the corporate and convoluted language, and just being honest about the problems they were causing:

'We're writing to apologize once again that you still haven't received your e-vouchers and are sorry for the length of time you've been waiting.

'When you sent us your request, we were confident that you'd have your vouchers within a few weeks. But we have to hold our hands up – we completely underestimated the size of the task we faced. And, despite the tireless efforts of our teams, our systems and processes weren't designed to cope with the thousands upon thousands of requests we received.'

This humility is even more important when the moment has a significant human impact. *The Times*' Patrick Hosking shared a letter he'd discovered from Moss Bros to his father, explaining their failure to have his wedding suits ready as promised:[38]

6th April 1951

Dear Sir

Words fail to express the humility in which I stand for the disgraceful way you were let down. This is the first time such a thing has happened in the history of the Firm, and I can only say that the orders received were phenomenal.

You are very modest in your expressions. Your fee for breach of contract is inadequate – I enclose an extra £5 and ask you and your wife to have a bottle of wine or two on my House, to make up in a small way for our lapse.

I offer my sincere apologies to you and your wife.

Yours faithfully

H.N. Moss

While the fact that customers have problems may not have changed, this letter suggests the humility and humanity with which they are dealt with may have done.

And there isn't a 'You Rock' in sight.

* * *

[38] https://twitter.com/HoskingTheTimes/status/1061233117208498176?s=20

In this chapter, we've heard about a hospital that's desperate to be recommended, a Silicon Valley start-up with a love for automated email and how we're all caught up in the war on clothes-buying criminals.

The average customer can expect to spend around 43 days of their life waiting on hold.[39] That's a month diving in the Maldives, a few weeks travelling on the Trans-Siberian railway or ten re-watches of the whole of *Game of Thrones*. This is bad for customers. And it's bad for companies too, as when placed on hold 60 per cent of us hang up and 30 per cent never call again (although maybe this is what some companies are hoping for).

We've seen this lack of respect for people's time in the endless feedback surveys and creating a mountain of data that is barely used. We've seen that some companies still presume the worst about customers, designing their processes as if they're trying to con them rather than being honest people trying to get on with their lives. And we've seen the difficulty organizations have with properly apologizing when something has gone wrong, holding their hands up and taking responsibility.

The companies in the Showcase (*see also* pages 43–52) understand their role in their customers' lives, being respectful of the time customers must commit to using their product or service, only asking for information or feedback when absolutely necessary. These companies treat their customers as fully-functioning adult humans, presuming the best about them. They recognize when their actions have a real-world human impact, showing humility when something goes wrong and focusing on putting it right. More than anything though, the best organizations remember that nobody cares about their business as much as they do:

'People don't have to turn up, you're not paying people to turn up. You have to be very conscious with your relationships with your donors. If you

[39] https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/hold-up---more-than-80-percent-of-people-are-put-on-hold-every-time-they-contact-a-business-188032061.html

don't get it right first time, they don't come back. We know it takes four good donation experiences before someone would commit to become a regular donor.'

NHSBT

'If something goes wrong, we must do something about it. It starts by trying to understand what happened, not go into denial. If someone can be bothered to complain it's a compliment – that they are bothered to do it rather than just leave.'

Riverford

'When we were starting out, everyone said "nobody engages with energy". But transparent, honest billing is something we wanted to do. So we invented our "Wheel of Fortune". Customers spin the wheel whenever they submit their reading and can win £500 on their account. It's been spun over a million times now and we get customers call us up who want to submit more meter readings. It's a silly little thing, but if you show customers you appreciate the time and effort they're putting in, it goes a long way.'

Octopus Energy

'We always say thank you and have an appreciation of them reporting an issue. We treat every comment with a lot of respect, as they've taken the time to tell us.'

Citymapper

'We learnt how important it was to keep it simple. We were just one part of someone's life. Companies often try to oversell how important they are to someone, but they're not that important. What's important to customers is the simplicity of being able to do what they want to do. If you keep it simple, customers will keep coming back. If you make it complex, then they'll find a reason not to come back because it's just not important

enough to them… we also understood the importance of saying thank you to donors, with the senior team being a big part of this. We would hold 30–40 dinners a year to recognize long-term blood and platelet donors, with over 100 people invited to meet the Director and other donors, and with the press there too. It's about recognition, not reward. They've spent a lot of time supporting us and we just wanted to say thank-you.'

NHSBT

'Be brave and be willing to take risks. But there's nothing more dangerous than people who think they're right, so bravery tempered with self-doubt, encouraging people to question you.'

Riverford

'Never undervalue your customers. A lot of organizations are acquisition-led and think "oh we'll just get another one", but over time that dilutes the brand because people talk. Put some of that marketing investment and time into dealing with your customers, rather than promising something you can't deliver. You'll keep more customers and create genuine ambassadors.'

NHSBT

In summary, being respectful means:

- being conscious of the customer's time;
- being respectful of them as an individual;
- showing humility when it's called for.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Responsible

'We're building something that matters, something that has a real effect on people's lives. That's what drives the whole team. But we're also aware that if we mess up there are real consequences too. People can miss their job interviews or miss their date nights. But it's good if there are things at stake; nothing's more boring than working on something theoretical. Real life is our motivation.'

Citymapper

Being responsible means:

- taking ownership of the experience and problems;
- helping achieve the customer's desired outcome;
- caring for your customer's well-being.

For all the issues we've identified in our relationship with our theoretical partner, one stands out above any other: they don't do the washing up when it's their turn. Instead, they try and weasel their way out of it, coming up with excuse after excuse. You didn't ask them clearly enough, so they didn't realize it was their turn. Your washing up was really important to them, but they were too busy with other things. If you really want the washing up to be done, maybe try doing it yourself? They've left some FAQs to help you on your way.

This lack of responsibility plays out in other areas of your relationship, too. They leave you to sort out any issues in the home rather than

take ownership themselves. They're a bad influence, encouraging you to go out drinking and spend money you don't have. They lie – or, at least, don't tell the whole truth – about things that go wrong.

Doesn't sound great, does it?

Every day, customers interact with hundreds of organizations that help keep their lives on track. Within the first hour of their day, many will already have been impacted by the alarm-clock maker, the water provider, the boiler installer, the bread producer, the electricity supplier, their mobile phone manufacturer, the news creator, several social media platforms and their gym owner.

Each company is a small part of a big jigsaw carefully put together by the customer to help them have the life they want. And as Gil Wedam from Citymapper says at the start of this chapter, everything these companies do, no matter how big or small, matters. Every experience has a knock-on effect on the rest of the customer's day, week and month. Every experience has the potential to make the customer a little bit happier or adds an extra layer of stress. Customers put their trust – and money – in organizations. However, too often that trust isn't repaid.

For the most human companies, the opposite is true. They understand the consequences of their actions and their role in their customers' lives. They accept responsibility for helping the customer achieve the outcome they want and for using their expertise to make decisions on behalf of their customers. And they take responsibility if something goes wrong, not making excuses or blaming the customer, but giving a genuine heartfelt apology when they've made a mistake and a clear explanation as to what happened and why.

Let's hear some stories to bring this to life…

It's Not Me, It's You
(Or the importance of taking ownership of the experience and any problems)

Shortly after Apple launched their Apple Music streaming service, I was trying to convince a friend to switch from Spotify. He tried it but wasn't keen. And when I say 'wasn't keen', I mean 'hated it because it

lost all of his carefully curated playlists during set up'. Feeling brave, I ventured that it was probably more an issue with human error and that if he just spent a little longer using it, it would work just fine for him. At this point he politely rightly reminded me that, a few years ago, it would have 'just worked'. The fact that he had to get used to it was the very reason he wasn't going to use it – Apple should be making it intuitive, like they used to.

This conversation came into my head a few weeks later, at 7.17 a.m. on a Thursday morning, when I was heading from High Wycombe to Solihull. Probably not one of Michael's Portillo's *Great British Railway Journeys*…

Arriving on a cold, wet, windy concourse, I went to buy my ticket from the large blue ticket machine. Destination selected, railcard discount enacted. Eleven ticket options offered.

Eleven.

We've all been in this situation: the confusion, the guess and then the fear. We pick what we think is probably the right ticket then spend the entire journey waiting for the train guard to make their way down the carriage, humiliate us in front of our fellow passengers and then have to re-mortgage our house to buy a new ticket for the remaining five minutes of the journey.

Except this time, I didn't even make it that far.

Having made my guess and paid my money, I grabbed the ticket and headed for the platform. The ticket went into the machine, I walked forward without thinking, timing my steps perfectly to stride through the opening barriers – and immediately bounced back off them into the person behind with such velocity that they nearly spilt their FrappaMappaCino drink all over themselves.

The conversation with the weary and bleary-eyed platform staff was polite and pleasant. He pointed out that my railcard discount wasn't valid before 9 a.m. So, I paid the difference, got my new ticket and was given a form to fill in to refund the original ticket.

Question one: *What is the 'reason for the change of ticket'?*

Quite simply, at 7.17 a.m., it was the machine not being good enough, not being human enough, not being intelligent enough to realize that the only reason I would be buying a ticket for a one-hour journey at that time in the morning was because I was going to use it there and then. It's not the kind of journey you feel the need to pre-book, by two hours, to guarantee your seat, in person, on the platform, regardless of however good the journey from High Wycombe to Solihull may be.

The reason for the change of ticket was that the machine had allowed me to buy the wrong ticket.

It's an experience that's seen all the time, with companies allowing customers to make mistakes, blaming them for the mistake and making them put in the effort (or stump up the money) to correct the mistake.

I once got a polite notice from the Royal Mail informing me that they were impounding some T-shirts I'd ordered from the US due to unpaid custom charges of £35. Having bought lots of things from the company before without the threat of imprisonment, I wrote to them to ask for help. Their reply, suggesting it was the fault of UK Customs for being extra-vigilant, left me less than impressed. As did the offer to refund me half of the original shipping costs, which amounted to the princely sum of £2.43.

Similarly, as hinted at earlier, I once got caught out at a car park Pay and Display for typing in a zero instead of an 'O' for my car registration number, distracted with trying to stop my kids from playing chicken with an oncoming Citroën. Ticket cost? £1.40. Fine for the error? £120 (reduced to £60 if paid promptly).

What's undeniable is that, in each of these situations, the customer is at fault. I bought the ticket, I ordered the T-shirts and I typed the wrong number into the machine.

Human beings are fallible and regularly make mistakes. Understanding this will help companies build more fool-proof processes. This is a far better use of time than blaming mistakes on time-poor customers, chasing them for fines and leaving a bitter taste in their mouths when they get punished for their error. Put simply,

if a customer makes a mistake, it's the company's fault for making it possible for the customer to make a mistake.

So, own up and own the problem.

Show Me the Money
(Or the importance of explaining what happened)

Sometime in the middle of 2012, seduced by Great Britain's Olympic success, surprised by my 30th birthday and suggestible to my friends' ideas, I started cycling to work. It's true what they say, you never forget how to ride a bike. However, while it might be easy to remember how to ride a bike, it's less easy to fix one when it inevitably breaks.

I have a toothbrush to clean the chain, leave the house with at least three types of spare inner tube and even pay people who know what they're doing to regularly service the thing. It was during one of those annual services that I was reminded that, when things go wrong for customers, the resolution isn't all about the money.

Having lugged the bike up the stairs (not the most customer-friendly shop layout, but possibly useful to stop shoplifters), I chose a service level, mentioned the funny noise the chain was making, then disappeared for a few hours before returning later to collect it. That's when the problems started:

Me: 'Hi, I'm here to collect my bike.'

Bike guy: 'Oh yeah, we couldn't find anything wrong with it.'

'Okay, did you do the service?'

'What service?'

'I brought it in for a service.'

'Erm… oh yeah, er… we did that.'

'Right… what did you do to it?'

'Let me just pump up the tyres for you.'

'How much do I owe you?'

'Nothing, we didn't do anything to it.'

Clearly, this wasn't how I'd dreamed the conversation would go, but I rode my bike out happily enough with harder tyres and a full wallet.

Then, a clunk.

Another one.

Then another, and another, and another.

As any cyclist will tell you, your bike making a new, strange noise is not welcome. I wasn't angry, just disappointed. A phone call, a few tweets, an email, another call and someone finally got in touch to let me know what had happened. Except, they didn't. Instead, the caller protested a bit too much that no records are kept of what happens to bikes when they visit, and there was no CCTV, so they couldn't explain it. But they were sorry, sorry enough to offer me a £10 gift voucher if I'd like to accept that and stop calling them.

We'd yet to even establish what they were saying sorry for, exactly. And that's what I really wanted to know. Not just so I could work out the problem and fix it, but so I knew they cared enough to make sure it wasn't going to happen again.

Weeks later, after more calls and emails, there was still no explanation as to why my bike came out worse than it went in. They did up their offer of apology to £50 though, which suggests either the damage was five times worse than they originally thought, or they were getting really fed up with me calling.

As important as it is to reimburse financial loss, to keep using a company after they've had a problem, most people require some kind of emotional reassurance. They need certainty that the problem isn't likely to occur again, that the company knows what went wrong and how they can fix it.

A gift voucher, while nice to have, doesn't do that.

Conversely, I recently had an Uber driver who decided it was okay to drive through a red light across three lanes of traffic, completely oblivious to the carnage he was leaving in his wake. I complained to Uber and within minutes the money for the trip was heading back into my account. More importantly, a few days later, details of what steps the driver had been asked to take to improve his driving arrived in my inbox.

Even more impressive is this explanation the Royal Mail gave to designer Dan Lockton, when a letter arrived late and damaged:[40]

> *'Dear Customer*
>
> *I am sorry that the enclosed letter has been damaged and subsequently delayed.*
>
> *The item was found during a scheduled collection from a posting box and had been damaged by snails. Fortunately, despite regular cleaning and placing pellets in the boxes, we find that slugs and snails still occasionally manage to creep into the apertures, fall down into the box, and start eating the glue on the stamps and envelopes.*
>
> *I am sorry for any problems caused by this unusual "tampering" and while I am pleased to be able to return your letter, albeit in a damaged condition, I regret the understandable annoyance caused.'*

Mistakes happen, things break, no one is perfect, but if an organization's default response is to offer money without understanding what went wrong, then they should expect a constant cycle of mistakes, complaints and compensation. While in the short term it may seem quicker and easier to offer a tenner and hope the problem goes away, in the long run the money, time and damage to a company's reputation will add up. And if you're the customer, think twice before accepting the compensation without getting an explanation – you might just be setting yourself up for more bad experiences in the future.

Far From Home
(Or the importance of staying focused on helping the customer achieve their outcome)

As life returned to normal after the early months of the COVID pandemic, I was reminded of the importance of companies focusing

[40] https://twitter.com/imaginari_es/status/1321872004182659073

on customer outcomes, rather than functional tasks. Going back into London meant rekindling my relationship with train companies. It's a little like being apart from someone where absence makes the heart grow fonder. Then, when you do meet again, you are reminded of all the little irritations and major annoyances that your brain had cleverly blanked out.

One evening, my train home was delayed, delayed, delayed… until right at the last moment, it was cancelled. This had a big real-world impact on me. It was a school parents' evening and I had to be at home, so I jumped in a taxi to just make it home in time. As you'd expect of me by now, I wrote to give some 'feedback': I suggested that it would be better to announce the inevitable cancellation earlier, so that I could have jumped into the cab with more time to spare.

The reply was interesting:

> *'If you had arrived at your destination more than 15 minutes late via one of our trains, you could have applied for Delay Repay.'* [a refund on my ticket]

But I didn't want my money back, I wanted to be home in time for my child's parents' evening. While I had a human, emotional problem, they were giving me a robotic, functional solution.

Along the same lines was a letter my wife received out-of-the-blue from her bank a few weeks ago:

> *'Dear Mrs Sills, We're writing to let you know that we've recently reviewed the overdraft on your joint account and have decided to reduce it.'*

Nothing wholly unusual about that – banks are well within their rights to change these things. It was slightly confusing though as she'd had this overdraft for 15 years and never once gone over the limit. Once again, I put pen (fingers) to paper (laptop) to find out why.

In the middle of a very polite letter back, one line stood out:

'It's because you don't use it.'

This is another great example of focusing on the functional experience at the expense of the emotional; of focusing on the task itself, not the overall outcome the customer wants.

Functionally, we don't use the overdraft so from the bank's perspective, of course it makes sense to reduce it and reduce their lending exposure (albeit ironically, my wife did then receive an email offer of a low-rate personal loan a week later).

Emotionally, however, we use the overdraft all the time. That account has our salary going into it and, more importantly, all our bills going out. Each month, the magical mystical Direct Debit machine whirs into life and seamlessly sends money flying all around the financial system to keep our lights on, our home insured and our car on the road. If, one month, there was a delay on my salary, the whole thing would completely collapse. Payments would be missed, Direct Debits cancelled and a whole sea of red-headered letters would arrive on my doorstep with cautions and charges to contend with. But we don't need to worry about this because we have that overdraft. Every month, we mentally use it to relax, to remove any potential stress or concern of something going wrong.

Removing an 'unused' overdraft because it's in the T&Cs is functionally fine but doing so without consideration for the real reason a customer might use it, and the emotional impact such a decision might have, removes the humanness from the relationship.

Similarly, while offering refunds for disrupted travel is useful and needed, too often it's used as a get-out-of-jail card for companies who fail to deliver what they promised. It makes it acceptable to not deliver, with a satisfactory outcome being that no one is out of pocket – rather than the customer having achieved the outcome they wanted. Although now we don't have an overdraft, maybe that train ticket refund will come in handy after all.

* * *

In this chapter, there have been tales of early-morning confusion at High Wycombe train station, a secretive bike shop who'll pay for your silence and a rail company who'd rather refund your money than return you home. If you think back to the last great customer experience you had, the one you tell people about over dinner (presuming your dinners, like mine, revolve around swapping hilarious anecdotes about customer face-palm moments), I'm going to bet that it involves a human. More than that, I'm going to bet it involved a human who stepped up and took responsibility in a situation where you really needed some help. The person who helped when your flight got cancelled. The mortgage advisor who somehow got a chain of six buyers to agree a moving date. The call centre agent who managed to untangle the online mess you'd got yourself into.

Companies are expected to be responsible in all sorts of ways now. Responsible for their role in protecting the planet, responsible in how they manage their shareholders' money, responsible in how they look after their colleagues… Yet as important – perhaps more important – is how they treat their customers, the people who are paying to use their product and service. If this responsibility is clear at the top of the organization, it will filter down and encourage every member of the team to demonstrate that individual responsibility for the customers they're dealing with.

As we saw earlier, it's not unusual for companies to give a great welcome experience, only to go missing once the sale is made. When a problem occurs, many companies prefer to make excuses rather than accept responsibility, or pay customers compensation and hope they go away, as we saw with my broken bicycle. Sometimes they prefer to pass the blame onto customers, as with my confusing train ticket, rather than doing all they can to help customers achieve their outcomes.

Conversely, the companies in our Showcase (*see also* pages 43–52) take their responsibility to customers seriously, understanding the true human impact their actions and decisions have on real people's real lives. They do the right thing for customers:

'Treat every customer as if they were your own gran. And when you're spending company money and making decisions, ask "would your mum be proud of the decision you've made?"'

AO.com

'Our approach was that complaints should be owned by whoever had been involved in the issue in the first place, rather than have a generic team replying. Therefore, we just had a small complaints team who were coordinators, making sure complaints were owned and resolved quickly by the local team responsible.… You should never ignore customers or try to make excuses if they have an issue. At the end of the day, it is the companies' fault because they haven't been able to do what they said they'd do. Take the blame for it not working and try and be honest. If companies treat people like adults, they'll respond like adults.'

NHSBT

'Every operational person is authorised to go and make things right for customers, whatever that means. We see a lot of initiative, much more than if we said "a complaint is worth £x". Things like ordering a Deliveroo for people to their home if something has gone wrong with their pre-payment meter, so they have warm food and supplies. It's about giving autonomy, empathy and thinking through the situation from the customer's perspective.'

Octopus Energy

'We have the "Report Issue" button on the app. Every single page has an outlet for if things go wrong.… And you always have this "Get Me Home" button that can take care of you, no matter where you are.'

Citymapper

'We brought in a new system for the complaints team that if we wrote to a customer and they weren't happy with the response, we would then have to phone them. You need the human intervention to understand how to put this right. It made a huge difference. Customers understood we were human as well and make mistakes, and the phone call was great at showing we genuinely cared. Some companies approach complaints as "what does the customer want?" but sometimes they don't want anything. They're just angry and want to know we care about the fact they're angry. Most companies have a complaints process or a customer charter but it needs to be more, it needs to be showing we are really sorry.'

Chiltern Railways

In summary, being responsible means:

- taking ownership of the experience and problems;
- helping achieve the customer's desired outcome;
- caring for your customer's well-being.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Straightforward

'We found out through research that people were interested in the process of blood donation and particularly with what happened to their blood after they'd given it so we developed a system that would send donors a text to tell them which hospital their blood had gone to… People were excited to track what was happening and see their blood travelling 300 miles to get to a hospital.'

NHSBT

Being straightforward means:

- providing certainty of what's going to happen and when;
- speaking in jargon-free human language;
- creating an adult-to-adult relationship.

Let's return one final time to our inaccessible, inconsistent, inflexible, reactive, disrespectful, irresponsible partner (who'll need some serious help with their Tinder profile!). It turns out they also keep secrets from you, with their opinions changing daily, dependent on which friend or follower they're talking to. They struggle with difficult or grown-up conversations, happy to chat about football or Netflix but less so about money and children. To feel superior, they use long, complicated words, old historical references and even occasionally slip into Latin. To explain this behaviour, they describe themselves as 'complicated', but more as a badge of honour than as something to change. For this –

and many other reasons – you might decide that this person is just too much like hard work to be with.

Relationships are meant to be a positive thing, to lift you up, improve your life, make things better. Yet often, relationships with organizations can feel the opposite of that. It can be like having a second job, a separate to-do list, another email inbox account just to manage to daily flow of special offers, document notifications and requests for feedback. Worse, some organizations can make customers feel uncertain, confused or patronized, forced to try and understand complicated processes or legal regulations. The language used can be impenetrable to normal people, with companies continuing to use it 'because that's the way it's always been done'. It can be hugely frustrating for customers not to be told the whole truth, to sense that something is being hidden from them, as we saw earlier with my broken bike experience.

Conversely, the most human companies are those that are the most straightforward to deal with. No complicated language, no hidden fees, no confusing processes. They create a sense of certainty, with customers being able to understand what is happening, when and why. They're open, letting customers into their processes and plans and revealing the humans behind the products. If problems occur, there's no denial, no excuses, just an honest, adult-to-adult approach and commitment to put things right. And the leaders – and therefore, the companies – all have an air of authenticity. No PR spin, no marketing shine, happy to share their opinions and be challenged about their approach.

Let's find out more about being straightforward.

In Search of Certainty (Or the importance of making customers feel safe and secure)

In hindsight, our waitress was excellent. She smiled, saw us to our table and introduced herself by name. The drinks arrived quickly. Later, as I placed the just-empty glass on the table, she was there immediately,

ready to offer a top-up. But when it came to ordering the food, she did *that* thing. The one where, rather than pulling out a notepad and diligently writing down the complex combination of fajitas, burritos and guacamole-topped nachos we'd agonized over, she just stood and listened. Nodding as we spoke, staring intently, but steadfastly refusing to write anything down.

As the six of us threw in our complicated extra cheese/no mushrooms/not-too-spicy requests, the tension was rising around the table. Nervous glances were being exchanged. Our waitress, however, maintained a fixed and smiley expression the whole time, presumably building a platter-picture in her head filled with chicken wings, mini-tacos and several sides of patatas bravas. Of course, when our food arrived, the order was perfect. We needn't have worried, but we did.

As impressive as our waitress was, this was a great reminder of how much we crave certainty in our lives. If she'd been slightly less competent and used a notepad, we'd all have been happier with the experience (even if she'd been using the notepad to doodle caricatures of us while committing the order to memory anyway).

I had a more stressful reminder a few months later too, when buying a new house. On the day of exchange, our solicitor called early in the morning to say there was an issue: our buyer was having problems getting home insurance sorted, so might have to pull out. She'd let me know, she said.

At 3 p.m., after hours of unanswered calls and untold stress, I finally got through to her. '*Sorry,*' she said, '*it's been really busy here. All fine in the end, the exchange happened this morning, as planned. Congratulations!*' I now know what it feels like to be simultaneously outraged and overjoyed.

This is a universal desire too, as I discovered when I analyzed the complaints handling approach for a global organization. All of the 20 global markets had measures in place for how quickly the complaint had to be acknowledged and resolved, the things the regulator cared about. Yet speaking to customers, they were more concerned about the

complaint being handled properly than quickly and just wanted to be kept up to date and to know what was happening, even if the update was '*we're still investigating and haven't forgotten you*'.

How many countries had a measure for how often to keep the customer informed? None. Subsequently, complaints were closed quickly and then reopened just as quickly when the customer said they were unhappy with the answer.

Poor for the customer and costly for the organization.

When we humans lack certainty, our imagination is left to fill in the blanks. We might imagine things positively, building huge excitement (like how good the nachos are going to taste). Or we may picture things negatively, worrying about the things that might go wrong (like how late we're going to be to the theatre and that I'm going to have to eat mushrooms).

Paul Dolan talks about this in his book *Happiness by Design*[41], arguing that the only way to change that feeling is to replace the blanks with knowledge:

> '*In situations where you face uncertainties, it will almost certainly be better to turn them into adapted realities. Do you have an unopened bill that's bothering you? Then open it.*'

This worry-reduction-through-managing-expectations is far from a new thought. Valarie Zeithaml was writing about 'Zones of Tolerance' back in 1991.[42] In their 2011 paper 'The Labor Illusion',[43] Ryan W. Buell and Michael I. Norton discuss the notion of 'Operational Transparency', or how giving customers information of what's happening behind the scenes not only helps to improve their

[41] Dolan, P. (2015) *Happiness by Design*. Penguin.

[42] https://www.researchgate.net/profile/Valarie-Zeithaml-2/publication/225084143_Understanding_Customer_Expectations_of_Service/links/02e7e53cd16b876407000000/Understanding-Customer-Expectations-of-Service.pdf

[43] https://www.jstor.org/stable/41261916?seq=1#metadata_info_tab_contents

experience, but increases their perception of value, too. And Matt Watkinson highlighted 'Set and then meet expectations' as one of his ten principles behind great customer experiences.[44]

Pleasingly, more organizations are now doing something about it and more than that are recognizing that managing expectations doesn't just have to be about worry reduction but can help with the excitement building part of people's imaginations, too.

The easyJet airline set the trend by showing waiting passengers exactly how far their plane was from the airport on its way to collect them, removing the pain of watching the big board of flights and giving a countdown to when their holiday would begin. And now these maps are everywhere, with delivery companies in particular showing the journey your brave intrepid parcel is on that day. They notify you when the journey started (mine was a late riser at 8.23 a.m.), what stop the driver is currently at and what number stop you are. It's like the Santa NORAD tracker, but with a person who leaves the parcel outside rather than breaking and entering.

I find it utterly enthralling. Grab the popcorn, take a seat and watch the action unfold – an immersive *Postman Pat* experience for the whole family to enjoy. Have I got time to get to the shop and back before he gets here? Why is he taking so long at number 38? What could they have ordered?! He's only two stops away! Quick, kids, get to the window and look out for them!

It doesn't change the functional experience of the parcel arriving, but it does improve the human, emotional experience a little bit. It's replacing some of the excitement that used to come with buying stuff in a shop, sitting on the train surrounded by bags and eagerly unwrapping them all when you get home.

Technology has made managing expectations and giving customers the certainty they crave easier than ever. But why stop there when you can have a little fun with it too? If it's good enough for Santa…

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[44] Watkinson, M. (2012) *The Ten Principles Behind Great Customer Experiences*. FT Press.

Showing the Plumbing
(Or the importance of speaking in jargon-free language)

Mario should be an easy game to complete. You start with the straightforward aim of getting to the other side and raising a flag. All you have to do is walk over some hills and you're there. Except, it's not that simple.

Every few steps something gets in your way, making you jump a bit higher, run a bit faster, or pound the ground in desperation. Often, the only way to complete the level is to go down some pipes, finding a route around these problems that makes the whole thing take twice as long. Of course, you don't mind when it's *Mario*. It's a game, it's meant to be challenging, meant to test your patience and take several attempts to give that well-earned sense of satisfaction at the end.

But being a customer, while hopefully enjoyable, isn't meant to be a challenge. Yet like *Mario*, some organizations make going into the depths of their plumbing the only route available for customers to reach their goal. Take, for example, the conversation I had with my broadband provider when my internet crashed hours before a big Zoom presentation:

'Hello, my broadband has stopped working, could you help me, please?'
'Sure! We'll check the line for you. What's your landline number?'
'Oh, I don't have a landline, I just use my mobile.'
'Ah, everyone still has a landline number, even if you don't have the phone.'
'Right. I don't know it.'
'Okay, we'll need your landline number.'
'But I don't know… [etc, etc]'

This is a great example of 'showing the plumbing': the way that organizations force onto customers their inner processes, their legacy systems and language whose origins are long-since forgotten. In this

case, it's an archaic attachment to a landline number as the secret to broadband success, despite not having used a landline for several years.

This same company invites potential new customers to call its 'Acquisition Team' – because as humans, we all want to be acquired (as much as we want to be 'retained').

On a more humorous note, I recently decided to stop selecting the completely meaningless 'Mr' when online shopping, instead preferring 'Revd', 'Sir' or 'Lord' in the hope of entertaining our mail carrier. One time when those weren't available, I just selected the blank option, leading to receiving a package addressed to:

Unspecified John Sills

After posting this on Instagram, I immediately received more brilliant examples including:

Prefer Not To Say Philippa Kelly

and

To Other Mom and Dad

However, the Boss Level of this – if I'm going to try and stretch the *Mario* analogy further than I should – is the banking industry. This is a text message I received from my bank one morning:

*AC ****8767 20NOV 08:31*
'You are using your arranged overdraft but have not been charged arranged interest as your arranged borrowing is within the interest-free amount.'

Most people consider that they have money, they spend money and they save money. Some money they spend now, some they save to

spend later and some they spend now, knowing they'll pay for it a bit later.

In the banking world, this means at least three accounts. Three lots of 16-digit numbers to remember. Three bits of plastic to carry around and not get confused between, each of which does a slightly different job with different rates and benefits. There may be joint accounts, household accounts and a range of savings accounts for DIY days, holidays and rainy days. All of these will have a mixture of direct debits and standing orders, overdrafts, APRs and ISAs. These are words and phrases that only exist within the boundaries of banking, far removed from a real person's real life.

Similarly, in the overly-long saga with my insurance company, the language used in their emails was unintelligibly un-human:

> *'We have updated the schedule following our contractor's visit. We will be involved in any reinstatement on a like-for-like basis through our Network contractor or a cash settlement to you. Our Network contractor has delegated authority in this regard.'*

'Schedule', 'Network Contractor', 'Delegated Authority'… These are phrases that make sense inside the business, but real people don't use them day-to-day, so simply add a layer of confusion as to what's going on. Something like the following would probably suffice:

> '*We've updated the plan. The company we're working with to replace your floor have the authority to make the repairs or give you the money back.*'

This isn't to say that organizations should go to the other extreme of being overly-friendly or casual in their communication; the tone of voice they use is very much up to the organization and the personality it wants to project. But whether the tone is super serious or friend-next-door, companies would do well to keep their plumbing hidden

and let customers have a straightforward run to the end of the level – and maybe collect a few gold coins on the way.

Sorry Seems to Be the Easiest Word (Or the importance of creating an adult-to-adult relationship)

I was scanning some bananas through the self-service till at my local Tesco when I noticed an advert for their new Tesco Pay service. It's an app you can download, attach your credit card to and use to pay with your phone. So, just like Apple Pay then – except with an extra app to download.

Not unsurprisingly, I thought to myself, *why would they do this when Apple Pay exists?* As is so often the case when I have question that my wife doesn't care about, I put it on Twitter:

> *'I wonder why @Tesco think that this will be a better option for customers than using Apple/Android Pay?'*

Then a strange thing happened: Tesco replied:

> *'When you download the app, you get Clubcard points. Just trying to make it as easy for our customers as possible. Sorry for any offence caused. Thanks.'*

'Sorry for any offence caused'? I'm all for trigger-finger social media managers getting involved 'in the conversation' and appreciate them giving an explanation but being offended was really a very long way down my list of thoughts and feelings I had while in Tesco that day. There was nothing I could see that required any kind of apology. Of course, as soon as this happened, and in line with well-known human biases, I started spotting examples everywhere.

The next day, on a train to Norwich, a particularly apologetic train guard announced his regret that there would be no announcement

about our arrival at the next station where we'd be arriving in a few minutes' time. Perhaps thinking he hadn't quite managed to calm our collective anger enough, he then apologized for us getting to Norwich one minute late, hoping it hadn't caused us any inconvenience – he'd clearly never been on a train in the UK.

A few days later, I posted on Instagram a receipt from McDonald's, which alongside the list of food I'd ordered had an itemized entry of 'No Thanks' and a price of '£0' (I added the comment 'Politeness costs nothing' which I was particularly pleased with).

Their reply?

> *'Hi John, sorry to hear this. Please DM us with more information (including the restaurant this was and the date and time of visit) so we can look into this further.'*

This epidemic of apology is captured by the website *sorryfortheinconvenience.co.uk*, tracking how often travel companies say sorry in real time. Within the first three months of 2019 alone, the word had been typed over 120,000 times by companies desperate to avoid a complaint catastrophe.

The problem with this, as the NBER study 'Toward an Understanding of the Economics of Apologies'[45] shows, is that over-apologizing can have a detrimental effect on a company's reputation, particularly when not matched with actually resolving the issue:

> *'An apology acts as a promise [of] better outcomes in the future. When those higher expectations go unmet, the firm reputation suffers more than if no apology had been tendered at all. Apologies should therefore be used after outcomes that are unlikely to repeat again in the future.'*

Apologizing when something goes wrong is the right thing to do, but if used too often, the word becomes meaningless, leading to the

[45] https://www.nber.org/papers/w25676

relationship between company and customer becoming less human, edging further away from straightforward adult-to-adult and more like a parent constantly scolding a child.

I don't want a child looking after my money, energy, or weekly food shop.

Ecotricity demonstrated how to do it the right way when explaining their recent price increase. There wasn't a 'sorry' in sight (except for the one about energy regulator Ofgem), just a clear and careful explanation for why this is the way it is:

'We work hard to keep our energy prices stable; we make our own electricity from the wind and the sun and plans to make our own gas from grass are well advanced. We use our customers' energy bills to continually build more new sources of green energy, a unique approach we like to describe as "Bills into Mills".

We also fix our wholesale prices well in advance and absorb any unavoidable increases for as long as we're able to.

There are of course elements beyond our control and a number of these have been moving in the past twelve months. We've seen a combination of rising wholesale costs, along with the costs of delivery (using the national and local grids to get our energy to your home) and regulatory costs. The industry regulator Ofgem has estimated that total costs have increased by 5.6 per cent to supply a dial fuel customer in just the past six months.

We've reached the point where we need to increase our energy prices. For dual fuel, that's an increase of 4.8 per cent, or about £1 per week for a typical customer. It's our intention to hold these prices until at least next April.

There are more details below. I'm sorry about the way it's presented. I personally don't think it's easy to understand and would like to do this differently, but this format is mandated by Ofgem.

I hope this short note will be helpful. If you do need further information, please reply to this email.
Thank you for being with us.'

Wonderfully honest, wonderfully straightforward, and wonderfully human…

If there is a problem, the company should own it, explain it and resolve it. If not, they should stand up for what's right and have a human conversation with their customer, building a better relationship as they do.

Sorry for any inconvenience that causes.

* * *

In this chapter we've heard about an impressive waitress who accidentally creates worry, a broadband company recreating a level on *Mario* and an easily offended supermarket social media team. Being straightforward to deal with is perhaps the most important behaviour of all of those that could deliver a human customer experience.

Running a business is hard. Not everything can be simple, mistakes will be made, things can go wrong, but acting in an open, honest, straightforward way makes it more likely that the relationship with customers will stay strong regardless of any issues or errors that occur and feel more like a partnership than parenting. Customers don't necessarily want to know every part of the process, to be exposed to all the inner workings of an organization, but they do want to understand what's going on and not be made to feel stupid, which is why the simplest and most impactful first step in creating a human experience is to use human language.

Acquisition, Average Wait Time, Revenue Income, Current Account, Net Promoter… These all reveal an internal way of thinking that customers shouldn't need to see. More than that, using this kind of language within an organization drives a certain culture and behaviour: a belief that customers are to be 'acquired', that the average experience is what matters, that people think in terms of 'accounts'. Changing this language internally is as, if not more, important than simply changing customer communications and processes. It will help shift the whole mindset to one that naturally thinks and talks

about customers in a more human way, thereby affecting every other element of the experience from the point it's created to the moment it's measured.

What was clear when speaking to the people in our Showcase (*see also* pages 43–52) was that this comes from the top. Each person was easy to talk to, honest in their answers and straightforward in their beliefs. There was no jargon, no complicated strategies or frameworks, no business speak. Getting this right means products and processes will start being designed in a more human way, colleagues are empowered to be themselves and customers feel more connected to the company. Then we can all spend a bit less time moaning about missing messages and a bit more time messing about with *Mario*:

'We found out through research that people were interested in the process of blood donation and particularly with what happened to their blood after they'd given it. So we developed a system that would send donors a text to tell them which hospital their blood had gone to. For about 6 months, 25 per cent of all of our Facebook postings were just about this, with people posting their text and showing where their blood had gone to, especially if it had gone to a children's hospital. It was a customer experience idea in the first place but became a great marketing tool. It cost us very little, but value-wise it was probably the best promotion we ever did.

'From that, the in-app mapping system was developed, to give customers more information. We integrated Google Maps to show them the journey the blood was on, from the donation site, then to the manufacturers, then finally to the hospital. People were excited to track what was happening and see their blood travelling 300 miles to get to a hospital.

'It was a simple thing to do, but the feedback was amazing. The value was immense and people who used it were far more likely to become ambassadors for us.'

NHSBT

'We want people to bring their whole selves to work. I don't want anyone to be a clone. There's lots of lovely things about some well-respected department stores, but it's like they come out of a factory, like The Matrix. *They wear the same suits, same shoes, same glasses. It's extraordinary. The question is, can we have fairness and good governance without becoming boring and risk averse?'*

Riverford

'Be transparent about what you're building, let the guards down a bit. We're open about our process and you can really feel the company… I think the humanness, such as the "Easter eggs" [in the app], remind the user that there's real people building this product, there's a team behind this product, that has some personality.'

Citymapper

'I was sitting in a park in Bristol with my daughter and her uni friends. There was a Co-op supermarket over the road and her friends went there to buy some croissants, avoiding the Tesco that was closer. I asked why and their reply was not because it was a Co-op. They said what mattered were the human relationships they had with the people in the shops. We are emotional beings, 90 per cent of the time we're making emotional decisions, and you have to engage with people on an emotional level. I think it'll become a key determinant of success.'

Riverford

'That's where the humanness comes in, it's a core belief that humanising a serious space and how our product emotionally connects to the user is a core part of how we think about our product. People should feel they're in this with the team together.'

Citymapper

'To have integrity, I think you must be personal, to show yourself. It's about authenticity. The closer you get to the organization it should look the same as it does with a tangential glance. Same on the inside as the outside.'

Riverford

In summary, being straightforward means:

- providing certainty of what's going to happen and when;
- speaking in jargon-free human language;
- creating an adult-to-adult relationship.

PART FOUR

The Five Enablers

In which I suggest a few ways of working that organizations need to consistently create a human customer experience.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Ambition

'It's a matter of ambition. We're all here to build the best product of our careers. It's challenging, but rewarding. It matters to excel at what you do. Raise your own bar really high.'

Citymapper

Acting with ambition means:

- having self-set standards for customer success;
- striving for the highest standards, consistently;
- improving the whole industry on behalf of customers.

When I worked in the banking industry, I used to say that no company was ever more than three months ahead of the other in terms of new ideas and innovations. Each UK high street bank measured its customer experience performance against the competition. The service levels were comparable, all averaging around seven out of 10, and so the challenge was to be at the top of that group. Any new ideas or innovations that did appear in one of the banks would be copied by all the others within a few months.

This situation is more pronounced in regulated or nationalized industries. The overseeing body will set a benchmark score for companies to reach and a selection of experiences to measure them against. While this often leads to improved performance in those areas, it also tends to have the unfortunate side effect of a much worse performance in the areas where the regulator has decided not to measure.

This approach has always amazed me. In the first example, the banks are 'satisfied' with 30 per cent of their customers being unhappy. *Thirty per cent!* This seems a remarkably high figure. In the second example, customers are faced with huge inconsistency, with the experience they receive being completely dependent on whether their issue is something a random regulator has decided is important or not that month. A lack of ambition is often also at fault for great ideas never making it to market, falling foul to the Descent to Average.

The first sign of this descent is usually when presenting the ideas to the senior team. The concepts are acknowledged as great and certainly what should be being done. They wonder, though, what the 'quick wins' could be from some of these?

Next, the business case. Sure, it would make customers happier, but does it make enough money? Could we find a way of delivering it slightly cheaper and maybe with less IT involved?

After that, the legal and compliance teams have their say. They're great ideas and we'd love to do them if we could. But they're quite different from what we've done before, so how about we tone them down a bit, just to be safe?

Finally, accountability. In his book, *Risk Savvy*[46], German psychologist Gerd Gigerenzer warns of 'defensive decision making', an affliction affecting between a third and a half of all important decisions made in large companies.[47] The manager in question feels she should go with option A but worries if something goes wrong, she would be held solely responsible so she goes for a less good option for the company, but one that protects her against negative consequences. What comes out the other side is an idea barely better than what you currently have, an incremental improvement and a demotivating feeling of disappointment for those involved.

As has been seen in the banking industry, just trying to be the best of an average bunch, delivering ideas barely better than you currently have, leaves you open to disruption from the outside. In the UK, Monzo

[46] Gigerenzer, G. (2015) *Risk Savvy: How To Make Good Decisions*. Penguin.
[47] *Risk Savvy*, G. Gigerenzer, pp.43–66

and Starling Bank appeared on the scene with a customer experience that far surpassed what was currently on offer and left the incumbents struggling to catch up. When you've been sat idle for so long, it's hard to get moving again. Which, ironically, was the situation I found myself in, just before the best customer experience I've ever received.

See You in Zurich (Or the importance of consistently aiming for the highest standards)

Back in early 2020, days before the world was put into lockdown, I found myself on a train flying through the Swiss countryside. I was with a group of 30 septuagenarians who were on a two-week rail holiday, doing some research into what made their experience great and what could be better. One of my colleagues is from Geneva and, when she found out I was going, repeated what we're all told about the Swiss railway system: wonderfully efficient, best in the world, incredibly reliable. So, within seconds of the emergency brakes bringing the train to a shuddering halt, I was mentally preparing my sarcastic messages to my Swiss friend and my angry messages to the Swiss Federal Railways Twitter team: train broken down, we're going to miss the connection, no one has any idea what's going on… typical Swiss inefficiency. But before I had the chance to hit send, something unexpected happened – or at least, unexpected to those of us who frequently travel on UK trains.

The train manager, fresh from giving an update over the intercom, appeared in our carriage and made a beeline for our tour manager. He sat with us and, without hesitation, apologized. Not one of the previously mentioned 'sorry for the inconvenience' apologies, but a proper, hand-on-heart, human apology for letting us down and for the problems this was going to cause for a large group of tourists hoping to enjoy a stress-free holiday.

I thought that was pretty impressive but I didn't realize that he was just getting started. He laid out exactly what would happen next. Our revised time into Zurich. The next train that we could get to replace our missed connection. The platform it would leave from and the quickest

way to get to it. Then he disappeared to the next carriage to speak to more passengers.

As the group were chatting among themselves about how good the train manager was, the tour manager's phone rang. He looked serious, then surprised, then delighted:

'I've got an update, everybody.'

We all listened intently:

'That was one of the Swiss Rail Operations Managers. He's reserved us a whole carriage on the next train so we don't have to worry about finding seats together.'

Before too long we were in Zurich, clear and confident on which train and which platform we were heading to. Not that we needed to be, of course. As the train doors opened, a station manager was there to greet us. She escorted us to the new train, leading us to the exact carriage that was reserved for our group.

Once we were all on board, the new train manager came along to check we were settled and, given the problems we'd had, gave us all free drinks vouchers for use on the trains at any point during the rest of the holiday.

When the train broke down, it was 14.30 p.m. When we got on the new train, it was 15.45 p.m. If I'm honest, I kind of wanted it to go on a bit longer to see what else would happen. Free money? A train each? The Freedom of the City of Zurich? It felt like being in a real-life version of Monty Python's 'The Dirty Fork' sketch.

This story may seem like a one-off, an exception to the rule or to what's possible for most businesses, but even if the scale is hard to replicate, the basics of what Swiss Federal Railways did to resolve our problem were simple: they owned the issue. No half-cut apology about things out of their control – *'you're on our train, we've promised to get*

you somewhere and we're not going to deliver on it.' Instead, *'We're sorry. Actually, genuinely sorry. This is our fault.'*

They explained the problem. This is what's happened, and this is why it's happened. A real human, adult-to-adult conversation which shows that they understand the issue without hiding behind policies, processes or an evasive *'you're not allowed to know that'*. They solved the problem. Not the functional problem of fixing the train but the human problem of us getting from A to B in a relaxed way. There was no suggestion we should fend for ourselves. Instead, a real sense that they wanted to deliver the outcome they'd promised.

Humans crave certainty and while making big marketing promises or giving a great service helps to build trust, seeing an organization react brilliantly when something goes wrong is what really reinforces that certainty in a customer's mind.

Before I got on that faulty train to Zurich, I was fairly certain, based on their brand reputation and individual recommendations, that Swiss Federal Railways would get me there on time. Having seen the reality in action – the genuine humility and apology, the explanation and communication, the ownership and determination – I'm now more certain than ever that they'll always deliver what they promise, even if something goes wrong. That broken-down train was more valuable than anything their marketing department could conjure up – and it will probably save some poor embattled social media manager from a few unpleasant messages, too.

* * *

In this chapter we've had a lesson in customer experience excellence with a group of septuagenarians travelling through Switzerland. My Swiss Federal Railways experience didn't happen because of an impressive journey map or a worry about hitting an NPS score, it happened because of ambition. Collectively, and individually, an ambition to deliver on the service they'd promised, make things effortless for us and help us achieve our outcome of getting where we wanted to be.

When speaking with and researching the companies in our Showcase (*see also* pages 43–52), a common trait was their level of self-set ambition. None of them really have a 'customer experience strategy'. Instead, they have intrinsic motivation to do great things for customers, based on a commercial or moral desire.

They don't compare themselves to the best in the industry – they almost presume that that'll be them – but to the best across *all* industries, wanting to learn from those doing great things elsewhere and applying it to their business. And once that ambition has been set, they accept nothing less, creating a culture of real high performance for customers. They push the industry to do better, trailblazing on behalf of customers. Interestingly, I didn't hear a single mention of achieving a good net promoter score or being top of any league table. Instead, in every conversation, there was a clear and obvious burning desire to make things better for customers and influence the whole industry to improve.

While useful in many ways, over-simplified 'customer satisfaction' measurements can accidentally replace the ambition of 'making things better for customers' with a belief that hitting a score is achieving the same outcome, creating a misalignment between what matters to customers and what the company is delivering.

In weekly management meetings around the world, you'll hear discussions on average waiting time, acquisition rates, retention, dormancy and complaints performance yet this style of measurement hides the true impact being felt by customers.

In *The Customer Copernicus*,[48] former Tesco CMO Tim Mason recalls the impact of the business running customer listening sessions compared to simply looking at average performance figures:

> '*Tim Mason remembered explaining to customers why the strawberries kept running out every Saturday, the embarrassment of having to go through the reasoning and not wanting to repeat it again next week.*

[48] Dawson, C. and Meehan, S. (2021) *The Customer Copernicus,* p.62

Compare this with sitting in a meeting room and seeing there is 91 per cent availability of strawberries and next week 91.5 per cent or 90.5 per cent – the numbers just don't matter in the same way.'

Why not measure 'Human Lives Wasted' instead of 'Average Waiting Time'? 'Relationships Started' rather than 'Accounts Opened'? 'Customer Holidays' instead of 'Savings Balances Held'? Measuring actuals rather than averages may bring the human impact to life.

Some of these may seem (deliberately) far-fetched, but it's an accepted truth – at least according to the tens of millions of people who have bought Stephen Covey's *The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People*[49] book – that to achieve the outcome you want, you should begin with the end in mind. I'm not saving for a holiday because I enjoy saving, I'm saving for a holiday because I enjoy holidays.

The end, for most customers, is to have an easy and enjoyable experience, to help achieve a happy and fulfilled life. Organizations are facilitators in this, their role to make their part of this life possible with the minimum of customer effort required. Keeping this higher ambition at the centre of decision making will result in happier customers and a more successful business – as we've seen with the companies in our Showcase – as well as saving a few hours each week in meetings fretting over made-up survey scores.

'We were very ambitious. We wanted to challenge the industry heavyweights, but there was a lot of competition. We weren't the fastest and we weren't the cheapest (and we wanted to avoid a race to the bottom on price). So our differentiator was how we treated customers. We set ambitious targets for reliability and service, and had to make sure that culturally, it was never ok to fall below those, to never give our best.'

Chiltern Railways

[49] Covey, S. (1989) *The Seven Habits of Highly Effective People*. Free Press.

'*It's a practical reality. It's a competitive advantage, and it's one of the most difficult competitive advantages to copy. People don't invent their own failure and people don't disrupt themselves. But once they've been disrupted, they would wake up to it and try and catch up. So we focussed on the experience – the "people will forget what you tell them but will remember what you made them feel" principle. We asked ourselves, "How do we build a brand through people feeling great about our business?"*.'

AO.com

'*We were tired of the slickness of stuff, with every app looking the same, everything being cookie-cutter. We wanted to turn up the personality of the product. As soon as you show a bit of positivity and challenge the assumption that a dry topic doesn't have to be dry, this surprises the user.*'

Citymapper

'*The thing we were most passionate about when we started out was that the existing energy suppliers were really fleecing the customers. They would offer a super-cheap price for the first year and then prices would go through the roof, and as a result the elderly, the fuel poor, all these vulnerable groups were massively overpaying, and they were subsidising this tiny portion of the market to get this super cheap rate… Those who were really savvy were saving £100s a year, whilst the people who couldn't afford it or didn't understand it were being ripped off. We thought "this just isn't right, and it's exploiting the most vulnerable parts of society…" We did a lot of work with the BBC on these kinds of practices. We worked with the regulator to bring about the energy price cap, and when it came about, we felt very proud. That's 20m households that have benefitted.*'

Octopus Energy

'You can't do genuine humanity cynically.'

Riverford

'I used to look at Royal Mail and think, "for two days out of seven, all your infrastructure is sat idle?". Similarly, in our world, it used to be "Order Week One, Get Sometime Week Two". So we launched 72-hour delivery, then 48-hour delivery, then next-day delivery, which was revolutionary. We launched weekend delivery, next day across an incredible range of products, so raised the bar on proposition without increasing the price.'

AO.com

'You need to focus on the team you build, on what your bar is for fitting with your mission when you hire. How you cultivate and maintain that spirit? It's a high challenge to keep that culture strong and hire the right people. We don't have a company culture document with a big customer headline. We hire people who care and are ambitious.'

Citymapper

In summary, acting with ambition means:

- having self-set standards for customer success;
- striving for the highest standards, consistently;
- improving the whole industry on behalf of customers.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Connection

'Being so close to our customers and colleagues – experiencing our own product, having daily informal chats, being open to feedback from all – helped us to stay connected to what really mattered and make it a part of every conversation at board level. We always had powerful stories to share.'

Chiltern Railways

Staying connected to customers means:

- understanding and immersing in customers' lives;
- using your own product, regularly;
- staying abreast of relevant changes in the world.

When speaking to and researching the companies in the Showcase (*see also* pages 43–52), one common trait overwhelmingly stood out over and above all the others: staying connected to customers.

This might sound easy, but it is in fact very hard. It's hard because the easier thing is *not* to do it; to believe that you are your customer and so already understand what matters; to send out a large survey and convince yourself that volume of data is the same as quality of data; to find the answer you want to support a view you already have, rather than embrace the inconvenient truths as an opportunity to truly make things better for customers.

It's hard, because it takes more effort to understand customers than it does to understand the latest craze on Twitter. As Managing Director

Tom Johnson of consumer insight and futures consultancy Trajectory often points out, *'People often overplay the likely impact of technology and underplay the importance of what really matters to people.'* And it's hard because, as Charlie Dawson and Seán Meehan expertly interrogate in *The Customer Copernicus*, most organizations are set up in such a way that the power lies with people who are furthest away from the customers.

Frontline colleagues are dealing with customers day-to-day, delivering the experience they've been asked to and having a direct impact on people's emotions. As you get further from the interaction you reach Marketing, a department focused on how people feel about the brand, but with the people in the department not usually speaking to the customers themselves. And furthest from the direct emotional impact, the CEO and Executive team, with the power to influence and impact the feelings of thousands of colleagues and customers – but often people who rarely directly and deeply engage with either group.

But doing the hard thing is often the right thing. Taking time upfront to truly understand what matters to people will save hours, days, weeks and a huge amount of money. It will enable organizations to design what customers want more easily, to provide an experience that is both better for customers and more efficient for the business and to get more actual word-of-mouth recommendations without the need to ask customers if they'd do so hypothetically. And as we're about to see, the only real way to stay connected to what matters is to see it for yourself.

The Reality of Perception (Or the importance of not just treating customers how you want to be treated)

I once knew of an organization that developed a detailed segmentation of its customer base. Twenty customer groups were split by attitudes and demographics, fashion and music taste, hopes, dreams and ambitions. It was received brilliantly. Senior managers in

executive meetings nodded with approval as they were introduced to the new personas, bringing to life the different personalities and, crucially, the different possibilities for the organization to be useful to each customer group. Yet a few months later, frustration had set in, with the initial excitement of the insight replaced by scepticism for most of the ideas.

To work out what was going on, the team who had created the original segments overlaid the same criteria on the people that worked for the company and what they found was fascinating. Across the 20 segments, there was an even split across the population. However, in the organization, nearly all the senior management team were in one segment, segment 10: white, middle-class, male, earning above-average income for their age.

Despite being wowed by the original insight, the senior managers applied their own '*would I want it?*' filter to judge all of the ideas, with the answer universally being '*no*'. Many ideas died, while others, which appealed to managers but not to customers, failed.

It's human nature to see the world from where we stand, closer to our own surroundings, more familiar with our own experiences. This is true for our literal view of the world. If you get a piece of paper and draw a map of the world, I'm fairly certain you'll draw the country you're in or from far bigger than it really is. In fact, having done this exercise thousands of times with clients over the past decade, many people in Europe draw their continent as double the actual size while under-representing the size of Africa by the same amount. More than that, the further you get from where you are, the hazier understanding becomes and the more generalized people's interpretations. Depending on where in the world you are, you'll have forgotten to draw Japan. Or Sri Lanka. Maybe Cuba. Madagascar almost certainly won't be on there, despite being twice the size of the UK. Iceland didn't stand a chance.

(If I'm wrong, then congratulations! You should consider a career in cartography. For the rest of you though, not to worry – you're just being human.)

This is also true of the way organizations, and people in those organizations, understand their customers. As with our segmentation senior managers, we're closer to what matters to us and naturally drawn towards the products and services we might like than we are to our customers and to what really matters in their lives.

We're also closer to our colleagues, our business and our industry with its rules and regulations. This makes what we do seem of utmost importance and makes us forget what it's like to be a person that doesn't understand – or doesn't care about – our products, our services, or our feedback requests.

A helpful reality check is to see how many of your bills you could pay if you had a salary in line with most of the population. In the left column, fill in your monthly spending on each area. Then, in the next column, see how far you could get if you were on the median (UK) salary and then how far you would get on the UK's minimum wage. My guess – if you're a professional senior manager in a mid-to-large corporate based in a city – is not very far.

Outgoings	*Your Salary £x per month*	*Median UK Salary (£2,000 per month after tax)*	*Minimum UK Wage (£1,121 per month after tax)*[1]
Mortgage/Rent			
Food			
Gas and Electric			
Water			
Council Tax			
Home Insurance			
Car			
Broadband			
Mobile Phone			
Childcare			
Clothing			
House Maintenance			
Life Insurance			

Medical			
Fitness			
Television			
Entertainment			
Holidays			
Savings			
Total			

[1]https://salaryaftertax.com/salary-calculator/uk

With our brains working against us in this way, it's no wonder letters and emails from companies are often confusing and laden with jargon. We've forgotten what it's like not to know the things we now know about our products and our industry; we've forgotten that our priorities may not be everyone else's priorities.

This challenge isn't new for people or for companies. Nor is the solution.

Over 60 years ago, on my grandmother's first day in her new job, she received a letter which perfectly articulates the way to escape this limiting perspective. The advice is as relevant now as ever and wouldn't be out of place on the front page of any employee handbook handed over on day one of a new job:

9th June 1961

Dear Mrs Bruff

Now that you have finished your school training and you are beginning your career as a telephonist, let me welcome you to the ranks of those of us who provide telephone services for the people of London.

It is a little early yet to ask you what you think of your job as a Post Office telephonist, but, if you have not already done so, I hope you will soon come to think of it as an opportunity to serve others. An efficient telephone service is essential to the business and social life of the country; and as our personal telephone representative, always in touch with the telephone

subscribers who are our customers, you will have many opportunities for helping others and of gaining for the telephone service a reputation for efficiency and unfailing courtesy.

Think of the service you get from others. You travel by train or bus, you are served in shops, so from your own experience, you know the difference between service given cheerfully and service that seems grudging and ungracious.

I ask you to make a firm resolve to give your best at all times. If you do this, and take pride in the great organization to which you now belong, I am sure you will get that true satisfaction which one gets from a job which is really well done.

I hope you will have many happy years with us.

Yours sincerely

R.H. McGann

I suspect that if a Silicon Valley start-up CEO sent this letter to his employees now, it would be a viral sensation and form the basis of multiple keynote presentations for years to come.

Stand By Me
(Or the importance of experiencing how customers behave, not just what they believe)

I interviewed a lady about her eating and shopping habits for a new project we'd just started. Her house was a foodie heaven – recipe books from floor to ceiling, cupboards over-spilling with spices from around the world, pots, pans and plates everywhere you looked. She told me that she practised yoga, cooked everything from scratch and would never consider using any kind of prepared food. It was far too unhealthy for her lifestyle. Yet the next day, when I went shopping with her, something strange happened. Far from spending her whole time in the organic produce section, she

happily filled her trolley with ready-chopped onions and ready-mashed mashed potato:

'I thought you said you cook everything from scratch, that you wouldn't use prepared food?'
'I don't, but this is different. I don't have time to peel potatoes or chop my own onions.'

Then as we got to the confectionery aisle, an armful of full-fat chocolate and every colour of wine was delicately balanced on top of the overflowing trolley:

'I know, I know, I said I'm healthy, but this is for girls' night on a Friday night. It doesn't count.'

These kind of examples are everywhere.

People who say they'd only install a smart meter if they were paid to do so, whereas actually all that matters is being able to have it installed at a convenient time.

People who say that the reason they'd switch banks is because of a better interest rate, whereas usually it's because their existing bank screwed up, so they switched to the first bank they walk past in the high street.

People who say the quality of the food is what makes them prefer one supermarket to another, whereas it's actually the recipes that the lady on the deli counter told them about each week.

In his brilliant book, *A Technique for Producing Ideas*[50], James Webb Young comments on the need to delve into raw materials of what really matters to people:

[50] Webb Young, J. (2003) *A Technique for Producing Brilliant Ideas.* Advertising Age Classics Library. McGrawHill Education.

'Most of us stop too soon in the process of getting an intimate knowledge of people. If the surface differences are not striking, we assume that there are no differences.'

I experienced this first-hand when interviewing a lady who'd just moved into a new-build house, looking to understand if she'd faced any issues. She was, on the surface, absolutely delighted with the place. As we spoke, she waxed lyrical about how much nicer it was than her previous place – '*A drugs den*' – and how grateful she was for the opportunity to have moved in.

Drawing the conversation to a close after 30 minutes, was there anything, I asked her one last time, anything at all that hadn't been perfect?

'Well, it's a bit inconvenient that there isn't enough space to put in a dishwasher, but I'm not moaning.'

'Okay. Anything else?'

'Um… well, the driveway is a little small – I can't open the doors of the car properly so can't get my daughter out of the back seats.'

'Anything else?'

'Yeah, the stairway is missing a handrail at the top, so my daughter has fallen down the stairs twice and my husband four times.'

'Wow, okay! Anything else like that?'

'We did have a big brown patch appear in the ceiling, so someone came and opened the loft hatch and a load of brown water poured out. It ruined the carpet so they replaced that too. They didn't pin it down properly though so my daughter tripped over that and hurt herself.'

'Right.'

'The garden is lovely though! I mean, it does flood whenever it rains but we're so lucky to have a garden.'

So often this kind of real human insight is missed, its place taken by beautifully prepared PowerPoint slides summarizing the thoughts and feelings of 'target customers' that support the CEO's hypothesis or aggregating an experience that no customer is actually having.

If an inconvenient truth is shared – something that goes against the existing beliefs of what really matters to customers and what the business should be doing in response – then it's more common for that meeting to descend into a debate questioning the methodology than it is to accept and discuss what's been discovered.

While hugely informative, traditional customer insight is often experienced second-hand, so fails to build the kind of 'affective' empathy needed to inspire action. Knowing what a customer says they want and need is very different to feeling genuinely compelled to find new ways of doing things on their behalf – especially when those things are likely to be inconvenient and costly to the organization in the short term.

This connection with real people's real lives becomes even more important in a world of algorithms and automatic recommendations. Life-long Watford fan Matt Ballantine wrote an article expressing his annoyance at Twitter suggesting he might like to follow other football teams.[51] It included an explanation provided by someone who works for the social media giant: as football journalists follow a lot of different teams and are followed by big audiences of football fans, they are 'people of influence'. And so, because they follow a lot of teams, the algorithm assumes that is the desired behaviour of anyone interested in football.

Humans 1 Algorithms 0.

It's only by fully immersing in people's real lives – experiencing first-hand, at a human level, what really matters to them – that people can reconnect with what's important to customers and have the visceral belief needed to push the organization into a new direction. That

[51] https://mmitii.mattballantine.com/2021/07/24/ooo-are-you/

means speaking to them, observing them, spending time with them, serving them and actually being them.

At Sky's 2005 interim results presentation,[52] James Murdoch made clear how important understanding customers was to Sky's success:

> *'We do 3.3 million unique house visits every year. That's a big number. And every single visit is unique. I can tell you myself and a number of [executives], we go out on these calls and we go on the road, and we go and visit customers and go and view these service calls. And every one is unique.'*

Despite this, more often than not the excuse given by those in senior positions and big organizations is 'we simply don't have time'. If your job is to create products and services your customers will love, or to share what you offer in a creative and compelling way, then really, what else could possibly be more important? So, if you don't think you have the time to get to know your customers, I'd recommend buying ready-made mashed potato – it'll save you hours!

Inevitable Innovation (Or the importance of understanding the things that are going to change)

I get really annoyed when my five-year-old son eats with his hands. His knife and fork just sit there, pristine and untouched, and I sit there silently raging, remembering the parental self-help mantras to 'pick my battles' and 'let the small things go'. My wife is far more relaxed about the whole thing – *'How many 18-year-olds do you know who don't use a knife and fork?'*

[52] Factiva, 1 February 2006, Interim 2005 British Sky broadcasting Group plc Earnings presentation, via *The Customer Copernicus*

For me, understanding that inevitability helps me to be far more relaxed about the whole cutlery thing. For companies, understanding the things that customers are inevitably going to expect will – in the words of Future Agenda's Director Patrick Harris – '*help them to make better decisions today*'. The trouble is, as humans, we're not particularly great at looking to the future. Most of us have an in-built over-confidence about what's to come (just ask all those futurologists who created beautiful 'World in 2020' trend presentations). We get over-excited by Shiny New Things, presuming new technology will change the world almost immediately. Gartner's Hype Cycle – a model that tracks the maturity, adoption, and social application of technology – shows this isn't the case, as does the snail-paced progress of Virtual Reality and driverless cars into our lives. Luckily you don't need a crystal ball to work out what's going to inevitably matter to customers. Because as pioneering sci-fi writer William Gibson says, '*the future is already here – it's just not evenly distributed*'.[53]

The trick to understanding what will matter to people in the future is to understand the things on the edges now, out of the mainstream, nearly, but not quite at a tipping point. The technology exists, the jobs are created, the products being used. Except they're being used in a different country, company or industry, like clever NASA or military people who are often inventing and using versions of smartphones a few years before the public gets sight of them.

History is littered with these innovations that were inevitable once a certain trigger had occurred. Napster and Spotify were always going to replace mix tapes and vinyl once internet speeds increased. Part-time banks would always become 24/7 instant money once the mobile phone appeared. High-pollution vehicles are absolutely going to be replaced by electric pods now that battery life has improved.

[53] https://quoteinvestigator.com/2012/01/24/future-has-arrived/

When these triggers happen, the same pattern is seen time and time again:

A new and better way to solve an old human problem is created.

Innovators experiment, just for fun, without care for business case or regulation.

Early adopters start using it, not necessarily legally, challenging the status quo (this was just as true for Gutenberg's printing press as it is now for Uber).

The existing organizations hit back, putting their defences up and citing rules, regulations and job losses.

But customers start to use it, start to like it and start to demand it.

Eventually, incumbents either give up and go home or decide to join in the fun, once enough of their business has been taken to make it financially unavoidable.

This path is already set for the future.

How much longer will train companies use paper tickets? Will hotels need receptionists? Will energy companies keep estimating? Will voting be non-digital? Will banks hoard your data? Will house-selling rely on estate agents? Will SIM cards be needed? Will deliveries require signing for?

Like water finding the quickest route down the mountain, these good ideas will eventually find the way to improve the customer experience for everyone, even if they have to go round a few old historic boulders on the way.

American writer and co-chair of The Long Now Foundation, Stuart Brand, calls this 'Pace Layering': understanding the things – nature, culture, governance – that will change slowly, and the others – regulation, technology, fashion – that will change far more quickly. So to really understand what's going to matter to customers in the future, be curious about the inevitable, the things on the edges, the companies

getting into trouble, the breakthrough scientific discoveries. Like those tiny food tablets astronauts use in space… Now there's a thought to suggest to my son.

* * *

In this chapter, we've heard tales of an inside-out approach to segmentation, a health-conscious cook in denial and a child refusing to use their cutlery. All of these stories point to the same conclusion: the need to really, truly understand what's going on in people's lives, now, in the past and in the future. The need to step deliberately out of your own world and into the world of others, consciously challenging the natural biases we all have by actively seeking out different perspectives.

To repeat what I said at the start of this chapter, staying connected to customers is the overwhelming difference between the companies in our Showcase (*see also* pages 43–52) and others that I've experienced. Ultimately, this is about creating a full picture of the customer's life, to be able to understand how an organization can be – and can stay – useful to them. To do this, what's needed is genuine, human connection, not thousands of surveys and massive data sets to passively pore over on a Monday morning.

The people at the top talking, in person, regularly, to their customers, about their lives and what matters, not calling them about a recent complaint or to ask their opinion on a new product. Spending time on social media to understand how people are feeling when they're at their most angry and emotional, their most viscerally human. Accessing a whole world's worth of unanswered questions through search trend data (after all, as former Google CEO Eric Schmidt once allegedly said: '*The only time you can know that people are telling the truth is when they're searching for something*').

What are your customers saying, doing, shouting about and searching for?

Then there's a whole load of colleagues who are speaking to customers directly every day. Consistently, the leaders in our Showcase talk about speaking regularly to their frontline team to understand what's really

going on, with open lines of communication to share honest feedback. They get colleagues involved in design work, contributing new ideas and helping to shape future offers. And they give them permission to try things that are off script, then share back and celebrate successes for others to learn from.

(Albeit to get colleagues' honest views, it's vital that this is done in an open and constructive way. My friend Mark Johnson once told me about his 'Lie Theory' in organizations. The CEO has an idea and tells one of the team who works for her. That person, not wanting to upset his boss, agrees that it's a good idea, even though he has doubts. He passes the idea down the chain of command, everyone unsure, but everyone saying yes rather than risk reprimand. The idea hits the frontline and doesn't work too well. A few weeks later, one of the frontline team is asked by their boss how well the CEO's idea is working. Not wanting to upset things, they reply, 'It's going great!', and so the lie passes back up the chain until it reaches the CEO, who hears the news she's been waiting for: the idea is deemed a success.)

When I ask business leaders if they're close to their customers, they always say yes. When I ask when the last time was they spoke to a customer, they usually say they can't remember. When I ask why they don't do it more often, the response is nearly always, *'I'd love to, but I just don't have the time'*.

But if you're running a business that relies on having customers, what on earth are you doing that's more important than speaking to them?

'We have an unfair advantage in that we design and build something we ourselves are using on a daily basis. Every commute is an opportunity to learn and instantly validate our ideas. The "Go" feature, that guides you in real-time once you're on the trip, was built on 1000 commutes from 60 people. So, no, we don't spend a lot of time in focus groups and research sessions.'

Citymapper

'You have to eat feedback from your customers for breakfast, lunch, dinner and snacks. You have to get out there and hear from your customers and your employees. How are you making it hard for them? What are the things they would change on behalf of their customers?'[54]

Workday

'I believe deeply in walkabout management. At one time or another, I've done every job in the business, through necessity or wanting to understand it. I go and ask people in the business "what do you do every day that we ask you to do that's stupid?"'

AO.com

'If you're not experiencing what your customers are, you're just making assumptions. So the majority of the leadership team all lived on the route and we'd use the trains every day, talking to customers every day. It kept the customer at the heart of what we did. In the boardroom we'd talk about what we were seeing, what we were hearing. The Managing Director was on Twitter every day. It started to give a gut instinct above P&L and Business Cases.'

Chiltern Railways

'We travel a lot and take that very seriously as the localised angle per city is hugely important to us. We have a culture called "The Travelling Circus" where we take a mini version of the team and they go and live in a city for a month, live the pain, the commutes. We pick our AirBnBs and offices, and change locations, to maximise our exposure to commutes. It's about living in the city for a while and really understanding what the reality is. We hire people locally too, and have a super diverse team from over 50 countries, and that gives a good way to get the local view.'

Citymapper

[54] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rxh9_leA9gQ

'We've got this functional ability to execute stuff really quickly, but unless you've got the feedback mechanisms to know what the thing you need to execute is, it's really hard to make those choices so we all make sure we talk to real customers every day.'

Octopus Energy

In 2020, Bendigo brought its new 'Branch of the Future' programme to the City of Greater Bendigo. The design approach was highly collaborative, with the bank *'canvassing feedback from Bendigo residents, local businesses, creatives and customers of the other four recently established "branches of the future" to help redefine the overall customer experience'*. This led to the new branch featuring a retail pop-up space and art gallery for local businesses and creatives to showcase their work, a community event space and three vibrant murals painted by local artists.[55]

Bendigo Bank

'A few years ago, I invited myself into about 40 customers' homes and cooked with them. I learnt a huge amount from it, more than I would have done from a few surveys. Quantitative is important but you need that qualitative feel.'

Riverford

'One of the first things I did when I came into the role was work on our customer journey. We brought in groups of customers and had them play back their entire experience with us across that journey. We got really great insights into the components we could improve, that outside-in perspective.

[55] https://www.bendigobank.com.au/media-centre/bendigo-bank-cuts-the-ribbon-on-new-bendigo-branch-of-the-future/

'Since then I've taken on this "Secret Shopper" mentality… I had my team sign me up as a new customer and I'm walking step by step through the process. It's been great because it gives me the viewpoint of how our customers are experiencing that process and getting great interaction with some of our frontline employees that I wouldn't otherwise get.'[56]

Workday

'Our walking routes [fast and main road] *come from understanding what the real world is like, not just the science and maths that the data produces. What are the real world problems that are out there that our product can help with? It's never "what's the best route?" it's always "I need to be there, I have time to hang out on the bus, it's the third time I was late this week, I can't be late again". There's always a reason.'*

Citymapper

'One way that we listen to our customers is through our informal customer community called miVoice. This is an online community of more than 5,000 customers, where members can share their views, opinions and ideas via regular surveys and discussion forums. Feedback from this community helps us continue to improve the banking experience and ensures we are focusing on the things that really matter to our customers.'[57]

Bendigo Bank

[56] https://www.blakemichellemorgan.com/podcast/how-workday-stays-customer-centric-during-covid-19/

[57] https://www.bendigoadelaide.com.au/globalassets/documents/bendigoadelaide/investorcentre/results-and-reporting/sustainability-reports/sustainability-report-2021.pdf

'We spend a lot of time with our customers. … Almost every single feature that we build has a design partner program, where we literally are with our customers, understanding what their pain points are and figuring out how can we solve those pain points in the product.'[58]

'We have a community for our customers where they can brainstorm new ideas'.[59] (The Workday community has over 94k members, with customer forums, user groups and brainstorms. To date, over 2,500 ideas submitted within the community have been put into the product.)[60]

Workday

'Our frontline team are very much like our donors and bought in to the importance of donations. Lots of our team are donors themselves so experience the "product" first-hand. This was different to my time in the corporate world, where very few of the team actually used their own products or services.'

NHSBT

'We're one of a few companies who don't believe the customer is always right. It's so unthinking. The reality is most customers in many ways don't know what they want.'

Riverford

'So being close to our customers and colleagues – experiencing our own product, having daily informal chats, being open to feedback from all – helped us to stay connected to what really mattered and make it a part of every conversation at board level. We always had powerful stories to share…

[58] https://siliconangle.com/2017/10/27/workday-hits-97-customer-satisfaction-thanks-design-partner-programs-ghc17/
[59] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rxh9_leA9gQ
[60] Workday.com

'I remember the old managing director got on a train and spoke to the catering team. They said they were ok, but shared some issues, such as the coffee machine being broken. The MD immediately sent an email to the rest of the Exec saying, "If I took your laptop away, could you do your job?"'

Chiltern Railways

'It matters to do cool stuff, so be timely, so be in the zeitgeist, to hack the system in interesting ways.'

Citymapper

In summary, staying connected to customers means:

- understanding and immersing in customers' lives;
- using your own product, regularly;
- staying abreast of relevant changes in the world.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Empowerment

'Humans are incredible, creative things. Don't put them in straitjackets and have endless policies to try and get them to behave well. If they're aligned on what is right and what is best for the customers, they can do incredible things.'

Octopus Energy

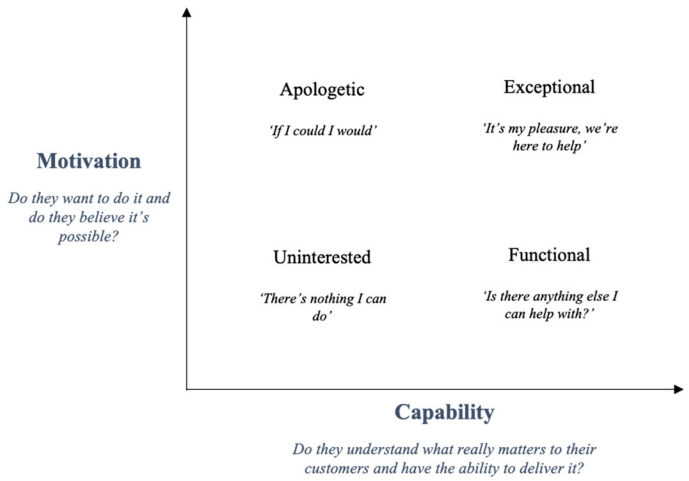
Empowering colleagues means:

- seeking colleagues' opinions and ideas;
- involving colleagues in the design process;
- giving colleagues autonomy to do what's right.

In many of the stories we've heard so far, it's clear that alongside the rapid improvements in online customer experience seen in the past 20 years, real humans still matter at the biggest moments. Humans who can use their initiative, understanding and empathy to create something that really connects when it's most needed. Yet in many organizations, a combination of over-reliance on process, a fear of regulation and insecure, micro-management makes this approach almost impossible. Subsequently, organizations are full of humans that aren't allowed to act in a human way. This is damaging to a company in three ways.

Firstly, it's bad for customer experience. It's not unusual to have an angry customer talking to an apologetic staff member, both of whom can see what the problem is and how it could be resolved, but the system they're in won't give them the freedom to do it. This is best summed up

by the phrase *'I would if I could…'* and is hugely frustrating for both people involved.



Inspired by the Fogg Behaviour Model[61]

Secondly, it's costly to the business. Countless hours and vast sums of money are spent on perfect recruitment processes, only to immediately restrict the natural abilities of the person they've hired through micromanagement. The employees start to feel wasted and frustrated, their fresh eyes and enthusiasm able to see what could be improved, but often held back to satisfy an historic hierarchy – so they leave.

Finally, is that it restricts the flow of ideas and through the business, leaving all innovative thinking and strategic decision making to the few at the top, who probably have similar demographics, views and life experiences (those Segment Tens from earlier on, *see also* page 158). The more enlightened senior managers recognize this limited perspective but are still more likely to spend time and money with outside agencies before they explore the great thinking they have hidden within their own headcount.

While this book is about bringing the humanity back into customer experience, rather than specifically humans, what's undeniable is that

[61] https://behaviormodel.org

the companies famed for giving truly great customer experiences are mostly the ones that still put real humans at the heart of their offer.

Zappos, first direct, Morrisons, Timpson, John Lewis & Partners, Metro Bank… All organizations that, at the height of their commercial success, built their business around their people and the freedom that they gave them. These are the organizations people tell their friends about and write case studies on. The organizations that give a genuine emotional connection no app or AI can hope to reproduce. Let's hear some stories of how empowerment – or the lack of – has had an impact in the real world.

Let Your People Go
(Or the importance of allowing colleagues to bring their whole selves to work)

'My shoelace broke, and I remember looking down and thinking, "I really don't want to buy another pair of shoes for this job." So that morning I resigned.'

Myke and I worked together at one of the big banks, with me as head of customer innovation and him as a marketing manager, just starting out in his career. He's smart and interesting and loved to get involved in any work we were doing on innovation, despite it not really being 'his job'. He was also into podcasting before podcasting was a thing, a side hobby that he often talked about, being a devoted Apple fanatic.

Despite having this energy for and knowledge about the changing digital world, the tight hierarchy of big organizations seemed to get in the way of Myke being able to share his knowledge or put this passion to good. So he left.

While a shoelace breaking might sound like a slightly cavalier approach to career development to some, it worked out pretty well for Myke. His podcast network, Relay FM, is now one of the most well-

known and respected podcast networks in the world, with its flagship show, *Connected*, being showcased at an Apple event in 2018. And many senior leaders in the bank now follow Myke on Twitter to keep informed on the latest advances in Silicon Valley.

When asked 'What is it that makes you different?', it's typical for CEOs to reply, 'Our people'. This is particularly true at annual company conferences where 'our people' is often hailed as the reason why company x believes it is better than competitor y, even though the people in both companies are probably of the same quality (and will often move between the two). It's foolish to believe one corporation has managed to somehow snag an exceptional group of employees despite paying broadly the same wages and offering roughly the same type of work. In reality, it's not the people that make a company different, but what the company allows their people to do. Do they see them as a real person, with valid opinions, achievements and experiences outside of their job, able to be shared freely? Or as a number, a person that can only be listened to once they've reached a certain grade in the company?

Here's an example of Timpson's approach from *The Customer Copernicus*:

> *'At Timpson's, there are just two rules for people working in stores: look the part and be 100 per cent honest. Everything else is flexible. Timpson name badges are designed to encourage everyone to talk regardless of hierarchy. They bear the person's first name, when they joined, and an outside interest or hobby.'*

Organizations are full of brilliant humans who often aren't allowed to act in a human way. They're recruited because of their personality, interests and skills, and then immediately boxed-in and shut down, shaped to become identikit versions of each other.

In his book *Drive*[62], Dan Pink writes eloquently about the importance of autonomy in human motivation (alongside competency

[62] Pink, D. (2013) *Drive: The Surprising Truth About What Motivates Us*. Canongate Books Ltd.

and relatedness). Conversely, a tight, hierarchical approach can leave people feeling strangled, frustrating them if they have a good idea but simply can't make headway through the system around them. So these people (that companies have invested a lot of time and energy in developing) leave to work for a competitor or do their own thing, not interested in having to earn the right to be heard, in only having their ideas considered once they've notched up five years' service. Not only does the company then have to find and train someone to replace them, but with the ideas being implemented elsewhere, it leaves them playing catch-up on an important new innovation which they could have been taking the lead on.

In contrast, many years ago my ex-colleague Darren Armitage, then Head of Technology Innovation at HSBC, launched an award-winning colleague idea generation programme called IdeaJam. Each month, a new campaign was created with a question for frontline colleagues to input into, which led to an over-flowing inbox of new initiatives. As well as submitting ideas, colleagues could vote up the best ones, giving a real sense of involvement in the ideas and the eventual implementation.

When asked what made it such a success, Darren was pretty clear:

> *'The technology that enabled us to do it wasn't that important. What mattered was people right across the organization feeling like they had the opportunity to be heard, to contribute to the overall success of the company, even if their ideas were away from their day-to-day role.'*[63]

Your people might well be your greatest asset, but just because you say it doesn't make it true. You've got to let them be different and let them make a difference. If not, they'll go and make a difference elsewhere.

[63] Conversation with the author, 2019

The Human Touch
(Or the importance of giving colleagues autonomy to do what's right)

The news dominated the local village Facebook forum:

> *'Please can I ask if you are buying train tickets in the morning that you buy them from the gentleman who works in the ticket office. They've threatened to close it in June and he is going to lose his job.'*

The responses came thick and fast:

> *'Tony? There's so much more to him than selling tickets! He's a font of information! He's so helpful!'*
>
> *'He's such a lovely man and does SO MUCH MORE than selling tickets. He has WAY more knowledge than the machines and I'd rather queue to speak to him and see a friendly face.'*
>
> *'There's nothing like getting information from humans. Another valuable job lost to automation!'*
>
> *'Ticket machines and the app do the job just fine. You have to accept technology moves on. Harsh, but true.'*
>
> *'Maybe we should set up a petition to see if we can save his job?'*
>
> *'Oh no! Tony has been an absolute mine of information! Thanks to his advice I was able to get 50 per cent off my son's ticket today.'*

(This last one might be why they're getting rid of him…)

Customer experience delivered by a real person has become such a rarity that when people experience it, it feels special. Special enough to tell other people about and, in some cases, campaign to keep it. More often than not, these special moments are when the human involved has used their initiative, gone off-script or helped avert some kind of minor crisis through quick thinking and genuine empathy.

At London Underground's Oval station in 2003, Customer Services Manager Anthony Gentles decided to try and perk up the 'blank faces' of the morning commuters – and the now famous 'Thought for the Day' was born. Grabbing a spare 'Information' whiteboard, he started a daily practice of sharing a thought from his favourite book *Tao Te Ching*, giving the passing passengers something to consider and chat about to staff and fellow commuters alike. In 2007 his colleague Glenn Sutherland took over and Oval station passengers – as well as over 30,000 followers on Twitter – have since enjoyed more than 3,000 'thoughts' to ponder.

(In October 2020 Glenn moved stations and began working at Morden instead – and within weeks the @MordenStation Twitter account had an extra 10,000 followers.)[64]

Chiltern Railways excel at this. I remember one particular commute where the driver was doing his job as expected: driving the train, on time, to our destination. He was delivering the functional experience we'd paid for. This driver decided that wasn't enough though, so he added his own human touch:

'For those of you who have joined at Gerrards Cross, your boarding technique was excellent, well done!'

'Please stand clear of the big closey slidey things.'

'If you stand in the doorway, tut tut, shame on you! Now get those smiles on your faces and brighten up the carriage.'

'Please have your tickets and smiles ready when boarding the train.'

(Singing) 'Oh, what a beautiful mooooooorning….'

'Go, my merry band of munchkins and have a wonderful day.'

Cheesy? Absolutely. Annoying if it happened every day? Very possibly. But while it didn't make my journey quicker, give me a more comfortable seat or aid my attempts to win the elbow battle for the armrest, it did have the whole carriage smiling by the time we arrived in London.

[64] https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/uk-england-london-42666628

Compare that experience to the train company I currently use with the automated message that gets played at the end of every journey:

> *'On behalf of all the train crew, we thank you for travelling with us and wish you a safe and pleasant onward journey.'*

A nice enough message, but given it's played thousands of times a day, it comes across as robotic, sanitized and meaningless. How much effort would it *really* take for the driver to make that announcement? And while it's tempting to believe these moments matter more now because so much of our experience is online, a post on Twitter from author Nate Crowley shared an extraordinary letter exchange from 1977 between his mother and Midland Bank, concerning her authorized overdraft:[65]

> *'In 1977, it seems, my mum got badly overdrawn and tried to get the bank off her neck by writing a poem. More astonishingly yet, it appears the bank... um... wrote one back. Well played, Midland. Well played, Mum.'*
>
> *Oh dear oh me*
> *As you can see*
> *I have severely overspent*
> *I do not know where the money went*
> *My apologies to Mr Bee*
> *I'm sure that he will shortly see*
> *Lots of money pouring in*
> *To fill my empty money tin*
> *Until that time comes to be*
> *My cheque book will assuredly*
> *Be safely under lock and key*
> *I hope from this you will have surmised*
> *That your humble servant is chastised*

[65] https://twitter.com/frogcroakley/status/980772810908930048?lang=en

The reply from Midland Bank came three days later. Not an 'arranged' or 'computer says no' in sight:

Your ode we read with great delight
The overdraft was an oversight
We note it wasn't your intent
To have severely overspent
Patient now we await your 'bread'
To take your account out of the red
On that happy day you'll see
Your cheque book can once more be free

These human moments don't have to be over-engineered 'surprise and delight' ideas captured on a journey map or process design flow dictated or created by a branding team based at a business park somewhere in Slough. They just need to be human and heartfelt, a moment of connection provided by someone who wants to create a great experience, understands what matters to customers and has the ability (and opportunity) to deliver it. We love them because we know there is a human involved, an individual who's decided to do something differently from everyone else.

Moments that act as proof of a human pulse behind a large corporate façade.

* * *

In this chapter, we've heard about a shoelace-breaking podcast pioneer, an overly generous train ticket salesman and a poet in need of some pennies. Through speaking to and studying the companies in the Showcase (*see also* pages 43–52), something emerged very clearly: these companies spend time hiring great people who fit their culture. They give them the training and the tools to be successful, then they provide the trust and autonomy to make things better for customers.

This empowerment isn't just about customers dealing with customers, but all employees: the people designing, processing, making, shaping, procuring, protecting and leading. All benefit from having more autonomy to use their natural abilities and knowledge to their full extent.

The challenge for organizations is, therefore, to find the balance between the undoubted efficiency provided by new technologies and the role for responsive humans in keeping customers happy. Used in combination, it's an incredibly powerful approach. Of course, different customers will want different combinations at different times, depending on what matters to them, in their lives, at that moment. There's not a perfect process or flawless flowchart that can correctly predict what will be needed when.

What there are, though, are humans. Humans who can read a situation, read emotions, understand the nuances from their own experiences or their own ability to empathize. Humans who can use the whole range of their skills and interests to connect with customers, to go quicker for those in a rush and slower for those looking for reassurance, to put aside formalities and forms when what's needed is advice or a sympathetic ear. Humans that are comfortable in the non-binary grey areas of life that most people spend their time in.

Organizations are full of brilliant humans who often aren't allowed to act in a human way. Set them free and who knows what customer experiences they'll create.

'We held regular colleague roadshows. However, the most valuable time was always the cups of coffee with people on the frontline, just chatting and hearing things first-hand. The more formal the forum, the less I learnt. The more informal, the more I benefitted.'

Chiltern Railways

'Everyone is rowing in the same direction. You see it in the energy to help each other do their jobs. When Covid first hit and we were trying to respond, we asked our team to come up with ideas for helping customers.

Our biggest issue was we had so many ideas coming in that we needed a small army of people to sift through all of the ideas.'[66]

Workday

'So we would get the team involved in any initiative we were planning, taking to the staff and using them as part of the development approach. They helped give us first-hand insight into what mattered to customers, but also as a sounding board to make sure it made sense from an operational perspective.'

NHSBT

'If any of the decisions we made at Head Office weren't right, we'd soon hear about it. We'd get direct emails from people at every level of the company, telling us what the impact was. People were very comfortable contacting the top team, knowing they'd be listened to, and wanting to improve the service. There was no grumbling to each other, it came directly to us.'

Chiltern Railways

'Fifty per cent of our roadmap will be stuff we've planned out, 25 per cent of capacity is left free for stuff we'll need to respond to and 25 per cent left free for people to do their own thing, to do what they think is right.'

Octopus Energy

'Every day, we have what's called "The Daily". Every day, we build a new version of the app and the team uses it. We get stuff in the daily as fast as possible then spend time with it in the real world, with real locations and real data. Sometimes we choose to ship things before it's perfect to see what happens in the real world and if our assumptions are correct.'

Citymapper

[66] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rxh9_leA9gQ

'Whenever new colleagues arrived, the Directors would always meet them and make them feel special. We'd say to them "if you don't know the right thing to do, just do the right thing for the customer". We'd tell people that we've brought them in because we trust them, and we believe in them… I've had a few moments where our people shocked even me. I remember going to Oxford Station one day and speaking to the team about a local train that had been cancelled. We spoke to the driver of the next train and he had already decided where he was going to stop the train to get everyone home. He was adamant – these customers need to get home, and his job was to do it. It was outside of our process but exactly the right thing to do for our customers.'

Chiltern Railways

'Culture is hugely important to us and we believe people should come in in the morning with the autonomy to make customers' experiences better.'

Octopus Energy

'We try and recruit people who fundamentally care, then try and create the environment for them to be the best version of themselves that they can be. Then you have to have the courage to call people out. Don't let somebody drop a Mars Bar wrapper on the floor and walk off. Those standards become institutionalised… Great people do great things and average people do average things. Recruiting and training great people will solve lots of problems for you. And you need fewer great people than you do average people… You have to believe in autonomy and take a leap of faith. Don't try and train rules in. We do principles, not prescriptions. The managers will spend a lot of time call listening and training, not telling people off.'

AO.com

'Have the confidence to manage in a human way, investing in people and trusting your people. Most people are trustworthy and if you trust them, they'll act in a trustworthy way. If you act like you don't trust them then it encourages them to act in an untrustworthy way.'

Riverford

'People deliver human experiences and need human connection. Humans are messy, with messy lives and messy relationships. They're less predictable than a machine or robot – but they're also much more magical. If you've got something that only a human can do, invest in the human in the way you would a machine, service them like you would service a machine. Great people do great things.'

AO.com

In summary, empowering colleagues means:

- seeking colleagues' opinions and ideas;
- involving colleagues in the design process;
- giving colleagues autonomy to do what's right.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Focus

'We focus on being magical in the moments that matter, finding ways – through basic humanity – to bring a very human experience, to be a human business on as many different touchpoints as possible. Our success is the aggregated benefit of hundreds and thousands of little things we've thought about. This makes it very difficult to copy, and to copy at scale.'

AO.com

Focusing on the moments that matter means:

- being brilliant in the high-impact moments;
- knowing the small moments that mean something;
- taking ownership when the customer has a problem.

As we explored earlier, there are a lot of parallels between customer relationships and personal relationships. Many cruise along without incident for years, enjoying the good times with no reason to break up. Then something happens, a defining moment that influences the decision to get married, have kids or move on.

Are you there for your partner when they're sick? When they lose their job? When they have a problem and don't know where to turn for help? Do you support them with a new and risky venture? Help them step out of their comfort zone? Celebrate their successes? These are the moments that give you confidence and certainty for the future, or where your partner's true colours are revealed and you realize that they're not the one for you.

The same is true of a customer relationship. Nothing of note can happen for a long time, the service being fine and forgettable, then your bank card stops working while you're on holiday, your insurer refuses to pay out for a claim, you've got a problem that no one is taking seriously… They can be big moments or small, planned or unplanned, but they're all moments of significant human impact, during which a customer will choose whether to stay, recommend or leave you.

Yet while it may seem obvious that these are the moments to focus on, the reality is usually more complicated. Organizations have so many competing pressures – customers, shareholders, regulators, competitors, colleagues, society – that it can be hard to stay focused. Many choose to focus on experiences that will lead to short-term profits – the 'onboarding journey', new product applications, setting up online self-service – or, worse, on moments the boss has decided are important based on a conversation he had with friends over the weekend. Others find it hard to make any decisions at all, trying to be all things to all people and inevitably not quite managing to be great for anyone.

What's left is an inconsistent experience, better at the start than further into the relationship, with customers left feeling abandoned during the moments that cause them the most stress, worry and angst. Get these moments wrong and the relationship will end there. But give them the right focus and consideration, and the customer may well stay with you for life – and invite all their friends to come along to celebrate, too.

It's the Thought That Counts (Or the importance of being there when customers need help the most)

While I was putting the final touches to this book, my mum passed away after a short illness. I was in a pub nearby when I heard the news, having just ordered some lunch and opened my laptop to type a few more words. As soon as I got the call, I grabbed my stuff and dashed out, mumbling confused apologies to the bar staff about to bring the food to my table.

I'd only been into that pub once before yet the next time I went in, they remembered me. They gave me a free drink, insisted on giving me my money back for the food I didn't get to eat (even though they'd prepared it) and the manager came to my table to offer her condolences.

It's called The Alma in Colchester, Essex, and I recommend you all visit.

These big moments are where the human side of an organization is so important and can be the difference between delighting a customer and causing genuine distress. These are also the moments customers excitedly tell others about, or choose never to deal with a company again.

When organizing the funeral, the florist, caterer and vicar all insisted on only charging half-price as Mum had been a long-standing customer and community member of theirs. Conversely, when contacting companies to close her various accounts, two of them sent feedback surveys to her email address asking how the experience of closing their account was (including a chaser email asking why it hadn't been done) and another, the employee dutifully following her script, wanted a detailed explanation for why the she didn't want to be a customer anymore.

As mentioned earlier in Part One (*see also* page 23), rigid processes and procedures can cause people to shut off their humanity and stop thinking for themselves. While these moments are sometimes predictable, they often have an individual twist to them, requiring a nuanced and empathetic human response.

Mike Hall, former CEO of Standard Life Health, told me a story about one of their customers in the early 2000s who was asked to give feedback following a series of operations. After giving a perfect score, she wrote:

> *'I cannot believe how wonderful this hospital is, so I racked my brain trying to think of something you could improve on and all I could think was the orange juice isn't fresh.'*[67]

[67] Conversation with author, 2021

High NPS score, would recommend, a good result for all involved. Not so, it seems, for the catering manager of that hospital. On hearing about the feedback, he asked for the patient's admissions file to be marked and for him to be notified if ever that patient had to come back for more treatment. Six months later, the patient returned. As she walked into her room, ready to greet her was the catering manager with a glass of freshly squeezed orange juice.

Equally impactful was an email shared on Twitter by Shannon Harwood. She'd ordered balloons for her mum who had just finished chemotherapy and asked for 'Fuck Cancer' to be printed on them.

A couple of days later, she received this reply:

> *Hi Shannon*
>
> *Amazon seller Eighty80LTD has encountered an unexpected problem with your order:*
>
> *Message from seller Eighty80LTD:*
> *Hi Shannon, we have refunded your order because we agree with your balloons! Do not worry, the balloons are still on their way to you. Use the refunded money to get some cake? All the best from Noelle at Eighty80 Ltd*[68]

However, perhaps the most famous story to demonstrate the importance of being there at a big moment comes from the folklore of first direct, the original banking challenger brand. A long-time first direct customer found herself trapped in the second tower of the World Trade Center during the 9/11 terrorist attacks. She knew that if she called first direct a human would pick up straight away, in line with their promise of no complicated phone menus. They answered immediately and she asked them to track down her husband and children and get them on the line (this was before the proliferation

[68] https://twitter.com/shannonhar95/status/1359895521746370560?lang=en

of mobile phones). Between them, they jointly kept her talking, and conscious, for 45 minutes until the emergency services arrived.[69]

I'm not sure you can process map that.

Small But Significant (Or the importance of recognizing the small moments with a big impact)

Not long after the iPhone appeared, I was asked to launch a new mobile app for the bank I was working with. All the competitors were launching award-winning, technologically stunning, visually beautiful apps and we were starting to get left behind. Two colleagues, Phil Hearn and Stephen Hill, had noticed something interesting, though. While these apps were full of clever ways to make large payments, sign-up for new products and geo-locate and tag your spending, it was still quite hard to check your balance. This mattered, because we'd also noticed that 90 per cent of customers only seemed to use the existing online service to check their account balance, then logged off again within seconds.

This would never have made a Top 10 list of moments that mattered, as it didn't make the organization any money and didn't have any significant complaints associated with it. Yet through both the data we saw and the conversations we had with customers, this clearly did matter to customers. Not only was it something they were doing frequently, but the information at hand – how much money they had – would clearly influence a whole lot of seemingly bigger decisions each day so we decided to quickly launch an app that allowed them to easily check their balance – and not much else – aiming to get it live within six weeks.

A lot of people thought this was a ridiculous idea: we were going to offer what essentially amounted to a minimum viable product, providing customers with the most basic level of service. And yet, customers loved it.

[69] https://hbr.org/2012/09/on-911-this-bank-saved-a-life

On the day we launched, we had so many downloads that the server nearly crashed. Within a few weeks it was the number one app in its category in the App Store and it became (I'm told) the most-used mobile app in the industry, with over 6 million balance checks each week in the UK. We could have taken a lot longer to build something that made use of everything that was possible with the technology. Instead, we launched something that gave people the thing they most wanted in a really simple way. It did exactly what they needed it to do, without being cluttered up by a screen full of other things they barely used. It reinforced that the moments that matter don't have to be huge, life-altering experiences. They can be small but significant, cheap to deliver but with a long-lasting impact – and they don't have to be planned, either.

Remember the pub I mentioned at the start of this chapter? I doubt they had a big journey map on the wall detailing the exact steps they should take if a customer runs out of the pub due to receiving some bad news. Similarly, having returned to the office after an early COVID-lockdown, one of my first stops was the Honest Burgers opposite our building, a place that had become a regular haunt for our team since moving in a few years before. We ordered food to take out, had a nice chat with the serving staff while we waited, then brought the food back to the office to eat. As we opened the bag, we found a small, handwritten note inside that simply said:

'Welcome Back! We ♥ You'.

There was something in my eye…

At around the same time, a friend of mine walked into his local Greggs for the first time in nine months. The guy behind the counter greeted him and said, '*Do you want your usual order?*' The server proceeded to perfectly deliver a cappuccino (no chocolate) and a pain au chocolat, the order my friend used to place only once a week pre-COVID. In his words, '*it was the most impressive piece of customer service I've ever witnessed*'.

These small moments don't just have to be moments of high emotion, either. They can be moments that annoy customers, but also are causing financial problems to the organization. For example, with one company I worked with, we realized that their direct debit form was confusing and leading to lots of errors. While it seemed insignificant, when it did go wrong it had a big impact on customers (who missed their payments, fell into arrears and created knock-on issues with their bank) and for the company (who had less money coming in, significant re-work to put things right and new customers who already felt let down).

Sometimes the moments that matter aren't the big, obvious, money-making moments that organizations like to focus on. Instead, they're small, subtle, yet significant. If organizations get these right, there'll be no need to ask customers if they'll recommend you – they'll be doing it every day.

Stand Up and Show Up (Or the importance of owning and resolving customer problems)

'A complaint is a gift!' say people who clearly didn't work in the banking industry during the payment protection insurance (PPI) crisis. A complaint is a gift that's given begrudgingly, thrown across the room at the party, a waste of time and effort for the customer who is so exasperated by the mistakes the company has made that they've had to give up some precious TikTok time to write an angrily worded email. They're an expensive gift to receive too, a bit like when someone gives you a Photo Studio experience day which requires you to then buy one of the photos for £500.

Teams of colleagues are employed to read, research and respond, resolving an issue that hasn't been properly dealt with elsewhere in the organization. Often that resolution involves compensation, money which, if diverted to IT capability or increased call centre capacity, may well stop the complaints happening in the first place.

Like so many of the examples in this book, complaints are not a modern invention. For as long as there have been customers, there have been customer complaints.

In 2015, the British Museum displayed a tablet from 1750 BC, on which is inscribed what is thought to be the oldest-recorded customer complaint.[70] The Babylonian copper merchant Nanni was less than happy with the experience he'd received from Ea-nasir Fine Copper. So unhappy that he sent one of his personal assistants back to the 'store' at least twice – through a warzone – to get a refund.

The book *Letters from Mesopotamia*[71] by Assyriologist A. Leo Oppenheim translates the text in full, including:

> *'I have sent as messengers gentlemen like ourselves to collect the bag with my money (deposited with you) but you have treated me with contempt by sending them back to me empty-handed several times, and that through enemy territory. Is there anyone among the merchants who trade with Telmun who has treated me in this way? You alone treat my messenger with contempt!'*

(It's not recorded as to what score out of 10 Nanni offered or whether he would recommend Ea-nasir to a friend!)

Fast forward to 2010 and I bought a new kitchen from B&Q. They massively screwed it up – I'd recommend you buy yours from there, too. We'd spent months planning it, getting interested in things that 17-year-old me would never have dreamt could be so interesting: granite worktops! Extendable taps! Multicoloured splashbacks! But when the day came to confirm the final order, things didn't go to plan. We'd been planning it for so long that they'd replaced all the styles and

[70] https://www.ancient-origins.net/artifacts-ancient-writings/4000-year-old-ancient-babylonian-tablet-oldest-complaint-020313

[71] Oppenheim, A.L. (1968) *Letters From Mesopotamia*. University of Chicago Press.

changed all of the prices. We were a bit annoyed that our kitchen design manager person hadn't spotted that this might happen.

So, he put it right: he gave us better cupboards, stronger worktops and a tap that extended further than we'd ever thought possible. He made sure the original installation date was kept too. And he did it all for the original price. Within days this fairly disastrous situation was sorted and the kitchen was on its way to us.

Problem owned, explained and resolved.

This matters because, despite being a thorn in the side of business owners for millennia, reducing complaints shouldn't be the aim. Complaint volumes can be – and often are – easily reduced through changes in how complaints are recorded, paying compensation too readily or just making it really difficult to complain in the first place. It's the epitome of focusing on the symptom, not the cause, and can lead to behaviour which seems logically correct, but actually causes more issues.

For example, I once did a study for a client of problem resolution in their 20 markets around the world. The traditional regulatory measures were being given priority in every country: time taken to acknowledge the complaint, time taken to resolve the complaint, compensation paid out. Yet when I spoke to customers, they didn't mind – within reason – how long it took for the problem to be resolved. They wanted to believe it had been investigated fully, to be kept up to date with progress and to know that the issue was unlikely to happen again. Ironically, the focus on complaint reduction and speedy resolution was creating a high number of reopened complaint cases, bringing extra cost to the business and extra frustration to the customer.

Reducing complaints isn't the aim, reducing customer problems is.

* * *

In this chapter, we've explored how a pub in Colchester dealt with a highly sensitive situation, the country-wide impact of building a basic balance-checking app and how a brilliant B&Q employee

averted a potential kitchen nightmare. Of course, many of the moments mentioned here – the kind pub owners, the welcoming burger restaurant, or the efficient Greggs employee – could have been functionally delivered without any human intervention. A retina scan as you walk in, an analysis of your previous orders, an auto-generated greeting alongside your auto-generated order and auto-generated thank-you based on the food you usually have – but it wouldn't have been the same, would it?

That's why the organizations in our Showcase (*see also* pages 43–52) do more than just understand what matters to customers. They use that knowledge to focus on the big make-or-break moments in a customer's relationship with them and the smaller moments that can have a significant impact on customers. They react in the right way in the moments that cannot be predicted or journey mapped, with empowered and empathetic people. And they know that – whether it's a middle-aged management consultant in twenty-first-century London or a Babylonian copper merchant in ancient Mesopotamia – there will be customer problems to resolve and commit to owning them and resolving them fully.

Underpinning this focus is a robust prioritization of effort, considering value to both the business and to the customer, identifying where the company can be different to the alternatives and accepting where they'll be the same as everyone else. This approach is better for customers. It means that – as we saw with my helpful removal company – they know the few moments that are going to have the biggest impact on my customer experience and my life in general. This approach is more efficient for the organization. It stops wasted effort on areas that don't matter so much to customers and often finds small things that have a big impact without the need for huge budgets to deliver. It also allows organizations to sense and react to big moments in society: recessions, pandemics, movements. The times where the world changes and customers need flexibility, they need an organization that understands the importance of the moment and the impact it can have on customers.

Getting it right in the moments that matter – the emotional highs and lows where customers need the most support – is where long-term relationships are formed and a genuine desire to recommend appears. The companies in our showcase do this as a matter of course, not just focusing on the big moments, but also understanding the small, subtle parts of the experience that have a big impact on how people feel.

'We did a lot of research on that first crucial donation and put a subtle system in place to help customers have a good experience. When the donor came through the door, on their chair there was a little red card to indicate to the team that this was a first-time donor and needed more care. They'd spend more time on the questionnaire customers have to fill out with them, check on them more regularly, answering any questions they had to ease their anxiety. We would also contact them after the session to see if there were any problems as we knew that was the moment we were most likely to lose someone.'

NHSBT

'We trained drivers in the fact that the experience is won and lost in the first 0.1 seconds of when the door is opened. And it's so simple to amaze people in that time – just smile. But if you're having a shit day, it's tough to be chirpy. So we have a programme called "setting the driver up for success". We do things like having nice uniforms, not the cheapest. The driver opens the van doors, it's already been packed in the right order for your deliveries, with room for returns. We make sure they have bottles of water to take on their drive.'

AO.com

'We did this thing called a Family Dinner every Friday night, where everybody jumps on a Slack and we debrief from different departments.

We asked, "What's the complaint you've heard the most today?" and someone replied, "Our bloody hold music." We were using generic hold music at the time, so we started throwing around ideas for fun solutions. Because we extend credit, we have people's date of birth and we thought, "Wouldn't it be nice if we could play something that would make you a little bit nostalgic?" We found an article where a data scientist had done some research and we found that when you're 14, you get this first awakening of music. Now people pick up the phone, they get the song that was number one in the charts when they were 14 – and maybe they're just a little bit happier than when they started the call.'

Octopus Energy

'Our Citymapper Mobility Index was a crazy two-week period, but it really, really mattered that we caught the moment where the world was looking for answers. It mattered that we did it, and that we were the first, having that drive to do something.'

Citymapper

'We had a travelling "field kitchen" that was great fun. We built a yurt from trees on the farm, took some chefs with us, and took it round the country. It cost a lot of money but had an amazing reaction. It was a very human experience. There were two yurts, a hundred people, and this hubbub of noise, real humanity. If you give people authentic experiences that are hard to replicate, they'll talk about you. If you just copy everyone else, people see through it.'

Riverford

'Many of our customers are on the frontlines of this pandemic. Their staff care for patients, stock shelves, deliver groceries, look for a vaccine, and keep the backbone of our society functioning while we weather this storm. Supporting their people as they help all of us get through this is critical.

As they adapt their processes, they need to quickly understand how the Workday system can help. We've increased our engagement to help them, through efforts such as adding more office hours and making them free, which gives customers access to extra consulting when they need it most. In addition, for our healthcare customers, we've added specific reports they needed for better data on staff, devices, material, and equipment to help them take care of patients.[72]

Workday

Focusing on the moments that matter means:

- being brilliant in the high-impact moments;
- knowing the small moments that mean something;
- taking ownership when the customer has a problem.

[72] https://diginomica.com/business-unusual-staying-customer-centric-crisis

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Perspective

'I find it hard to believe the ways some companies treat their customers. You can't get hold of them. It's so difficult to get hold of them. They expect you to ring up then wait forever to speak to someone. They'll do anything to reduce their transactional cost, but it's such short-term thinking. Yes, you can make more money in the short term but you'll threaten your long-term viability.'

Riverford

Having a broad perspective means:

- understanding the things that will always matter;
- taking inspiration from outside your industry;
- believing happy customers will lead to commercial success.

We started this book with the myth of customer feedback and learned how seeing the world from the inside-out is an inescapable trap for even the most customer-focused of colleagues. As Charlie Dawson and Seán Meehan bring to life in their 2021 book, *The Customer Copernicus*, this force is like gravity, pulling you back into an inside-out view of the world, something that needs to be constantly challenged.

As humans, and organizations, we work incredibly hard to reinforce and maintain our view of the world. I've no doubt you'll have seen the Blue Marble photo, taken by the crew of the *Apollo 17* spacecraft in

1972. It's the first photograph taken of the whole round Earth and one of the most reproduced photos in history.

Interestingly though, the photo we've all seen a hundred times isn't the photo that was taken. The camera was held by a weightless astronaut who took the photo 'upside-down', with the South Pole at the top of the photo. It didn't matter too much to him as in Space the idea of 'top' and 'bottom' makes little difference. Yet when Nasa first published the photo, they were worried about confusing people, so turned it around to make sure it matched our expectations and existing perceptions.[73]

It's a nice reminder that not only do we all see the world from where we stand – our perspectives shaped by the beliefs that have been handed down to us, and the people and places that are closest to us – but we're built to find reinforcement of our existing views. This narrow, inside-out perspective makes it incredibly challenging to consistently create a human customer experience. Instead, it creates organizations focused on their own short-term objectives rather than long-term customer success, seeing new technology as a shortcut to satisfaction and cost-saving, forgetting what really matters to customers.

It creates organizations that believe their customers want the same experience they would want, reframing what they're hearing to fit existing plans or a pre-installed view of the world, overplaying their role in their customer's lives. It also creates organizations surrounded by competitors and regulation, satisfied to just keep up with the rest of the industry rather than trailblazing on their customers' behalf, too busy to get their heads up and be inspired. And it creates a constantly reinforcing belief that the way things have always been done is the way they should always be done. Until one day – as Woolworths, Blockbuster and Toys R Us experienced – it becomes painfully evident that they shouldn't.

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[73] https://www.theatlantic.com/technology/archive/2011/04/the-blue-marble-shot-our-first-complete-photograph-of-earth/237167/

Everything Changes But You (Or the importance of understanding the things that will always matter)

I bought an Apple Watch. This isn't a controversial thing to say as I sit here writing in 2021, but back in 2015 – shortly after it was launched with typical Cupertino fanfare – it wasn't a popular decision. Angry Apple-fanboy forums cranked into life to criticize the new device. The battery life was too short; the apps were too slow. Siri was…. well, Siri. Despite all that, I rather liked it. It helped me to track my fitness, set timers when I was cooking, and made me feel like someone from Wakanda when I bought a sandwich in M&S.

It did have one big problem though – it wasn't great at telling the time.

To prolong battery life, the face of the Apple Watch was usually switched off. In the adverts, the disgustingly good-looking sun-kissed Californian subtly flicks his wrist, the screen lights up and the time appears.

So far, so good.

That's not what happened in Essex. Not on the first flick. Or the second, or third. By this time, the other people in the meeting had stopped talking and were just staring. Less Wakanda, more Wallace & Gromit.

Despite having more data on how people live and behave than at any other time in history, it's never been easier for companies to lose sight of the things that really matter to their customers. Partly, this is because as soon as companies find the insight that supports the view they want supported, they stop looking. And it's partly down to the obsessive attention given to social media, leading to the overweighting of opinions of the outraged and the techno dazzled. This causes companies to miss or forget about the consistent, necessary and often unexciting things that form the backbone of their offering. The things that matter to customers have always mattered to them and probably always will.

Morgan Housel of Collaborative Fund describes these as 'Permanent Assumptions':

> *'Some things are always changing and can't be known. There can also be a handful of things you have unshakable faith in – your permanent assumptions.*[74]

Amazon understand this better than anyone. Whatever they sell, however they sell it, whoever they sell it to, three things never change – it's well priced, it's in stock and it's delivered fast. The importance of these things has never changed, whether internet shopping, mail-order shopping or even high street shopping.

Amazon founder Jeff Bezos said of this:

> *'You can build a business strategy around the things that are stable in time. It's impossible to imagine a future 10 years from now where a customer comes up and says, "Jeff, I love Amazon, I just wish the prices were a little higher." Or, "I love Amazon, I just wish you'd deliver a little slower." Impossible.*[75]
>
> *'So we know the energy we put into these things today will still be paying off dividends 10 years from now. When you have something you know is true, you can afford to put a lot of energy into it.'*

These permanent assumptions exist in every industry. For example, while it's great for planes to have free Wi-Fi, customers will go elsewhere if the planes always land two hours late – they have to get customers to their destination safely and on time. Banks can turn their branches into coffee shops and play live music by the ATMs, but if their debit cards stop working then none of that matters – they have to keep

[74] https://www.collaborativefund.com/blog/permanent-assumptions/
[75] https://www.collaborativefund.com/blog/permanent-assumptions/

customers' money safe and secure. Insurance companies can give away thousands of branded soft toys to their loyalty scheme members, but if they're not able to help when the pipe bursts, their reputation will suffer – they have to help customers if something goes wrong.

Unless customers' core needs are met, everything else is insignificant. That's why those endless lists of 'things that a mobile phone has killed' are misguided. The phone hasn't killed the camera, the calendar or the TV. It has simply offered a new way for customers to access the things they've always wanted to access: to capture memories, to plan your day, to be entertained.

Even the most-used smartphone apps are just new ways to deliver the things that have always been the basis of human life. WhatsApp and Telegram are about connecting with people. Google Maps is about knowing where you're going. Twitter to stay up to date with what's happening in your community. YouTube, Instagram and TikTok relieve boredom and allow people to project their status.

Organizations spend vast amounts of time and money designing The Next Big Thing, with over-excited CIOs persuaded to build something because the technology suddenly exists to do so, rather than because it's going to be genuinely useful to customers. Not only is this costly for businesses but it's also rather annoying for customers to see shiny new offers launched when it still takes them 20 minutes to get through to someone on the phone. So, when it comes to understanding what really matters to people, a good place to start is with the things that have always, and probably always will, matter to humans: people they can trust, products that are useful and problems to be dealt with.

The safety, the information, the connections…

And a watch that tells you the time.

Doubling the Dots
(Or the importance of taking inspiration from outside your industry)

About 15 years ago, I heard the most ridiculous idea I've ever come across. A man I hadn't met before (and haven't seen since) trapped me

in a corner at a house party to give me an enthusiastic and over-detailed explanation of his million-pound-making innovation. I figured the best approach would be to listen, smile, nod politely, then make my excuses and escape towards the buffet.

He claimed he'd invented a new form of transport: a multi-person taxi-bike, capable of holding up to eight people. This taxi-bike would be available for hire to groups who wanted to get from A to B but didn't want to order a normal taxi. He believed people would choose this because a) they like being in the fresh air, b) they would be able to access the network of special bike-taxi lanes that were going to be built right across the city and c) because they would prefer the relaxed bike ride to a rushed Underground train. It could even fold up for overnight storage.

I couldn't bring myself to lie and tell him it was a good idea. What if it rained? How often would a group of eight people need to get from A to B together, but not be in a rush and so have plenty of time to cycle? What if they weren't all physically fit? And if there were only four of them, could they still use it or would the effort become too great? Is this transport exclusively for groups of eight a pretty niche market? Why on earth would the council permit these things on the road at all, let alone build them special lanes? (I had no complaints about the overnight storage – that was smart.) Having delivered my damning verdict, I wandered over to grab a few vol-au-vents and thought no more about it.

A few years later, I was on a weekend away in Amsterdam. As I stepped outside one of the bars, I stood open-mouthed at the sight coming (slowly) towards me: eight blokes, on an eight-seater bike, happily pedalling away – and each holding a beer. For a second, I presumed I'd just been in a different type of Amsterdam bar, but the reality was confirmed when I nearly got run over.

The brilliant writer Steven Johnson once said that '*the trick to having good ideas is not to sit around in glorious isolation and try to think big thoughts. The trick is to get more parts on the table*.'[76] When I first heard

[76] Johnson, S. (2011) *Where Good Ideas Come from: The Natural History of Innovation*. Penguin.

about the taxi-bike idea, I was thinking in glorious isolation. I compared the idea to existing forms of transport, finding all the reasons it was worse and all the reasons why it wouldn't work. Whoever came up with the beer-bike idea (and I hope it was the person I met) had more parts on their table. They were thinking about people who want new experiences. They were thinking about people visiting new cities and how you must choose between drinking in a dark dingy pub or being a sight-seeing tourist. They were thinking about stag and hen dos who want to drink but suffer from the (admittedly useful) 'dry time' in taxis, en route from one venue to another. How good would it be if you could see the city, move locations, drink and have a fun experience all at the same time?

They were thinking about the fun that humans could have with this, not the problems the local council would find with this.

Real creativity comes from making connections, throwing together the obvious with the not-so-obvious and seeing what interesting things emerge. This means understanding what really matters to people but it also means being alive to what's happening in other companies, industries and countries, from athletics to zoology, gathering ideas and inspiration to design something genuinely pioneering, not a slightly-above-average add on.

In his book, Dr Christian Busch calls this '*The Serendipity Mindset*': being alive to unexpected encounters, keeping an eye out for the improbable, seeing what others don't, broadening your worldview. He recalls famous experiments conducted by Dr Richard Wiseman from his book, *The Luck Factor*[77]. In one such experiment, Wiseman instructed the participants to go over the road and buy a coffee. Outside the coffee shop, he had placed a crisp five-pound note and inside, an actor playing a successful businessman at the counter.

The participants who self-described as 'lucky' were far more likely to spot the money, strike up a conversation with the businessman and exchange business cards. Those who self-described as 'unlucky' were

[77] Wiseman, R. (2004) *The Luck Factor*. Cornerstone.

far more likely to walk past the five-pound note, order their drink quietly and avoid any conversation with others. So, take out your headphones, turn off your laptops and head to the nearest house party. Who knows what ideas might be waiting to be discovered by the buffet?

One Step Back, Two Steps Forward (Or the importance of looking to the past to help shape the future)

In 1899, a group of artists in France led by Jean-Marc Côté put pen to paper and drew the future.[78] Originally for cigarette boxes, then postcards, the drawings imagined what life would be like in the year 2000.

Of course, as with most predictions of the far future, they were quite wide of the mark. To the best of my knowledge, we don't have whale-buses taking us diving underwater, flying police officers arresting us for dangerously flying our cars, or made-to-measure instant suit-making machines – which is a shame.

But some of their ideas weren't so crazy:

Post being delivered by a flying postman.

A robot with wheels attached scrubbing the floor.

Farmers with a remote-controlled combine harvester.

A hundred years later, and drones, Roombas and GPS-enabled John Deere tractors are commonplace around the world.

As we discussed earlier in this book, the things that really matter to people tend not to change that much. It was a pretty safe bet for the artists that in the year 2000, just as in 1899, people would still need things delivered, still want a clean and tidy house and still have an appetite for food that would require efficient farming. But more than

[78] https://publicdomainreview.org/collection/a-19th-century-vision-of-the-year-2000

that, looking to the past can help to reveal ideas that can be begged, borrowed and built upon. As the American writer Mark Twain said in his autobiography:

> *'There is no such thing as a new idea. It is impossible. We simply take a lot of old ideas and put them into a sort of mental kaleidoscope. We give them a turn and they make new and curious combinations.'*[79]

History repeats itself, so when looking to design for the future, a good place to start for innovation inspiration is in the past. For example, despite all the time and money spent in the past few years on companies trying to perfect their pithy three-word purpose, I've yet to find a simpler, more articulate description of an organization's aim than that provided by Pugh Brothers of Holloway in the 1950s – 'Service, Quality, Price'. Alongside it came a fairly superb brand promise which closely echoes John Lewis' famous *'Never Knowingly Undersold'* promise, around since 1925:

> *'The goods which you have bought today are the best value for money that can be obtained. If you have any cause for complaint in regard to Goods or Service, we shall consider it a favour if you will tell us. Our aim is a satisfied customer.'*

Content marketing is another not-so-new idea. In the 1980s, Midland Bank produced a cassette for people planning their retirement and an original Money Saving Expert guidebook to help women with money, presented by the soap-star influencers of the day. While hopefully the somewhat patronizing tone of the book is something that has changed in the intervening years, the need to make money a less male-focused industry remains.

[79] Twain, M. (1924) *Autobiography*. Harpers & Brothers.

(In the 1990s, Midland Bank stole a march on Spotify and released their own mixtape CD. While the reason for this isn't entirely clear, Halifax also released their own CD around the same time, so it seems it was the exciting marketing method of the day.)

Even the newest and most exciting products and services we rush to buy have been here before. Take Sainsbury's announcement in 2019 of a new Partnership with Deliveroo.[80] Useful? Absolutely. Unprecedented? Not so much, given they'd originally offered delivery-by-bike over 130 years before.[81]

Then there's the electric scooter craze of the 2020s, so cutting edge it caught traffic officers and city lawmakers by surprise. It really shouldn't have, given the U.S. Postal Service tested the new Autoped electric scooters over 100 years before.[82] (These vehicles were also popular with New York gangs and Suffragettes in London, ideal for racing down alleys to escape the chasing police cars.)

Uber is just a taxi service (in 1635, the Hackney Carriage Act was the first legislation passed that controlled horse-drawn carriages for hire in England).[83] Airbnb is just giving people a place to stay. (In Roman times, lodgings were built next to the thermal baths and on the routes popular among the government officials.)[84] Deliveroo is just providing good food, fast. (Excavations in Pompeii have discovered Theropoliums, proto-restaurants that served up ready-made hot food to the Roman lower-classes who didn't have their own kitchens.)[85] So what is it that customers want now, and how was that need met 10 years ago? One hundred years ago? A thousand years ago? What worked, what didn't and what can we learn?

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[80] https://www.about.sainsburys.co.uk/news/latest-news/2019/22072019-sainsburys-saddles-up-with-deliveroo

[81] https://www.independent.co.uk/news/business/news/sainsburys-delivery-one-hour-online-food-shopping-bikes-a7330906.html

[82] https://www.smithsonianmag.com/history/motorized-scooter-boom-hit-century-dockless-scooters-180971989/

[83] https://www.thoughtco.com/hailing-history-of-the-taxi-1992541

[84] https://www.hospitalitynet.org/opinion/4017990.html

[85] https://www.theskinny.co.uk/food-and-drink/features/delivery-history-deliveroo

Sometimes, taking one step back for inspiration can help you take two steps forward in innovation, delivering the experience that customers want now and helping prepare for the experience they'll want in the future. As bestselling author Nir Eyal once said:

> *'People don't want something truly new. They just want the familiar done differently.'*[86]

* * *

In this chapter we've heard stories of a watch that doesn't tell the time, an awkward house party encounter with an amateur inventor and tales of flying French postmen, cassette-based content marketing and Airbnbs in Ancient Rome. What's needed is a broader, and perhaps less arrogant, perspective on the world. One that accepts other companies and industries might have ideas worth looking at. One that understands that, despite the prevailing narrative, most things stay the same. And one that can see bad customer experience is expensive to provide, with repeat phone calls, multiple letters and colleagues choosing to leave being stressful for the customer but also costly for the business, too.

This perspective was evident in every company in our Showcase. Each talked about understanding the customer's bigger picture, the outcome they were trying to achieve. Each talked about customer experience not just as a nice-to-have, but as a long-term commercial imperative. And each talked about taking inspiration from elsewhere, displaying a level of confidence for what they'd achieved alongside a genuine humility and desire to learn from others. Interestingly, many talked about time and commitment too. They mentioned the need to see creating a great customer experience as a long-term aim, being both

[86] https://medium.com/behavior-design/people-don-t-want-something-truly-new-they-want-the-familiar-done-differently-fef00fcec0ba

challenging to do and requiring investment before getting reward. It's an ongoing challenge, with ever-changing expectations and a crucial need for consistency.

Without this perspective, many ideas tend to be safe, sticking with the status quo. Of the better ideas that do sneak through, many don't make it past the Post-it, thwarted by poor implementation or risk-averse leadership. And of those ideas that do become reality, many fail fast, the perfect mobile purchasing process designed in an innovation lab no match for the harsh reality of a panicked parent in a car with screaming children trying to book tickets to a museum with one hand while force-feeding said children healthy snacks with the other. (Anonymous famous London museum, I'm looking at you.)

Whether it's a colleague working in a contact centre or an executive board in charge of a global company, context is everything. Being able to step back and see the bigger picture is often what sets apart people and companies that achieve long-term success from those who end up in a short-term spiral of customer complaints and cost-cutting. That's what the companies in our Showcase do.

'[Our product] is an investment. We need to make sure that our customers are living up to the promise they made to their executives. A lot of people bet their careers when they spend significant dollars on a solution, and we need to make that customer look good'… 'Your approach needs to be personalised, you have to understand their industry, be empathetic, understand their specific issues. And focus on outcomes, not just use the applications. How can the applications help them achieve their strategy?'[87]

Workday

[87] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rxh9_leA9gQ

'We take a holistic view across the supply chain, which normally means getting it right the first time is the most profitable way.'

AO.com

CEO Marnie Baker said:[88] *'We have a longstanding purpose: to feed into prosperity, not off it. As a bank we were born out of community, for community, and recent times have just reinforced how important community connections are to all of us.'* Ian Jackman, then Head of Customer Voice, said: '[Our belief is that] *successful customers and successful communities create a successful bank – in that order.'*[89]

Bendigo Bank

'Very early on if I could see something that customers would enjoy but wouldn't give any commercial benefit, I was inclined to do it. We used to grow pumpkins and I got so fed up with it costing more to transport them than we made, I just said, "Come to the farm, we'll give them all away" and gave the money to charity.'

Riverford

'It's a subscription revenue model so it's not just delivering a product and then not thinking about it anymore. It's a continuous partnership with our customers. That's why the relationship with our customers matters so much. We want to make sure they're getting value from our products.'[90]

Workday

[88] https://www.bendigoadelaide.com.au/investor-centre/reporting/2021/2021-results-announcement/

[89] https://home.kpmg/au/en/home/insights/2018/09/customer-experience-bendigo-bank-client-story.html

[90] https://siliconangle.com/2017/10/27/workday-hits-97-customer-satisfaction-thanks-design-partner-programs-ghc17/

'It takes time. The incubation period to get traction is at least three years. But the average tenure of a FTSE CEO is 3.5 years. So they get the upfront pain and not the reward, and probably a lot of pain from shareholders. Understand how hard it is, and how committed you need to be, and be very honest with yourself to whether you are committed to it. Be true to what you want to be. Then be a great version of you, not a half-baked version of somebody else.'

AO.com

Having a broad perspective means:

- understanding the things that will always matter;
- taking inspiration from outside your industry;
- believing happy customers will lead to commercial success.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

Cheat Sheet

If you've made it this far, congratulations! Here's a handy cut-out-and-keep guide. And if you've just skipped to this bit straight away, well, it will save you some money on one of those book-summary apps. Here's what we've covered:

The world is perfecting the functional experience at the expense of the human experience. Organizations are full of humans who aren't allowed to act in a human way. And the best way for companies to increase their efficiency is to make things better for customers.

There are three myths that underpin this lack of humanity in customer experience:

- The Myth of Loyalty – remember that nobody cares about your business as much as you do;
- The Myth of Customer Feedback – remember to start from the thick end of the wedge;
- The Myth of ROI – remember that bad customer experience is expensive to provide.

As a result of people and organizations believing in these myths, an empathetic, systematic approach to customer experience is often replaced by a functional, transactional one. This is characterized by symptoms such as:

- reactively fixing pain points as a customer experience strategy;
- prioritizing customer experience effort primarily by what customers are complaining about, or what the CEO has said is important because of a single complaint they received;

- subscribing to generic frameworks suggesting that all customers want the same outcomes, such as 'personalization' or 'speed';
- building large expensive journey maps that end in a recommendation of 'Transformation';
- obsessing over a single number as a proxy definition of success and measuring everyone in the organization against it;
- Pestering customers for feedback and focusing on averages, not actuals.

Companies that manage to create and provide a human experience are often commercially successful. Those companies have several things in common. They all have:

- a vision of how they want to make life better, in line with what they want to achieve as a business;
- a system that allows them to prioritize, assess, design and monitor their performance for customers;
- Five enablers (*see also* pages 145–214), their ways of working:
    - Ambition
    - Connection
    - Empowerment
    - Focus
    - Perspective.
- Seven behaviours (*see also* pages 53–143), how they act with customers:
    - Accessible
    - Consistent
    - Flexible
    - Proactive
    - Respectful
    - Responsible
    - Straightforward.

Most of all, they have all retained the humanity of the people that make up the organization.

CHAPTER TWENTY

Final Thoughts

One of the best analogies I ever heard about customer experience is that it's like world peace. Everyone agrees it's a great thing to focus on, but no one is ever sure how to do it or whose responsibility it really is, so it tends to be largely ignored until a new boss arrives (UN Secretary-General/CEO) or there's a big problem (threat of war/bad customer complaint featured in a newspaper), at which point it's everyone's priority for a few months until the focus shifts or the crisis is averted and the world/company returns to its previous ways. With that in mind, it's likely if you bought this book, you probably already believe that customer experience is important. You may even already think that giving a more human customer experience is the answer or have your own framework to make things better for customers. However, even if that is the case, I hope the stories in this book have made you smile, perhaps even cringe and nod knowingly, recognizing moments you've experienced and mistakes you or your company may have made.

And you will have made mistakes. No company or person is infallible. I've never met someone who goes to work wanting to do a bad job for customers, yet these things still happen. I've been responsible for plenty of customer experience disasters myself – it's one of the reasons I've tried, where possible, to avoid 'naming and shaming' companies in the stories I've shared. But people also do great things. I'm more convinced than ever that great customer experiences are created by those who genuinely want to create great experiences. Even having the best design approach in the world won't help if the person doing the designing doesn't truly care. Therefore, if nothing else, I hope this book gives you the motivation to keep trailblazing on behalf of customers,

to retain as much humanity as possible in how you understand, design for and deliver to customers.

In bigger businesses, this might mean reconnecting with real people's real lives, influencing large groups of colleagues and encouraging a different perspective on the cost-cutting mentality that is impacting so many customers. In a start-up or smaller business, the challenge might be to retain that special human connection that local companies seem to create, but so often gets lost under a myriad of processes and procedures as they grow, or as the founder moves on.

In both cases, it means using common sense and having a willingness to do the right thing for customers. Organizations are complicated and customer relationships can be difficult, but being human is easy. It's using the consciousness and empathy we all have to feel what an experience may be like to a customer, think about the impact it may have on them and do something to make it as good as it can be.

In fact, just as I was finishing the first draft of this book, an article appeared in the *Guardian* newspaper about the British vacuum cleaner brand Henry, an iconic blend of human and machine. Founder Chris Duncan was sharing the secret of the vacuum cleaner's success, which began at a trade show in Lisbon in the 1970s:

> *"'It was as boring as sin,' he recalls. One evening, Duncan and one of his salesmen idly began to dress up their latest vacuum cleaner, first with a bit of ribbon, then with a union flag badge on what started to look a bit like a hat. They found some chalk and drew a crude smile under the hose outlet, which suddenly looked like a nose, then some eyes. Searching for a nickname that felt suitably British, they settled on Henry. "We put it over in the corner with all the other equipment and the next day people were laughing and pointing," Duncan says. Back at Numatic, which then had a few dozen employees, Duncan asked his advertising guy to design a proper face for the cleaner. "Henry" remained an in-house nickname; the product still had Numatic printed above its eyes.*

'At the next trade show, in Bahrain, nurses from the nearby Aramco oil company hospital asked to buy one for the children's ward, to encourage recovering children to help with the cleaning. "We were getting all these little reports and we thought, there's something in this," Duncan says. He increased production and, in 1981, Numatic added the Henry name to the black lid, which had begun to resemble a bowler hat. Duncan was still focused on the commercial market, but Henry was taking off; they heard that office cleaners were talking to Henry as a way to break up the grind of night shifts. "They took him to heart," Duncan says.'[91]

If in doubt, be human.

[91] https://www.theguardian.com/lifeandstyle/2021/jul/24/how-henry-vacuum-cleaner-became-accidental-design-icon

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